

DEVIL IN THE WATERS

Book Ten



Neto
romanza

KT MORRISON

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

NETOROMANZA

A DEVIL IN THE WATERS Novel

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1

RUINS

Out the hotel window was an Italy he hadn't expected. He'd warned himself not to anticipate too much. Yes, Swanson shipped him to Rome on business, but all of Italy wasn't some rich cultural diorama, wasn't wall-to-wall architectural marvels. There were parts of Italy that looked like Hamilton, thick with smoke and industry.

Yet the view out his hotel window was Instagram Italy, travel channel Rome.

Swanson had booked their executives in the Hilton right by Piazza Navona. Their meetings were nearby. This was ancient Rome. The view showed a building opposite, a baroque framed window staring back, set in chipped limestone, the distance between the two just a narrow channel, a cobblestone street below barely wide enough for one tiny Fiat. But he was close to the main drag, the Via del Plebiscito, midday sun bright and hot and Mediterranean, slanting between the two buildings. From the second floor, he could look down to a busy cafeteria and wine bar, bustling with well-dressed Romans and sloppy tourists. If he looked up and out to the left, it was a sea of flat roofs, distinctly Renaissance Roman. Across the street, before the roof-sea, a palatial block built in the 1300s. He'd visited yesterday, coming home from a meeting, swirled in melancholy. The place had hosted famous Cardinals, even Dante Alighieri one time about 700 years ago. The interior central garden had cheered him up, and he'd sat there for maybe twenty minutes with his face to the sun, blocking out all the thoughts that wanted to crowd him.

Three in the afternoon in Rome, nine in the morning back in Ajax. He had let Meyer sleep in this morning, waiting to call him once he'd gone to work, getting scolded yesterday for calling at six.

Meyer said, “I’m telling you, buddy, you’re crazy. Nothing’s happening here. She goes to work, she comes home.”

Josh sat on the window ledge watching happier people on the street below, home for lunch now on a Wednesday, no more meetings scheduled today. He still wore his suit, but his tie was over the back of a chair. “What about lunch?”

Meyer sighed. “I don’t know, Josh. I’m at work. I can only check on Kimmy when she’s in Ajax. And she’s in Ajax in the morning and she comes home after work. She stays at home, she doesn’t go out.”

He dug the heel of a hand into his orbital and lay back on the bed, looking up at the ceiling. “No visitors?”

“I’m not there the whole time, man, but look, seriously, I’ve watched her two days and I don’t see any sign of anything. You’re totally paranoid. Are you sure?”

Sure Kimmy was cheating.

“I’m sure, Meyer. She knows I know it.” He rested his forehead on the glass, not realizing how feverish and warm he was until the cold of the glass touched his skin.

Meyer waited a beat, soaking in Josh’s assertion Kimmy was cheating on him. “Then what do you need me for?”

He sighed, raised his face, rubbing his chilled forehead.

The pressure was enormous, and without realizing it, he’d offloaded it onto his cousin. No, not offloaded, because he felt no relief, did he? Maybe he did. Or maybe enlisting Meyer was his avenue of targeted destruction, a missile’s trajectory aimed at the love of his miserable life, meant to sink her through exposition. I had to tell Meyer, Kimmy, I had to have someone watch you. What did you expect me to do? You brought this on yourself. . . . You brought this on us.

But what was he supposed to do?

“You know what I want, Meyer. I want it to stop.”

It had been over a week, eleven days now, since he'd found his wife's panties between her boss's couch seats. A ruse. He told himself it was all a ruse. He wouldn't allow any contrary thoughts. Kimmy planted them there for her husband to find. It was part of their game.

But if it were true, Kimmy was impossibly brilliant; a staggering strategist.

“Josh, I... I didn't see her this morning.”

“You weren't going to tell me?”

“She's not like that. I can't believe this. I don't even believe you. I... figured I missed her. Or she's sick today. She came home last night... I saw her come home at a normal time.”

For a week now he and Kimmy had been distant and quiet. Anything she might say could dispel his comforting artifice. He didn't want to talk. Talk about anything. He wouldn't spend time with her. It was a relief he'd had to travel to Rome.

He said, “Maybe she didn't go in today.”

“Why don't you just call her?”

And do what, Meyer? Talk to her?

“Maybe I will.”

“Listen, if you're sure, you're sure. But if you don't want it to happen again, talk to her. Don't make me follow her and spy. I fucking hate it.”

“I'm sorry, Meyer.”

“I'm doing it because I love you. But I love Kimmy, too.”

“I know. I know.”

Then they made torpid small talk, how was Rome, are you seeing Sophie this weekend, what time are you coming home on Friday kind of shit, the whole while a contemptible loaf stuffed somewhere in his viscera, stifling his breath, stifling his vigor. They said their goodbyes, and he closed the call, knowing he would call Meyer again tomorrow and bother him with more questions. Why did he even want confirmation when he was so happy in this cottony cove of oblivion he'd formed?

What Meyer told him should relieve him. Kimmy goes to work. Kimmy comes home on time. No sign of Devlin.

The reason he'd asked Meyer to spy escaped him. What if Meyer reported something he didn't want to hear?

He set his phone on the round leather-bound side table next to the low double bed. The room was modern yet lavish, but the space small and narrow. It was perfect. Perfect because it was so far and foreign from home. Just what he needed. But it was moments like this one when he wasn't sitting in boring meetings with Radialus, the Italian media company, or hashing out logistics with the rest of the team from Swanson, usually just sitting in the hotel's cafe down at street level, that were the worst. Time to think. Time to mope. Time to... consider. Time to fester.

His travel suitcase sat upright on its wheels in the corner. He unzipped it, put his hand deep into the bottom and fished around for the thing he was looking for.

He'd have a shower. Then he'd go across the street and have something Italian for dinner at the wine bar. Maybe he'd go for another walk. Or he'd stay in, lie on his bed and wait for Thursday morning to happen. He could go out with some of the Swanson people, but as much as it would take his mind off his troubles, he couldn't imagine having to talk to anyone right now.

First, he sat on the bed and opened another button on his shirt. He would have to undress for the shower in stages.

He and Kimmy couldn't go on like this for much longer. One of them would have to do something. Something.

If he told her to quit work at Devlin's what would become of her? And what would that mean?

Why, Josh? Why can't I work there?

She could stay at home again. Make baskets for cats and sell them on Etsy. Brilliant strategist. Brilliant strategist making baskets and wearing cardigans and cooking him dinner. That sounded great for him.

"Oh god," he said in deep misery, even though the thought made him laugh. It was pure surrender. Kimmy was valuable. Josh Waters couldn't afford her. She was too expensive.

Kimmy Chang was too smart for him, too beautiful. Everyone knew it now.

He didn't have what it took to maintain a relationship with a six-foot in heels lawyer making a quarter-mil a year, with a beautiful face, one so perfect his heart ached when he thought of it.

At least no tears came.

That was the weirdest thing about this purgatory, where he denied the obvious truth because admitting it would equal his total destruction: he hadn't cried.

Well, why would he now? Everything was just as it had been. Kimmy had taken their game too far, and they had to stop. They stopped. Problem solved.

He chuckled again, doing it into the scented fabric swatch he'd dredged from the lower depths of his suitcase. He held them out now toward the window, the midday Mediterranean light turning them into a silhouette.

He knew their color even with no light shining on the satiny surface. He held them outstretched by the twin cords that would ride his wife's slender hips. The panties she'd left for him to find in the cushions of his boss's

couch where she knew he would sleep when he stayed over after the ball game.

Or, hear me out, she didn't realize she'd left them there.

He whispered a foul curse, balled them in a fist and pressed it to his forehead, eyes squinted shut. It was clear. Devlin fucked his wife on the couch.

And there was so much more.

He growled in frustration, knowing he should get in the shower, go for a walk, do anything but sit in his hotel room thinking of this.

What he pictured: That night he found the panties, he'd met Devlin at the Updike for a bourbon before the ball game. Devlin had asked him to smell his drink, that there was something off about it. Body smell.

Had he fingered Kimmy and then taunted him with his own wife's smell in front of his friends?

He cursed again, shaking his head, grumbling, his face pinched in a tortured scowl.

Devlin fingered Kimmy. Glenn knew and Rumble knew. They'd all laughed at him, sharing a secret joke at his expense, this loser, this fucking piece of nothing had a cheating wife who spread her legs for the big bad wolf. Kimmy thought so little of her husband she let her boss finger her. Let him fuck her with his giant cock. Everyone knew Devlin had a giant cock. All of them laughing as he smelled Devlin's finger and had said his own bourbon "smelled fantastic." It wasn't the bourbon, you asshole. It was Devlin's finger. Glenn smelled it. Rumble smelled it. They'd smelled Kimmy's pussy. Smelled this loser's beautiful wife's pussy on her boss's fucking finger.

"No, no, no," he said, the psychic pain almost unbearable now, a stronger more sensible part of his brain coming in and shooing away all those

thoughts with a broom like an Italian grandmother, Go on, get outta here, leava my boy alone!

A distraction: eyes up to the ceiling, an uncomfortable awareness came to him. The fast beating of his heart while he considered how others conspired to deliver to him the grandest of all sexual humiliations, had produced a significant erection.

He sighed and hunched forward, resigned to his humiliation and the arousal it provoked. He unzipped and parted his boxer's fly so his dick could poke out. Then, disgusted with himself and the sight of his own penis, he draped the panties over top. The satin felt good. The embroidered flowers scratched. That felt good, too. He gripped his cock with the panties and rubbed, thinking of what might have happened. Thought of Kimmy on Devlin's couch with Devlin's finger—no, two fingers, or even three—plunging in and out of her, making her squishing sounds... Oh, oh no, did she squirt for him? Did his wife spray all over the couch as Devlin finger-blasted her into a wild and shrieking orgasm? And now: Kimmy's long beautiful legs wrapped around Devlin's hips, his huge cock stretching her vagina to its limits and Kimmy raking her nails over his sweaty, muscular back.

And how about this one, Joshy, my boy: Had she already fucked Devlin when they were all together in Cayman? God, could the woman he loved be that evil? Could that thoughtful woman wield such pointed cruelty? Had she and Devlin ever laughed together at his expense, made fun of him behind his back?

Someone knocked on the door and he jumped off the bed, throwing the panties to the corner, hissing the Lord's name in vain as he hopped in place trying to get his fly up without nicking his penis with the zipper teeth. Holy fuck his heart was pounding now. His temples throbbed and his neck ached from the fright.

He paused for a moment, hands on his knees, trying to catch his breath. He'd almost come from those horrible imaginings. What kind of sick and twisted pervert could get off on something so horrible? "Just a minute," he said.

It would be Mark or Harmeet, or maybe even that busybody VP, Kathryn, wanting to meet up later and ruin his evening with a strategy session. Or, fuck, maybe all of them going out to a bar for some team-building karaoke.

He opened his hotel room door.

The woman standing there was familiar to him, but he hadn't seen her in a long time.

She was the last person on earth he wanted to see right now.

2

DISTANCE

Kimmy stood at his hotel room door.

Four-thousand miles from home, across an ocean, a whole other continent. There could be only one reason she was here.

“Oh no,” he croaked, wincing, tortured, falling away from the open door and stumbling into his room, his insides, viscera, heart and soul, all choked by an ache wringing him dry of his already diminished spirit. “Why are you here?”

Behind him, Kimmy’s voice, just a gentle whisper calling his name. The whisper followed him, lashing at his back like the crack of a whip. He spun around, lurching forward, hands clenched in fists, growling at her through clenched teeth. “I said, why are you here?”

Kimmy stepped into the room, still eclipsing her body with the half-open door, shielding her from his anger, her narrow eyes now wide and trembling. “I had to come,” she whispered.

His shaking fists raised above his shoulders, he roared at the ceiling in agony, “Why are you here?” Then the fists hammered down on his thighs and he twisted away from her in torrential rage.

“I missed you,” she cried behind him, her voice rising from a whisper now to a warbled plea. “I missed you, Josh,” she said, her renewed statement breaking into breathy sobs.

He spun around again to face her, his back to the wall next to the sunny window. Kimmy couldn’t come near him. Too afraid. Standing now inside

his room, the door closed, her back to it, hand on the lever, ready to bolt to safety if she had to.

And why?

They stared at each other from across the narrow room, both of them backed against walls. He grimaced and beat the back of his wrist against his forehead, voice thick with heart-wounding, lamenting, “Why— why did you have to come here?”

Kimmy covered her mouth with both hands, her eyes glistening wet, flooding, tears spilling her cheeks. She could barely form words, her voice a tightened squeak. “I missed— I missed you so m-much.”

“Aw, Kimmy,” he cried, and beat his thigh with another fist, then recoiled, pivoting to the side, staggering past the window, wishing his room had another exit so he could run far, far away from what his wife’s presence meant.

Kimmy called his name again, coming deeper into his room.

The panties that had betrayed her lay in a crumpled ball in the corner where he’d thrown them, and he lunged for them, snatching them up from the floor before Kimmy saw them, before the panties revealed to her his own shame. He faced her, the panties clutched to his stomach. Kimmy stood at the foot of his bed, only a half-dozen feet away. Her hands were open, reaching to him, wanting him to come to her because she was afraid of what he might do if she went nearer to him. Tears narrowed her black eyes, head cocked at a pleading angle as her pouting lips mouthed the word, “Please.”

He raised his fist toward her and opened it. Showed her what he hid. Her balled panties unfurled to drape over his held out palm.

When Kimmy saw them she buckled and howled in silent pain, folding in two with both hands between her knees. He stepped toward her again. “Why, Kimmy? Why did you come here?”

Still hunched over, she said, “I missed you, Josh. I missed you so much.”

Slowly, she stood upright before him, face to face and close, crying, wiping at her cheeks with hands half hidden in the sleeves of her cotton sweater.

The woman revealed to him when he'd opened his hotel door wasn't the Kimmy Chang he'd left at home. Not six-feet tall in expensive heels, not with black-lined eyes and blood-painted lips. Not with the superior stare of a woman born with cold dragon's blood.

This Kimmy looked like the woman he'd married. No heels, only canvas lace-ups. Cotton pants, cotton sweater. Her hair wasn't slicked back in a high-gloss bun, revealing the sharp angles of her jaw, her long swan-like neck. Now her hair was clean but tousled, framing her angelic face in waves. She wore no makeup. She looked like she did when she was in high school. She looked how she did when he fell in love with her.

He shoved the panties into her face, making her recoil. But she stood her ground, leaning away, features pinched, eyes closed, snuffling for breath as he mushed them into her mouth and nose.

He insisted on knowing: "Why, why?"

Kimmy's shoulders shook with her crying.

He let the panties go and they fell to her chest, stuck on her sweater's fabric for a moment before tumbling to the hotel room floor.

"There's only one reason," he said, his brow heavy with the weight of extreme sorrow, his cheekbones aching with the desire to burst into tears at this revelation.

"No," she whimpered, shaking her head.

"You should have stayed at home. You should have stayed at home, Kimmy."

"I couldn't," she said, unable to make eye contact. Then, a tiny whisper: "Don't leave me, Josh."

“Kimmy, don’t! Don’t say that.” He turned away and put his arms on the wall, hanging his head.

“Josh, please...”

He wheeled to face her, furious she couldn’t see what her arrival meant.

“Kimmy, stop. Please, why? Why, Kimmy?”

She didn’t know what to say, looking up at the ceiling and still crying, her face beaming with hurt. “I don’t know...”

Arms hanging at his sides with the unbearable weight of his dread, he said, “You’re admitting it.”

Their eyes met and more tears streamed from Kimmy’s eyes. Her chin dimpled, her jaw trembled. She wanted to deny it but she couldn’t.

“You just killed me,” he said, his voice quiet.

“No, Josh, no,” she said, her voice rising, taking the place left behind by his diminished volume. She rushed to him, casting her fear aside, grabbing the lapels of his suit jacket. “That’s not it. That’s not it at all.”

He turned his face away, resting the back of his head on the wall.

If she’d stayed at home he could lie to himself more. He could fucking lie to himself more and more and more until he was bubble-wrapped in a fat padding of lies. The doubt, the vacillation, the uncertainty—they all clouded his vision, kept him from seeing. But Kimmy in his hotel room all the way in Rome was 20/20, 8K Cinemascope, crystal clear, high illumination.

He armed her away, broke her grip from his jacket and stepped away, showed her his back, turning to look out the window. Down on that cobblestone street below, people with better lives came and went with coffee, wine, pastries, and smiles on their faces.

In his periphery he could see Kimmy’s head bow, her neck emitting a teeny click. The tension deflated from the moment and she turned away, too.

When her footsteps receded he said, “Don’t go.” The footsteps stopped. She should go. She should get out of his life.

“I hate being without you,” she said toward the door.

He turned from the window to regard her standing near the door, shoulders slumped, head down.

For a brief second he wanted to hug her, but then pure heartache gripped him again, and his features pinched into a harrowed mask. “You should have stayed at home.”

She nodded, her shaggy black hair shaking.

He could never, ever trust her. She was here because she was guilty and if for a second he wanted to feel sympathy or some angle on happiness, all he had to do was consider his cousin Meyer was probably the world’s worst private detective and Kimmy had spotted him. Now she was here to convince stupid Josh she was a good and loving human being.

Only: what would Kimmy gain by coming here for that reason?

“I’ll go,” she said.

“Because you’re guilty?”

She stayed where she was, still facing the door.

“If you hid those fucking panties for me to find, then why are you here?”

“I told you I missed you.”

“I left on Sunday and it’s Wednesday.”

“We hardly talked last week. You didn’t want to stay in the same room with me. If I’d come in, you would go out. You stayed late at work every night. . . . You only called me on Monday to say you were here.”

She'd sown distrust, she'd sown his field with the bitter seeds of betrayal. But he wouldn't say it. He would never say it out loud. If the words were spoken, if the words mixed with oxygen, they'd ignite, they'd burst into a fireball of total devastation, of self-immolation and utter exothermic ruin.

"I would have called tonight," he muttered.

Kimmy turned and faced him, her face a mess, streaked with tears, features wounded by hurt, her eyes filled with pain, but she raised her chin, and though her words were weak and shaky, she said, "I never sh-should've hidden my underwear for y-you to f-find."

Then they stared at each other for the longest time, not saying anything, Kimmy like a soldier at attention on a sweltering day, held upright by marionette strings, ready to crumple at any second. Such a lie. Such an obvious lie. Lying would be the only thing that would keep him alive, keep him walking, keep him breathing.

He turned away from her and looked out the window again, this time across the Renaissance sea.

"Josh, please..."

He chewed on his lower lip, trying to push away all the thoughts that wanted to jump him in the dark and kick the living shit out of him. "Everything was easier when you were home."

A moment of silence, then: "I can leave."

He shook his head, mouth a slim and firm line, his brow troubled lowered.

Again: "Josh, please..."

He turned, knowing this would be the moment he crumbled and fell to his knees, melting into a sobbing puddle. But nothing happened. No emotions came. He regarded Kimmy, his beautiful, smart, funny wife, best friend and companion, almost the mother of his child. A woman he'd loved. And felt nothing. No rage, no hate... no love. "I'm empty, Kimmy."

Now it was Kimmy crumbling, looking to the heavens above the room's high ceiling, new tears spilling, hands going between her knees, head falling forward. She emitted a tortured wail but choked it off, reducing it to quiet sobs.

He closed the distance, stood an arm's breadth away, watching her skinny back heave for breath, finally feeling something. But feeling it for a woman he used to know. He didn't want that woman to cry. He put out his hand like he would rest it on her back to calm her, but closed the hand and returned it to his side.

He turned and dropped to sit on the foot of the bed, hunched over and watching her cry. Tears dropped from under her black hair, twinkled in the sunlight before they fell to the carpet and melted away.

At last he touched her arm. She swayed toward him, not knowing where he was, staggering and tumbling onto her side in his lap, where he folded his arms around her shoulders and held her while she hid her face away.

3

PLEAS

The suit brought her to Italy. She told him about it.

“You didn’t bring the suit I bought you. I saw it in the closet.” Josh said nothing.

They lay on the bed together, both facing the same direction. She stared at his back. He’d removed his suit jacket after he’d held her while she cried, wearing his white dress shirt and suit pants now. The sunlight had crept down the wall outside the window, the angle lowering, the color deepening. Traffic was quiet. She rubbed her face and stared at the too-close-to-focus bedding for a long while, her mouth working around with nervous tension.

After a while she said, “That was the hardest part about you being gone.” The suit.

Nothing. No movement. She knew if she peeked around his shoulder she would find him awake, eyes open and staring at nothing, hearing her but unresponsive. His back moved with his slow breathing.

How could she explain it? The sight of the beautiful tailored suit she’d bought Josh—left behind and hanging in the closet in its protective bag—amplified tenfold the notion Josh had abandoned her. She was the suit in the closet. Left behind and forgotten. But no, not forgotten. Unwanted. Unneeded. Forsaken.

To explain it would illuminate the reason she would feel such worry, such shame. Guilt. Further admission of her devastating crimes.

By now it was clear: Josh knew she didn't hide her underwear in Devlin's couch. Josh knew it but didn't want it to be true and had blinded himself to the truth. Deafened himself to it. He'd thought it was all a game and that's where he wanted his existence to remain.

And now he'd gone mute, as well.

Josh's wounding was so grave he couldn't acknowledge the truth. If he did, the shards she'd broken him into would cleave away and shatter on the floor. Her eyes went wet again, and her face scrunched as she began crying once more. All she wanted to do was touch his back—but his possible reaction scared her out of trying.

This time Josh didn't comfort her. Didn't hold her while the tears flowed.

She said, "I can't be without you."

Still nothing. She rubbed her cheek on the bed, drying her eyes, her heart wedged high in her throat. "I had to come, Josh. I'm sorry I had to come." Her voice was a thick whisper now.

When he still said nothing, she craned her neck up toward the pillows—they were nearer the bed's bottom, both of them wearing their shoes with their feet hanging off the foot of the bed—and regarded the black and white photograph of some Roman sculpture, maybe Zeus.

"Will you talk to me?"

Josh said nothing and she was sure he wouldn't. She would return to the airport and go home and suffer in their apartment, hoping the man she loved would return from Rome to her. But knowing that was impossible. Why was she even here? She didn't think it was selfish, but Josh's reaction proved she was.

Then Josh spoke, his voice flat and lifeless. "What do you want to hear?"

That you still love me. That you don't hate me.

"I want to hear your voice."

Josh shifted to get more comfortable but didn't roll over. He said nothing.

"If I touch you are you going to m-move away?"

Josh shook his head, then rubbed his brow, sounding troubled.

Her hand went out but stayed an inch from his back, afraid he would recoil at her touch, afraid he would spin around and tell her to go. Hearing him tell her she should never have come broke her heart. As her shoulder began to ache from holding her arm out and aloft, she held her breath and allowed her hand to come in slow and hesitating contact with Josh's back. Even to her, her touch felt disingenuous, conniving. How would Josh feel?



The lost time in Cayman. That's what he thought about, staring at the blank wall. Sitting at the villa and awaiting her return. And Devlin's photo of Kimmy standing in his Cayman hotel room. That's where it had happened. Whatever happened, that's where it started. He knew it. Devlin fucking told him by showing his friends a picture of Josh's wife when they were all in the private room at the strip club. All of them making fun of Josh, all of them knowing their good buddy Devlin had even fingered this man's wife earlier in the day and taunted this dipshit husband—to their delight—by making him smell his wife's pussy on his fingers. What a fucking joke he was. What a fucking dupe.

Three men making fun of a boy.

A boy who pretended to have a woman.

Kimmy touched his back and his skin crawled. Now he comprehended her bewitchment.

But her fingertips pressing his back, the warmth of her touch were welcome. A surprise. Something changed in him when he felt her touch. His heart throbbed; an ardor bloomed in his chest. Not for her. For himself. An empty sort of manifestation only meant to show him what he deserved. He deserved love. He deserved honesty. He deserved truth and fidelity.

But what had he got?

Whenever he tried to face it, it wasn't there, like whipping around knowing your stalker had crept up behind you with a knife raised above to plunge in your back... And only finding an empty road, clouded with fog and a ghost of laughter.

With nothing behind him, he could only look inward. Pin some blame on himself. Had he pushed Kimmy into it? Had he made her think that's what he wanted? Were his own perversions at fault? How much blame did he deserve? The male part of him shouted: None! Fuck that, you bitch, this voice said, she's a cunt! But it was too easy to think like that. That was neanderthal shit. Knuckle dragger shit. That was Rumble talking. Josh Waters was a sophisticate. Or a chump.

Since he hadn't shrugged away Kimmy's touch, her hand roamed, smoothing up to his neck, over his shoulder, her slender fingers gripping his upper arm and holding him. Great. Her left hand. Her fucking left hand with his ring on it.

He folded his right arm trapped underneath him, across his chest and held only the ends of her middle three fingers. With that gesture Kimmy scooted closer.

It was too much. He abandoned the bed, getting up and walking to the window, leaving her alone to hug herself and hide her face away.

He said toward the window, "I think it's better if I'm alone right now."

Kimmy sniffled, rubbing her face. She sat up on the end of the bed. "I can get a different room," she said.

“You could, but...”

“Who are you here with?”

He turned around and put his back to the wall beside the window, the glowing light falling on Kimmy’s legs and feet. “Not anyone you know,” he said. “Not the people I work with. Harmeet’s here, but you don’t really...”

She looked up, a little hopeful. “I like Harmeet.”

“Yeah, but it’s not the same. He’s my boss. This isn’t...”

Kimmy looked down, her face sullen. What did she think, this could turn into a fun time, that all the Swanson gang and her could go out for drinks?

Very quiet, she said, “We could have dinner tomorrow. Just you and me.”

“I really have to concentrate. This is a big deal for me. I have to be on top of my game. I don’t want to be distracted.” He sighed and shook his head, looked aside to the window out across the terra cotta roofs. “Especially if we’re down to one income.”

Kimmy said nothing as he lost himself in that easygoing outside world, thinking of times he’d dreamed of traveling across Europe, of having a girl at his side, thoughts he ached for back before he had Kimmy. Then something occurred to him and he looked over to Kimmy. “We’re not down to one income?”



She didn’t know what to say, didn’t want to explode what might be substantial progress here. “I didn’t... We can...”

Josh’s brow lowered into a puzzled line. “How are you here, then? You just didn’t go in, you didn’t quit?”

“I... It’s...” She stopped talking, sighing, putting her hands on her knees and squeezing. She waited a beat before looking up to meet Josh’s eyes. “If you tell me to quit, I’ll quit, Josh.”

He stared at her with incomprehension. All that she’d built in the last hour crumbling as his jaw sagged and his lips parted. He sighed a profanity, pushed his fist into his brow, shaking his head and grumbling. She hunched over, making herself look as small and frail as she could.

Josh raised a shaking hand formed in a claw, then scrunched it in a fist, his features condensed to frustrated anger. “This is what I mean, Kimmy. Distraction! Now I’m wondering how you didn’t quit. I’m wondering how you didn’t quit last fucking week!”

His voice grew loud and angry and she jumped to stand, going to him. He shied away but didn’t stop her from taking hold of his lapels again. “I’m sorry, Josh, I’ll quit, I’ll quit. Don’t be mad.”

They were close, their mouths only inches apart. But Josh took hold of her wrists and loosened her grip, pushing her hands away.

He wouldn’t look at her, only saying aside, “Can I be alone?”

She folded her rejected hands across her stomach. “Why?”

She’d boxed him in and he had nowhere to go. He wanted to reject her again, wanted to look out the window, or move to the bed, but she’d closed his avenues of escape by sealing him near the end of the long and narrow hotel room. She backed away, gave him space.

Josh stepped past her and across the room, and she could sense his anxiety lessening as he fled from her. Just a few feet away and he was already clearheaded. Back to her, he put his hands on his hips, head bowed as he tried to gather his thoughts. She let him keep his space and stayed where she was.

At last, he said, “Get another hotel room.”

She gasped a silent sound, her spine going buttery for half a heartbeat. “Okay. Yeah, I will,” she said, sidestepping around him, heading to the door, not wanting to blow whatever it was she’d gained here.

He stopped her at the door, saying, “You shouldn’t have come, Kimmy. But you shouldn’t go. If you go now, it’ll only make it worse.”

She leaned her back on the wall, holding the door lever, rotating her grip on it, knowing she should just go and leave him alone, that would be the better thing, the wisest thing, but she couldn’t stop herself, turning, getting him to face her, saying, “Josh, look at me. Please, look at me.” And when he did, she said, “I’ll do anything to make you happy. Anything.”

BITTER ORANGES

Nothing had gone how she'd thought it would. She'd pictured Josh exploding with emotional joy opening the door to see her standing on the other side, all the way in Italy. Just for him.

Then again, his agonized reaction wasn't inexplicable. While extreme, it wasn't bizarre or out of place. And that's what hurt the most.

Josh at last revealed the pain she'd caused him. All the last week he'd held it in, plastering over his terrible discovery with the thin explanation she'd planted the panties in Devlin's couch for him to find. She didn't think Josh believed that. Now she knew he didn't. Josh didn't believe it, but he wouldn't say it. Saying it would make it realer than he could handle.

But what did Josh know? Nothing. What was it that he believed? Josh would tempt his darker half with the worst thoughts imaginable, but he was a rational man.

So here she was, almost eleven in the morning, sitting on a medieval brick wall with the high Mediterranean sun on her face. She'd wandered the city beginning early in the morning, skipping breakfast so she could clear her head and escape the hotel room that overnight had become a tomb of dreadful worry.

The Giardino degli Aranci was a remote and quiet spot in the otherwise busy city. Not a key attraction for September tourists. An oasis for thought and reflection, which she did, nursing her second cappuccino of the morning, the cooling paper cup held in her fingers between her knees as her gaze lingered to the east from the park's beautiful belvedere, back from

where she'd departed this morning. Josh would be awake and attending meetings by now.

The bend in the Tiber River showed on her left, St. Peter's Basilica on the right. The pruned and nurtured canopy of ancient orange trees towered more than fifty feet overhead, extending behind her in a colonnade lining the park's central footpath avenue. Someone planted the first orange tree in honor of Saint Dominic. The garden began with one orange tree imported from Spain over a thousand years ago. Something small can become something big.

There was an ache in her heart. A lamentation of her unnecessary crimes and the pain they caused. A melancholy. Melancholy, but something larger than only this terrible moment with Josh. The pain she'd caused him rose high in this territory, but it wasn't the whole of her suffering. Something about the belvedere, the calm, the tradition, the link to the past, and even the oranges, summoned something lost, some small flickering something inside her.

Lost time. More meaningful times, connected times where her family was whole; a time of lanterns and paper boats and joss paper and her parents' distant families. All now gone.

The oranges here in this Italian garden were like the ones her father would offer up during the Ghost Festival—though the last time she'd seen him do it was outside the Lungshan Temple in Taiwan, the summer after her mother died.

The lasting impression earned from watching her mother die had been a nihilistic dispossession of faith and magic and the joys and lusts of living. Her mother's dreams had gone unfulfilled. She'd half-raised a family, but never saw the fruits of her caring labor. Instead endured half a decade of suffering. Half a decade of chemo and hair loss and hospital trips and being brave but crying behind the bedroom door. Once a carefree joyful woman, a beautiful woman unpossessed of agonal mortality, descending into sorrow and haggard frailty.

She tossed the coffee cup into the trash bin, her stomach soured. Her hands jittered with unresolved malaise and too much caffeine. She rubbed a thumb into an orbital ridge to push away some building tension.

After Tiffany's party this summer everything she'd dreamed of opened before her like a fairytale book. Pages with gilded edges and hand drawn illustrations, the script in elegant feather pen calligraphy. A life filled with all the delicacies of the world. But they were all temptations, false things that lured her from duty and care. She'd been careless and she couldn't remember why. Maybe just the ills of living in her fatalistic anomie.

Like a fool she'd trudged that fairytale path. A linear modality, and one thick with the dancing lure of temptations always a few steps ahead of her, ensuring her feet were ever moving forward, disregarding the danger of growing darkness.

Hands in the pockets of her cotton pants, she left the belvedere and its stunning view behind, traipsing the avenue underneath the orange tree canopy's cool blue shade. Sleep last night had been small and fitful. Up at five in the morning, not knowing what to do with herself, puttering around the narrow hotel room, four floors above Josh, her room looking to the north. Every item around her life wobbled on its shelf, threatening to crash to the floor and ruin everything. The hidden panties caused the shaking. They were the earthquake that set the ground under her feet into heaving instability.

Devlin played a card she never had anticipated. Never believed he would have the balls to play. So much for poker. This whole time she'd thought it was her who held the upper hand. Devlin showed her it wasn't. He didn't know he wouldn't hold the upper hand for long. Devlin had an enemy now, and he would pay. She would make him pay.

For now she would head back to the hotel to nap in the afternoon before dinner with Josh. Plus she had paperwork and contracts to look over, and she wanted to lie in a hot bath for a while and think some more.



She met Josh at an expensive restaurant on the Via del Plebiscito. They sat at a table for two by a smoky window overlooking the street and the street-side tables. Stone medieval archways separated the rooms, the ceilings were bright tin; silver-painted walls and crystal chandeliers, the floor a harlequin pattern in white and lemon-yellow tiles. The hard surfaces in the old renaissance building made hearing difficult.

She said, “I’m buying, okay?”

Josh still wore a suit. He shrugged, his face grim, looking tired. “I can expense it.”

“Just let me.”

He looked at her, blank. “Fine.”

Nothing about this trip was easy. This man on the other side of the table was her closest ally in life. Her best friend. Her husband. But she’d disregarded that sanctity. Her hands trembled holding the menu. Nervous with Josh like this was a first date. Wanting to make a good impression. Wanting him to like her, think she was pretty, think she was smart and funny. He’d known all those things to be true, and she’d betrayed him.

Josh reached over and fingered down her menu, looking at her with sober eyes. “Before you start talking, before you say something... Don’t apologize. Don’t apologize for anything. You understand why?”

She did. He’d made it clear in his hotel room. She set down the menu, saying, “I won’t.”

“Good,” he said, holding his hands together near his face, looking out to the street. “What are you ordering?”

She said nothing, cupping her cheek, looking down at the floor between their table and the next, feeling heavy yet empty. She looked to Josh and said, “You were right, Josh. I shouldn’t have come here. I was at home and I was heartsick. Heartsick thinking maybe you didn’t want to love me anymore, and I got scared, and I came here.”

Josh closed his eyes. “Kimmy. Don’t...”

“Don’t worry, Josh,” she said. “I won’t say anymore. I had to say that. But I’m done now.”

They perused their menus in silence, her heart racing, her stomach tight. She’d eaten nothing today and she still felt little urge to eat. She decided on the beef tartare with fresh truffle and Josh ordered a beef steak with honey and pistachios.

“Do you want wine?”

Josh shook his head and she passed the menus back to the waiter. She said, “I hope we don’t get kicked out for not ordering wine.”

Josh smirked and it was the first ray of hope since she’d booked the flight here out of Pearson. Her heart ached. Not for herself, but for Josh. She took a deep breath and reached for his hand. He didn’t pull away and her eyes welled like she would cry. She couldn’t help smiling. She pushed her slender fingers into his warm grip and he squeezed them. Their eyes met. She said, “All the games are over. Okay?”

He nodded, his eyes turning down, his lips slimming.

“We never should have played them,” she said, thumbing his knuckles.

He looked up again, his eyes glassy and wet, the whites showing sign of pink. “I never should have asked you to play.”

She shook her head. “We’re not going to talk about it.”

Josh put his head down again, his grip on her hand still firm.

She had to be the strong one. Josh couldn't lead right now. One look at him would tell someone how lost he was. "We're not going to talk about it ever again. You want to know what we're going to do?"

He asked her what, and she showed him the most confident expression she could muster in this awful moment so far from home. "We're going to have this dinner. Then I'm checking out of the hotel and I'm flying back to Toronto. You're going to concentrate on work. You're coming home to me on Friday night—tomorrow night—and we're going to spend the weekend being good to each other."

Josh nodded, silent, his unseeing eyes looking near the middle of the table.

"I'm never going to do anything ever again that might hurt you. Even if you w-want me to, it's too dangerous."

Josh looked up, his eyes wetter than before. A tear spilled from his right eye and he withdrew his hand from hers to wipe his face with the yellow napkin.

She gathered her hands in her lap, her shoulders sagging, wondering how she could ever do anything to hurt such a good man. "Josh, baby..."

He sniffled, blinked his eyes, then wiped them again. He put his elbows on the table and bunched the napkin near his mouth staring at her. She met his eyes and soaked as much pain from him as she could.

At last he set the napkin down, and steadied himself. Then he looked at her again. "Did you, um... Did you and him ever, uh..."

Her lips began to tremble and her chest shuddered.

"Did you and him ever laugh at me? Laugh at me behind my back?"

Her trembling mouth fell open and everything in her dropped away. Her vision blurred with tears and her neck swelled. She began to sob, falling forward, hating the man she loved could think she would do that. She'd done so much worse in her mind, but that's what Josh feared. He feared

she'd humiliated him with a man he hated. A man he warned her about. Faces from nearby tables turned her way and she hid in her napkin, crying into it.

She excused herself from the table, pushing back and clinging to the napkin for safety and security. She headed to the washroom, stopping at Josh and holding his neck, stooping near his ear to whisper the most honest thing she could imagine: "Never, Josh. I love you and I could never do that. Please, don't think that."

QUILLS & BARBS

If she picked Josh up at the airport it would lead to an uncomfortable drive home from Mississauga to Ajax, more than an hour in the car with so much to say and no room to say it. Josh carpooled to the airport with two of the other team members headed to Rome, and he'd left his vehicle at the Swanson lot. He'd ride back with them and drive home to the apartment from work. His flight was due at seven, and he'd be home around eight-thirty. She had a lot to prepare.

Late afternoon on a Friday, back in the office for the first time this week. But now she was packing up and heading home at five o'clock. But as she closed up, Tami knocked on her door, indicating through the glass with her expression something urgent. Kimmy waved for her to come in.

"Devlin's downstairs. He called to say don't let you leave yet."

She couldn't help an aggravated sound and a desperate sigh. She'd almost made it through another week without seeing him. "Did he say what he wanted?"

"No."

"I was almost out the door. Where was he?"

"Pulling into the parking."

Shit. "Fine," yeah."

Tami went back out front to her desk and now Kimmy sat down in her office chair, wishing she had left an hour ago. She slumped in the leather, shaking her head, then brushing her hair back from her face. Gone was that

razor-sharp killer look, coming to work today in a gray suit and flats and her hair shaggy around her face. When the elevator door opened out in the foyer, she got back to packing her shit to take home for the weekend. Outside Devlin paused to talk to Tami. Tami looked over her shoulder to Kimmy, back to Devlin. Then shut off her computer and got her purse. She disappeared then, going around the desk and Devlin, down the hall, Kimmy figuring she would retrieve her things from the fridge and head home under Devlin's instruction. Devlin watched her now through the glass, hands in the pockets of his navy double-breasted suit, his hair slicked back and gleaming.

He stepped forward then, coming to her door, smiling like an asshole. Tami walked behind him to the elevator with her cooler bag slung over her shoulder next to her purse. He came into her office, the door hissing closed behind him. He said nothing, still smiling, dragging the moment out, knowing he deserved to be screamed at, to have her nails scratch his face. He practically dared her to do it with his arrogant demeanor. He looked over, looked her up and down as she put contracts into file folders. He said, "Casual Friday?"

She said nothing now too, continuing to pack up, as he crossed her office to the window wall and admired the view of the city. "I was in Kingston all last week, and you weren't in the office this week. I feel like it's been forever since we talked."

She closed the file folder and snapped the lock. "What's there to say, Devlin? What do you want to hear?"

"Why weren't you at work this week?"

"I worked from home."

He turned from the window, still smirking. "Home?"

"I completed all my tasks. You've never checked up on me before. Why now?"

“I know you weren’t at home, Kimmy. I know where you were. Rome in September, my, my, my. Spectacular.”

She stopped what she was doing and stared at him, hating her gaze even touching him. “Then why ask? Why does everything you do or say have to come with such dramatic flair? I know you know where I was, so don’t try to reveal this knowledge of my whereabouts as if you work for fucking Mossad or something, Devlin. I used my company card in Rome—for necessary incidentals, not for the flight, not for the hotel. And I’m not sneaking away, I wasn’t hiding. There are important things I had to attend to. You of all people know that. What do you have to say about it?”

His smirk widened to a teasing smile. “Did you have a good trip?”

She went back to packing. “It was wonderful.”

“Did you see the colosseum?”

“No.”

“Shame. Beautiful city. I’m sure you saw plenty.”

“I did.”

“And how’s our friend Josh? Doing well, is he?”

At the mention of Josh’s name she bristled, almost lashed out at him, but held it in instead, grumbling under her breath, choking back all the things she wanted to say, all the things she knew would hurt him or scare him in return.

Devlin asked a new question when she didn’t respond. “How did it go for him out there?”

“Everything’s great. He’s doing wonderful.”

“Oh, good. Good, good,” he said, coming nearer to her desk now, the setting September sun coming in and lighting half of him in cool autumn

blue. “I imagine he’ll be heading home tonight. You picking him up from the airport?”

She said, “Is that why you’re here? To poison my spirit before he comes home? Did you come all the way to Toronto to catch me on a Friday night before I head home just to stick your scorpion tail in me?”

He smirked, seeing her unintended double entendre. “UFC tonight, Kimmy. Me and the guys. Would’ve invited Josh, but I knew he’d be away on business.”

“You have to be sick in the head, Devlin. This evil act you’re putting on, it’s cartoonish. I played with you for a while but now that I’m not in the mood, I’m puzzled why you’d think acting this way is intriguing. You’re laughable.”

Devlin put a hand over his heart, furrowing his brows with sympathy as though she were a feisty kitten before an ill-tempered pit bull. “Oh, Kimmy. No one laughs at me.”

She narrowed her eyes. “You ruined my life. You think you’re going to get away with that?”

Devlin patted the hand on his chest over his heart. “Oh, come on, Kimmy, your life isn’t ruined. You’re here, you’re alive. Not a thing about you looks ruined. In fact, you look fantastic. Get some sun and some rest in Rome?”

“You’re the cruelest man I’ve ever met. How couldn’t I see it coming?”

Devlin scoffed, bewildered. “What’s it? What’s this it of which you speak?” He laughed and looked around the office like he might spot the it she referred to, hands on hips in that arrogant Superman pose. “This it sounds like some sort of train wreck, some devastation.” He looked around again, this time with a perplexed look on his face. “I don’t see smoke, I don’t see fire. I see you, back at work. The worst thing that’s happened is you’re not wearing heels anymore—but don’t worry about me, I’ll recover.”

“I knew you were a pig. I knew it. I always knew it. I can’t believe how stupid I am. I hate myself for that.”

Devlin chuckled. “This pig, as you call me, granted all your life’s wishes. It didn’t come free, you had to pay a toll.” He stepped closer, meeting her at the side of her desk, raising his strong chin and looking down on her, studying her. He fingered her suit’s lapel. “But if you think I want to ruin anything, you are miles off target. I want to build. I want to create.”

“You did nothing but destroy.”

Devlin shook his head, sorry for her lack of comprehension. “Don’t pretend you have no vision, Kimmy. You’re not dumb. You can see where this is going. You can see where I’m taking us.”

She pushed his hand off her lapel, hating the ugly sparkle from feeling the size of his large warm hand under her own. “Devlin, look at me. We had something going, and it was fun. I enjoyed it. I have no idea—I mean zero—why you did what you did...”

He raised an eyebrow. “Do you want me to tell you or do you want me to let it play out? I could tell you, but it ruins the surprise of it.”

“Is that a threat? You think you can threaten me?”

“Threaten you with a good time, yes. These are not words you have to worry about. I’m not threatening you. You are in the clear. You are the star in my life. I’m threatening no one. You don’t see it. That’s the thing, there’s so much you don’t see even though I told you from the beginning how all of this would go and where it would end up.”

She zipped up her computer bag, gathered her keys and hefted the file folder, ignoring him. Then she moved around him toward her office door, stopping to give him a look asking if they were done here.

Devlin sat on the corner of her desk, tugging his pant legs, spreading his legs and showing her his generous bulge. He crossed his arms. “You’re going to be so proud of me.”

She scoffed. “How can you be so delusional?”

“I’m sure of myself. I know what I’m doing. You’re my prize. The trophy I win.”

“I’m no one’s trophy.”

He put up his palms. “I agree. You’re right, you’re right. I apologize, Kimmy. Trophy is the wrong word. A trophy you win after the game. You’re what I win before the game.” Now he stood again and approached her. She didn’t budge.

They stared at each other, her eyes flickering over his black devilish orbs, wondering how one man could be so deluded, so motivated by sin and deceit. His hand moved to her chin, and she recoiled at his touch, turning her nose up. “You don’t get to touch me anymore.”

He showed that perplexed look again. “What’s changed? We were so good together. I remember how you would tremble at my touch, how you would beg for me—”

“You gambled it away because you don’t know how a game is played.”

“I don’t know how its played? Kimmy, I wrote the rules.”

“I used to think there was more to you, Devlin. That everyone was wrong saying what an asshole you were. Maybe there was something in there, deep in there that was like sophisticated, dark but sophisticated. But you’re not even an asshole. You’re just a pompous blowhard, puffed up on privilege. You like to talk like Nietzsche, but you’re dime-store, through and through.”

Devlin burst out in an amused and shocked chuckle, reducing her insult to a schoolyard taunt with his merriment. He sighed a comical sound of someone with endless patience for such a game. “You’re mad now. You’re swearing to yourself how you hate me and I disgust you and you’ll never be with me again, but soon, soon you’ll get that ache deep inside you, and bit by bit you’ll talk yourself back into my bed because you’ve got a secret

spot about ten-inches deep in that sweet pussy of yours that I love so much, and I'm the only man who can touch it, I'm the only man who can fill you all the way up and explore your tenderest territory, make you squeal and squirt and—”

She grimaced and pulled away from him. “You’re out of your fucking mind, Devlin. A pure fucking sociopath.”

“Ooh, that’s dirty talk to me, Kimmy. Tell me how bad I am.”

She said, “Some day very soon, I’m going to make you regret ever tangling with me.”

They both smiled at each other, practically sneering, then she turned around and left her office, looking to get home as fast as she could.

6

OVERMATCH

A listless journey of thousands of miles ended out front of his apartment, parking his Qashgqai in the lot and stopping to look up at the window of the apartment he shared with his wife, glowing a pale yellowy light in the bluish evening. Tight unease ruined what should be a golden moment of return, coming home to Kimmy, who he loved. But looking up at that familiar glowing rectangle that represented so much—hearth, home, and what should have been a family—inspired nothing inside him he would expect, only a pervasive dread that grew in closer proximity to his wife. Distance had saved him until she'd followed. Her departure had healed it. Now walking through the doors and heading to the elevator, his stomach tightened in anticipation. He would soon have to face what he'd worked so hard to avoid.

After landing, he'd texted Kimmy to say he'd arrived. Then the tiring mechanics of airport navigation, driving back with Greg and Sloane from Swanson. Then he sat in his car at the Swanson lot for fifteen minutes, not even starting it. Putting off what? Coming home. Seeing Kimmy. Leaving the fairytale land of avoidance to face the medusa of his nightmares.

He paused at the apartment door, face twisted in agony with no more excuses to stay away, no more reasons to divert his attention. There were no more distractions. He knew she would stay up to welcome him home, knew she would greet him on the other side of this threshold.

He opened the door and stepped in, wheeling his suitcase behind him, closing the door, going as quiet as he could in case by some act of the great lord above Kimmy had fallen asleep waiting for him. Perhaps his quarter hour of purgatory in the Swanson lot could pay off.

But it hadn't. He was aware of her now, sitting in the family room, waiting for him, standing and coming into the foyer to greet him. She stood leaning a shoulder on the corner of the kitchen wall, arms folded, hands tucked at her sides, one bare foot over the other. Any other day in the thousands of days he'd shared with her, the sight of his wife this way would have melted him. Yoga pants, oversized comfy cotton sweater, shaggy hair, and that goddamned beautiful face he loved so much.

With no smile, only a soft sibilant voice, she said, "I missed you so much, Josh."

He nodded, tucking the corner of his mouth back and sucking his cheek, staring at the floor. He tossed his keys to the table.

She said, "I'm glad you're home."

"Yeah," he said, standing still, looking at her pretty feet, long and graceful, her sweet tawny skin, the bright pearly polish on her tiny toenails.

"Come in," she said, and left him, probably realizing how she crowded him at the door, retreating into the apartment's interior. He shrugged off his jacket and hung it up, then wheeled his suitcase into the apartment, coming around the kitchen to the family room. Kimmy sat on the couch with the television on but muted, occupying such a safe space in his life, a space where he'd spent so much matrimonial companionship. He told her he would unpack tomorrow, bringing his suitcase into the bedroom and storing it in the closet, changing out of his travel clothes, considering then that another perfect escape would be the shower. He'd been in cabs, a plane, Sloane's Subaru, for the last eleven hours. He locked the bathroom door when he showered, the water scorching hot.

Kimmy lay on the bed when he emerged, lying on her side on the covers, facing away toward the apartment window. "I know you're punishing me," she said.

He dried his hair, dressed in a T-shirt and pajama pants, then tossed the towel into the laundry hamper in the closet. "I don't think I am," he said.

She lay unmoving on the bed, two hands under her cheek, eyes looking out the window at the night sky. "I'm not saying I blame you. I wish I knew how to make you love me again."

"I do love you," he said, standing at the foot of the bed, protecting himself with folded arms.

"I made a mistake. I took the game too far. I wouldn't have done it if I knew it would hurt you."

He sighed, then sat at the foot of the bed with his back to her, putting his travel-heavy chin in a palm and staring into the steamy bathroom. Sure. The game went too far. That's all it was. That's what he wanted it to be, and of course, that's what Kimmy wanted it to be. He listened to the sounds of her sitting up, swishing her legs around, probably staring at his back. He looked over his shoulder and caught her doing that, hating the unwarranted sympathy he felt for her, seeing the sullen and hurting look on her face, the pouting lips, the furrowed brow, the teary eyes. He held out his hand backward to her. While it changed nothing about how he felt, he hoped it might offer her some reprieve from whatever pain she might feel right now, the same way her offered hand helped him in that restaurant in Rome.

Kimmy took more than he offered, holding his hand and scooting right to his back. The closeness of her brought warmth and pleasure and the feel of her lean body against him swelled tears in his eyes. Her cheek pressed his back, the light weight of her head resting on his shoulder. It mimicked a hug, and with the promise of glorious freedom from the torment that consumed him, he turned and embraced her. With that, Kimmy's arms went around him, her face buried in his neck. He lowered to the bed, holding her. Kimmy clung to him, crying and snuffling, her face hidden in his collar. Her cries, her tears, her hugging arms, all worked to bring a release on the clutch that held his heart. Whatever grasped him, whatever constricted his emotions, released at least for a moment. He smiled at the ceiling, holding the woman he married in his arms as she let out her own pain, her own torment, her own suffering.

After a long while of that, a repeat of what happened when she'd followed him to Rome, she eased out of his clutch, hiding her face, sniffing still,

then loping into the closet, taking his bath towel and using it to clear her face.

She returned to the bed, her cheeks red, eyes puffy, her lips swollen. New tears filled her eyes. She fell to the bed next to him, turning to him. She cupped a warm hand to his cheek. “Now that you’re home, everything’s going to be different, Josh. I swear. No more games, no more of that... whatever it was we were doing. We’re going to be serious now. I’m going to be serious about you. You’re my life...” The tears spilled at last, and she wiped them with her sweater sleeve. “You’re my life, Josh. I don’t want to play any games that would jeopardize that.”

For a flickering moment while he looked in her eyes, shame bloomed in his heart. Had he done this to her? She suffered for his own perversions. He’d pushed her into his dark kinks, his most sinful desires. But if it were his fault, he’d have to illuminate the “it.” What was it? What was the it that happened? How did her panties end up in Devlin’s apartment?

He didn’t want to fucking know. He didn’t want to ever, ever find out why. They were never there. It was some trick, some black magic cast by Devlin Stone.

He cupped her cheek, too, the both of them on their sides, face to face, holding the other. “You’re my life, too.”

Her eyebrows bowed, her mouth condensed to a blushed dollop. “Am I?”

“Of course you are,” he whispered, thumbing over her flawless cheek, looking into her eyes.

“I’m only going to be good to you. I won’t be bad to you. I swear it, Josh.”

“You were never bad.”

He watched her face contort and flutter through fluctuating emotions. She tried to say something, but more tears came. He thumbed them away. She said, “Can I kiss you?”

He nodded in rapid jabs and his wife planted her hot mouth on his, her ragged, happy breaths snorting through her nostrils, relieved, redeemed, loved. He hugged her again, ignoring all his suspicion and blooming with what he needed right now: peace and thrumming ardor, a loving glow lighting up his darkest places.

Kimmy's kiss broke away, her hand still on his cheek, her head bowing. He kissed her forehead as she seemed to be brought to tears again. His eyes roamed the room, at peace again and yet a terrible dread still threatening. He looked at their bed, their bedside table, the room, the window, the curtains. And wondered if Devlin had ever been in here. Had he fingered Kimmy on their bed? Had he done more? Where did he get Kimmy's panties?

Kimmy whispered, "Can we get into bed?"

He agreed, and they separated. He got off the bed, pulled back the sheets. Kimmy sat on the bed still, pulling off her sweater and tossing it to the floor. She was naked underneath. Just her lean beautiful torso, her teacups with their small chocolate nipples; her tight stomach bunched in the thinnest of rolls, her ribs showing. She stood, came around to her side of the bed and pulled back the covers, too. He got into bed, watching her still. She peeled the yoga pants off, no underwear underneath. The long muscles of her thighs flexed. She sat, showing him her graceful back, the shoulder blades pressing out her thin skin. He placed the whole of his outstretched hand on her naked back, and she paused, looking to the side, showing him her profile and letting him touch her. He imagined he could hear her heartbeat. Then let his hand fall and gathered it to his chest. Kimmy slipped in bed next to him, totally naked, shimmying to back herself into him. He folded an arm around her, felt her thin, delicate body in his clutch. She was a thing of great value. Tall, beautiful, striking, her intelligence fierce. When she wore her stark uniform of corporate law, she would steal any man's breath. Maybe even strike fear in his heart. Yet here she was in meek Josh Waters's bed. Devlin had told him she was too much woman.

But would too much woman fly to Rome for meek Josh Waters just so she could tell him she loved him, just so she could cry in his arms?

For the first time in two weeks, he smiled. It was timid at first, almost guilty of its own existence. Maybe he could move on from this debacle. Maybe there was hope. Nothing had happened. Nothing he would ever know about.

He kissed the back of her neck, whispering, “I love you very much, Kimmy.”

She squirreled around to face him, her eyes darting over his. Now his hand was on her warm narrow waist, moving lower, sliding over her feline haunch.

She said, “It’s been two weeks.”

Since what? Since they’d been intimate. But the first thing he thought was to blame her, to assault her with it. To think of her as a horny, insatiable woman who was getting it from two men. One of them went away, and she was getting it half as much.

It fucking aroused him.

He grew hard. Her touch, his renewed fantasy, her hot, smooth skin under his hand. Her nakedness.

She’d used her nakedness as a weapon. Flicked the blade out of his hand with her own, his sword of doubt and lost faith clattering to the castle floor. He was disarmed, helpless.

Maybe Devlin was right and Kimmy Chang was too much woman. She could make him do anything. Suffer anything.

“I just want to feel your body, Josh,” she said, guiding him to take off his shirt. “I want to feel your skin on mine. We don’t have to do anything, we can—”

She stopped when she found his erection. He shouldn’t feel ashamed by his arousal in his wife’s presence, but now he worried she thought maybe he’d been thinking dirty thoughts of her again, dark fantasies of her betrayal with his high school bully.

She pulled out the front of his pajamas and her long hand snuck in and cupped the belly of his throbbing hardness. He shuddered, powerless under her magic touch.

GRAVITATION

The tidal draw toward his wife, the woman he loved, pulled him closer with irresistible lunar power. Where Kimmy traveled, he would follow. And when Kimmy stilled, they would connect. If she voyaged, he would splash and swirl in her traveled path, looking evermore to reconnect.

The terrible thing that never happened, that neither of them could ever acknowledge, now seemed distant and foggy with her hand on his naked erection. Kimmy's sexual touch reminded him of uncomplicated times, almost archaeological times, ossified into happy monuments prominent in his memory. Of asking her to marry him. Of their wedding. Of their honeymoon. Freakier ones, too. The first time she put her mouth on his cock. That incredible feeling the first night he'd made her orgasm. Happy pillow talk, naked in the dawning light. Tiger Bites. The terrible afternoon she told them they lost their baby.

He touched her beautiful face, and she closed her grip on his erection. They kissed. This time, love bloomed again in the plump osculation, their soft lips squashing one another. He tasted her tongue, his heart aching with the relief from clenched pain. It became too much emotion to bear, and it scared him into retreat. He shrank from their connection, timid, like a child afraid of the stove that had burned their hand.

Kimmy's mouth shrank, then relaxed, and he adored the supple way her lips worked together. She was truly a gorgeous creature, so much about her elegant and graceful; a purity to her simple angular construction; an armature of long bones, sharp angles and swooping curves, exquisite muscle and ligament holding it all in lithe place; skin so soft and smooth, blushed in the butterscotch colors reserved for big cats or birds of prey. And those black eyes, deep with love or foreboding or maybe both. She'd never

said a vicious word to him, never insulted him or hurt his feelings. Only ever offered support and care. But in eyes that black, any mysterious creature could swim; dark and unimaginable cosmic horrors, monstrous beings that would flay your flesh away from your soul.

She said, “Josh, you’re all I ever wanted in my life. I have everything I want in you.” Her hand caressed his cock, underhanded, coaxing, yet without fever.

Would her hand stay timid on Devlin’s mighty totem of enormous sexual power? In his sickly early-summer tent-dream, Devlin had put that veiny beast in his hand. Had he felt Devlin’s masculine force? Had it really been in his grip?

Had Kimmy held that titanic male organ throbbing with vitality, wicked sperm thrashing in Devlin’s huge balls like shark-infested waters? Had she succumbed to its power?

The thing Kimmy gripped now in her lukewarm marital bed paled in comparison. If the thing neither of them would ever acknowledge did happen, how could she return to her meek husband? How would she turn her back on a vigorous man like Devlin Stone?

He cupped her cheek, his heart growing heavy again, sinking like a rock in his wife’s mysterious gaze. He said, “I’m sorry I ever made you play that game.”

Her mouth creased, just for a second, before plumping again. “No apologies, remember?”

He nodded, whispering, “Yeah.”

She dipped her face to meet his lowered gaze. “It goes for you, too, Josh. No apologies.”

A terrible sadness seized his chest as he realized his penis had lagged in her hand, gone floppy and shrinking. Kimmy squeezed it with two fingers,

trying to plump it. The smaller he felt in her hand, the more his hardness faded and the smaller it became.

She sighed—comforting, not disappointed—and she said, “We don’t have to tonight. It was a long flight. I know you want to sleep.” Or maybe he disappointed her.

But how could any man not want to make love to a woman like Kimmy Chang? Naked and eager, trying to manipulate his organ into hardness. Devlin would say a woman like Kimmy Chang required a man who satisfied her. Never failed her. Never let her down.

Devlin wouldn’t shrink in her hand. Both of them knew that, but neither of them would say it. It just hung in the air like an unacknowledged noxious smell.

Maybe that’s why the thing that never happened had happened. Maybe Kimmy Chang didn’t get what she wanted from Josh Waters.

Maybe Devlin gave it to her.

His cock returned to full hardness in his wife’s warm hand. Kimmy moved quicker, pleased with the renewal. Wanting it. Not doing her husband a favor, no, Kimmy was a woman with needs as large and complicated as his own. She wasn’t his subjugate wife; they were a partnership, and each of them had desires and capabilities they brought to the bargaining table. If he offered his floppy penis in a bargain, negotiations might break down.

Under Kimmy’s inexorable sexual pull, he moved into her, wanting to satisfy her before she sought satisfaction elsewhere. The challenge thrilled his heart. But the proximity of an aggressive and much larger challenger scared the shit out of him. Shrank his balls and his confidence, and frightened away his masculine stiffness.

It was erotic and terrifying.

But a game they had to stop.

His mouth crushed hers, his eyes squeezed shut; he flexed every summonable pelvic muscle, forcing his erection to stay strong.

Don't flee. Please, don't flee.

He got over top of her, and Kimmy was willing, going to her back, long arms slinking around him, her limber legs opening, allowing her husband access to pollinate her dusky little flower, to deposit his seed.

She even told him directly now, her hands cupping his jaw, looking into his eyes, her black gaze frightening in its illegibility. "Come inside me, Josh. I want to feel you come inside me."

He didn't know how to respond.

Kimmy urged him. "Please, Josh. I need it. I need to feel you come inside me."

A demand.

An easy demand, sure, but a fallible task. A challenger loomed behind him, expecting his failure, eager to replace him, eager to send him into the woods with nothing. Take from him a resource he didn't deserve. A resource meant for better males. Stronger men, more capable ones that a woman like Kimmy wouldn't deny.

Kimmy would be relieved if he scampered off into the underbrush with his tail between his legs, his softer and smaller penis jiggling between his legs.

And that made him hard as a rock. Because there was no Devlin in this room. Only Josh and Kimmy, married, living together, families connected.

Or did his obligations burden Kimmy Chang?

Did his last name weigh her down? Was Kimmy Chang freer than Kimmy Waters? During the day she was slick and sinewy Kimmy Chang, esquire. By night she was Kimmy Waters, beige and watery, clad in formless cotton, making Tiger Bites for her husband, and weaving cat beds.

The warmth of her interior claimed his hard cock. He sank his hardness inside his wife. Kimmy sighed with satisfaction. She was hot. But barely wet. She didn't teem. Her interior didn't welcome him with a gush of sexual excitement. The reception was mild. Disinterested, even. Her words were flabby invitation, polite platitudes meant to charm her husband away from her deceit.

Or she was honest, only timid now, worried the husband she'd pursued to Rome would reject her.

Or maybe she would retell this story to her lover, she and Devlin Stone laughing together at Josh Waters's expense, the two of them in his bed at lunch, his apartment only a few minutes' drive from Kimmy's office. Would she tell Devlin she'd almost lost him from their game—not Josh and Kimmy's, but Devlin and Kimmy's? That Josh almost bailed on them and they could no longer enjoy inflicting torment? They would laugh because he was a fool who couldn't help himself, a worthless puppy dog happy to have any owner.

He withdrew.

Kimmy called his name, tried to pull him back, but he crouched on his knees between her open legs with his penis listing to one side, removed of its necessary steel. He couldn't satisfy her.

“Josh, what are you doing?”

Kimmy sat up, her thighs closing in on him. She hugged one arm around his neck, her other hand discovering his flaccid member, unable to perform its duty. She fondled his penis, but her hand stilled. Her forehead touched his.

“It's late, Josh. Would you just hold me? Can we sleep together? I just want your body next to mine.”

He told her yeah, his ego crushed. His defense system worked to blame this on her, show her he was still mad, that the same specter that had haunted him in Rome lurked in the shadows of this room. This was her fault. Sure,

he told her he didn't want an apology, but maybe he deserved an apology. The more this was her fault, the less it was his.

But what if... Maybe he could hear the truth? Maybe she should tell him how far she went with Devlin.

But what would that do to him?

It would murder him. Devastate him. Tear him down to a pile of bloody shreds.

Maybe Devlin only fingered Kimmy. Or maybe less than that. Maybe she let Devlin remove her panties. Maybe she showed Devlin her dusky flower. Maybe he parted her petals.

Fuck.

He grew hard again. Kimmy's grip expanded to accommodate his hardness's return.

She snuffled a small chuckle filled with happy relief. Her hand stroked his hard cock. With her forehead on his, her eyes closed, one hand at his neck, her long, long fingers scratched at his cheek and jaw, the other closed around his erection. "I want us to devote ourselves to each other, to our marriage. Okay? No more games."

He grimaced, his features twisting, rolling his forehead against their small point of contact. A measure of blame pointed his way. Their game. More like his game. It was his game.

She said, "I say we go for it. We buy a house. Start a family. We do it now. Not later. Now."

How? How would they do that? They had capital, but it wasn't enough to buy a house around Toronto. They would be down to one job again. But maybe... Maybe she was right. Maybe big things would happen for him. Maybe staying safe made things dangerous. Maybe staying in one place made you a target.

Or maybe Kimmy would tell Devlin she had him right where she wanted him. Monday at lunch, stretched out in his bed, her panties on the floor. Or stuffed in the couch. Maybe they always had sex on the couch. Maybe they both planted the panties there, laughing, wondering if he would find them. Devlin would ask her what if he finds them, and she would say to Devlin, I can convince him of anything. Devlin touched Kimmy's cheek and admired her cruelty.

His cock leaked slickness into Kimmy's grip.

He shuddered and pushed away from her, backing off the bed.

She pleaded for him, naked, legs open, one palm shining with his pre-cum. "Josh, come back, please."

He huffed ragged breaths and felt more panicked than he had ever felt in his life. He ruffled his hair, eyes wild like a frightened animal, his thoughts racing. "I just, I have to..."

He turned then, naked, embarrassed by his nudity in front of his wife, went and hid in the bathroom. Didn't even turn the lights on. Put his back to the closed door, twisting his head on his neck, grimacing with intense anguish. Feelings of betrayal, or maybe failure, or maybe lust. His cock throbbed and leaked more pre-cum, running over his scrotum.

He went to hands and knees and snuck across to the laundry hamper. When he'd come in here for his shower, he'd brought only one item from his suitcase. The panties he'd found in Devlin's couch. The panties she'd hid for him to find because they were playing his game. The panties Devlin removed before he fucked her on his couch that afternoon. Fucked her and come inside her and pushed his fingers into her pussy or maybe her anus, just so he could make Josh smell them when they met for the Jays game later that night.

EXORCISM

With the panties balled to his chest, he slumped against the bathroom cupboards. The position reminded him too much of sorrow, like if he wanted to curl in a ball like this, he should be sobbing. But instead of rolling tears, all he endured was a thundering pulse. So he stood, elbowing himself up from the counter to his feet, avoiding the mirror because what he saw might frighten him.

Now he was hinged at the waist, elbows on the counter, forehead resting on the knuckles of a fist. The scent of Kimmy's panties close to his mouth and nose attuned him to the knife edge of his existence; love, lust, and trust on one blade cheek, hate and betrayal, but also lust, on the other. He tiptoed on its deadly razor edge like a tightrope, and with each step came closer to losing his balance at last, falling to one side, or straight down, cloven in two and ruined, from balls to brain.

He held the panties to his mouth and nose in the fashion of a chloroform rag and drew a deep breath, hoping to succumb to whatever powerful toxicity his wife's panties held. This balled fabric had become an obsession point, damp and heavy with meaning. He moved one hand between his legs. His cock was hard as steel and dripping with excitement. He stroked it, his grip wet and heavenly, and with the panties held to his face, he closed his eyes, rolled them up high, and stroked faster, looking for release from the torturous grip the fantasy of the bleakest betrayal held him in. If he could come, he could escape. At least for a while. If he could come, Kimmy would hold no obligation over him. He could sleep. Sweet, innocent sleep next to the woman he loved.

Then, Kimmy's quiet voice on the other side of the door, close, very close, as if her cheek pressed it: she called his name, her voice trailing high with

questioning.

“I’ll be out in a minute,” he mumbled, his voice thick, his breath hot. His heart ached.

“Josh?”

“Just a minute.”

A quiet beat, then: “Let me do it. Let me do it for you.”

“I’ll be out in a minute.”

Another slow beat of time. “Please, let me do it, Josh.”

He let his cock go, a shiver of embarrassment traveling through him, like he’d left the door open a crack and she saw what he was doing. He straightened and turned, folding his arms over his chest. “Do what?”

“Please, come out. Don’t leave me alone out here.”

When he stood without answering for too long, she said, “Come to bed and let me do it. Then we can go to sleep together. Okay? Let me help you. Don’t be alone.”

He said again, “Do what?”

An exhale. “I can hear you.”

“Why are you listening?”

“Please, Josh. Come to bed. Don’t lock yourself away.”

Shame burned his cheeks. He was easy to read. So easy his wife knew he’d retreated to his own fantasy to avoid reality. And reality was sex with Kimmy. And reality was much more than that. More than he could ever face.

“Come to bed, Josh. I really, really want to do it for you.”

Did she know what he was doing? Really know?

He turned and almost looked in the mirror by accident, stepped aside, came to his senses for one brief second, thinking he would hide the panties in the hamper again, but then darkness folding over him, his fist tightening, clutching the panties over his heart. He snatched a towel from the rack and draped it over his aching arousal, his cock poking a tent in it, anyway. Then he unlocked the door, put his hand on the lever and stood there, hesitating, for almost a minute.

Kimmy turned the lever herself and his hand allowed it. She'd dressed again, only in her oversized cotton sweatshirt, the neck hole to one side, slumping to expose most of her narrow shoulder. No yoga pants now, just bare legs, and he supposed no panties.

"Come to bed," she said, showing him a soft, timid smile. She held out a hand for his.

In one hand he held the towel. His other reached out and opened and showed her the panties.

Her face furrowed with sympathy. Her lower lip sucked under her upper, and her black eyes sought his. "No, Josh," she whispered.

His hand trembled, holding his sacred object, then he closed them in his fist, hiding them again. Kimmy took his hand in both of hers and pried his fingers open. "Josh, give them to me." Her voice was easy and loving, but a voice of authority. His fingers surrendered their hold, and she removed the panties from his grip, reclaimed her property. "No," she whispered again, stepping past him, going into the bathroom. He watched as her bare foot stepped on the bathroom trash's foot pedal, flipped the lid open, and dropped in the panties. Foot away, the lid dropped closed.

It was for the better. But his brow grew heavy with more shame, more embarrassment, and a dark part of his heart wanted those panties preserved, memorialized. Treated with better respect than such an unceremonious farewell.

Kimmy opened the mirrored door of the vanity cabinet and retrieved a small tub of petroleum jelly she sometimes applied to her lips in the harshest days of the winter. Then she took his hand without asking and told him to, “Come on,” leading him to the bed with the towel covering his erection. He followed, saying nothing, and climbed into bed with her. She pulled the sheets over to cover them, staying in her sweatshirt, and saving him from the savage grace her beautiful naked body showed.

She stayed face to face with him, both of them on their sides, pulling off the tub’s tin lid with a small sound of suction. He watched those graceful fingers ply a dollop of ochre grease, then thumb the finger pads in crackling circles. Her other hand pushed the sheets down below their waists, and she stretched the towel out, taking it from his grip, exposing his erection.

When her hand gripped his cock with that slick velvety grease, his whole body stiffened and jerked as wicked pleasure seized him. But just like the bathroom mirror, he didn’t want to see his own reflection in his wife’s gaze, didn’t want to risk even seeing how his wife’s gaze assessed him. He dipped his chin, curled his body like a shrimp, his face dipping below her gaze. Kimmy kissed his forehead while her delicate grip stroked him.

For the sake of closure—for Kimmy’s sake and for his own—he let his eyes close and his mind wander in the dark. He thought of Kimmy doing the same thing for Devlin, using her hand on him. But Devlin wouldn’t lay passive on his side. Devlin would mount her, straddle her chest, her little titties jiggling as she struggled to control the python in her two-handed grip. Now here she was nursing the seed from her husband’s aching balls, comforting him with a prescribed milking, coaxing the poison from his system.

Kimmy cupped his balls, and he whimpered as if in agony, but her touch was exquisite pleasure. She kneaded his scrotum and stroked his cock with thumb and three fingers. The pace was slow and steady. Purposeful. Administrative. She tended a sick patient like a dutiful nurse. Again, she kissed his forehead. She knew his thoughts. Knew his darkness still swirled. Sought to bring light through a nocturnal emission. Peace might come from release. And he needed release from his pain.

So he tempted the wicked. Conjured what he needed to find the solace his heart pleaded for right now. While his wife stroked his cock with loving care, he imagined her in the worst ways he could. Imagined her possessed with lust and desire for an evil man, worshipping in private ceremonies his masculine spirit erected between his legs. Only she didn't supplicate before it, didn't grease the seed from his reproductive terminals, she lay prostrate in horrible sacrifice, offering up her tight sexual core for Devlin's sacrament.

Did Devlin come inside her? Was Kimmy that bad? No. Impossible. But in his fantasy she was wicked. And she begged Devlin to feel his eruption inside her body, to have his thick seed splash her depths, putting liquid pleasure where her husband couldn't. It was impossible. But he imagined it for release. Pictured her getting pounded in Cayman. On all fours behind her husband's back, getting it deep and hard. He pictured her toweling off, laughing with Devlin how late she would return to Josh, sitting in the hot tub with a bottle of champagne for them to share. Telling Devlin her husband's fantasy. Telling Devlin the ugliest secrets he shared only with her.

Something turned over inside him. The release he craved had woken from its hibernation.

He riffled more terrifying images, flicking through them like a horny kid going through his first porno mag. And instead of playing them out, now he fantasized speaking them aloud. Asking Kimmy the most unimaginable things. Did you wear a condom when he fucked you? Has he ever come in your mouth? The night I smelled his finger, did you know he would do that to me? Did you come when he did it, imagining my humiliation? Do all your friends know you're fucking him behind my back?

Do you all laugh at me?

His body trembled first, then seized, then rocked as his balls retracted and the sperm erupted. It came out with force enough that Kimmy emitted a small sound of surprise before purring encouragement, her matron's tone that of encouraging a boy. It came so hard and so fast his urethra hurt for a moment. Then Kimmy squashed the pain away with her massaging grip, squeezing and stroking and working pure and awful pleasure from his body. He bucked more and more, looking down to see his organ in her beautiful

hand, shining but unimpressive, spurting thick globs of semen onto the towel she'd lay out.

“Good, Josh, good,” she whispered, teasing him with only two fingers and a thumb squishing on his cock head. He closed his eyes and imagined Kimmy telling Devlin all about this on the phone, telling Devlin how he couldn't stay hard enough to fuck her and she'd had to jerk his little dick off. Would she compare his load to Devlin's? Would she say to Devlin she wished it was his cock in her hand? Say that Josh is home now and I want to see you again. I want to torment him more and more and more. I come so hard hurting my husband. It makes me squirt to know he suffers.

Now he pushed his forehead into Kimmy's collar and she put an arm around him, still squeezing his cock, still milking the last drops of pleasure from his balls and his poisoned brain. He pulsed more come. Kimmy made a sound of pleasure. Satisfied she'd drawn more of his badness out of his body and onto the towel.

At last, she could squeeze no more from him and her hand stilled. He huffed for breath into her chest. She stroked his back, then eased away so she could dry her hands off on the towel. She dried his cock, too, and getting his scrotum and between his legs.

Then the towel was tossed away, and she lay with both hands under her cheek, studying him with those unreadable black eyes.

Nothing could be said. No thank you, no thanks for nothing. No sorry I couldn't keep it up. The urge to survey more dark territory with her had ebbed. He didn't want to ask her why she wasn't sopping wet. I thought you missed me? Those questions didn't inspire the same thrill.

And shame accumulated again, but now he didn't cherish it, didn't polish it and place it on any mantle to be admired from his leather chair. Now he hated it.

He took a deep breath, appreciating that, for the moment, Kimmy had cured him. His anguish may be chronic, but his beloved Kimmy didn't want him to hurt as much as he dreamt she did.

He scooted higher on the bed, getting so his head was above hers, looking down on her, not up at. "I want to sleep," he told her now, cold and unattached, his turbulent waters stilled by her ministrations. Her face showed nothing, but she nodded once. He told her to roll over, and she did, unsure, a hint of worry maybe. But when she showed him her back, he reached beyond her and turned off the light, then put his arm around her. At his embrace, he sensed she'd begun to cry, so he held her tighter and fell asleep.

SPYCAM

For a long while in the morning she watched Josh sleep, sometimes touching his hair, careful not to wake him. He'd had a bad week. The man she'd married had gone far from home, thrust into a stressful position with his career's future at stake, and meanwhile bearing the burden of the horrible things his wife may have done behind his back. And they were only his imaginings, inspired by finding her panties in his boss's couch. What horrible things had he imagined? The truth was worse. The truth was something even his imagination would stay far, far away from.

The way the sun shone in the window lit up his hair, showing the gold in his auburn curls. He looked boyish and innocent, and a lot like the college kid she'd fallen in love with. How could she treat him with such disregard? The whole thing seemed like a blur—no, a greasy smudge on the soot smeared window of an abandoned factory. Six months ago, they were pregnant and were about to begin a family. What happened to that? How did her life veer so far away?

The tears came again, and she slipped out of bed, wiping her eyes, telling herself she didn't want her sobs to wake him, but knowing she was a coward who couldn't sit and watch the sun light up an innocent man being punished for her crimes.

She dressed and went to the kitchen, at first thinking she would make Josh all his favorite foods and then realizing that would be a bad idea. The family room blinds were down and the kitchen dim. She stood with the fridge door open, cool air batting her calves, her head in her hands as she found herself in a mirrored maze conundrum. There was no easy way out, no straightforward path to peace and restoration. There may be no path at all. Josh was broken. When she'd played games with Devlin, her steadfast

rule was to never hurt Josh. Now Josh was more than hurt. He was emptied, scooped out like a tub of ice cream, just a sodden cardboard husk. And she'd done it. Emptied him. She'd thought she was on top of the game, she thought she knew all the angles. Devlin had been bold and played a one-in-a-million trick shot that left the crowd gasping.

Didn't Devlin respect her worth? Didn't she do wonders at Stone Custom Brokerage? Was that a lie?

No. No way. She knew it wasn't. She'd tracked her predecessor's work before he'd left and she'd replaced him. The guy played more golf than analyzed contracts. Devlin needed her. Needed her at his father's company, and she knew he needed her for anything he wanted to do on his own. He wasn't smart enough without her. Devlin knew her value. Why he'd gamble that value on humiliating her husband made no sense.

So now the fun was over. No matter how much Devlin said the fun was only beginning, Devlin was wrong, and the fun was over. None of this turned out the way she wanted it. Not with Devlin, not with Josh, and not with her job at Stone. She had nothing left but a broken husband, shattered like fine porcelain by his high school bully, and she was left picking up the pieces, on her knees trying not to cut her fingers on Josh's shards, a tube of super-glue in one hand and the murky instructions for reassembly spread out on the floor. She had nothing now. Nothing but smashed love, heartache, regret, and a burning passion for vengeance.

As much happiness that images of her serving Josh breakfast in bed might inspire, they were happy fantasies that looked nothing like reality. She'd love to do it, ached to, but couldn't because doing so would hurt him further, a focused revelation of her guilt. Like showing up in Rome. But Josh deserved care. Deserved nothing but the best of care. This was a tightrope act of tender mercy and support and love without playing the hand you'd love to play because it would illuminate your betrayal.

It'd been a long time crying last night. To watch your husband hurting the way Josh was, to let him rest his head on your chest while you milked his erection, knowing in his fevered mind he was watering the tiny sprouting plant bursting from the nefarious seed you'd planted. But she wasn't alone

in that act; Josh's soil was rich with the nutrients needed for that terrifying plant to grow.

That was a terrible thing to think.

Josh was blameless. She knew he was blameless. It was she who had eroticized the sadistic art of betrayal, polishing those dull surfaces in Josh's mind that would fantasize about something so cruel until they gleamed like gold.

She sighed, her brain seeking relief from her own torment, a fraction of what she'd heaped upon her husband, snatched a wad of paper towels and dried her cheeks. When she'd pushed the oppressive thoughts back like a lion tamer with a chair, she got to work making a regular, no-big-deal Saturday morning breakfast, one they'd eat before she'd turned their world upside down.



She queued up an episode of The Office and set the volume a little too loud, balancing her plate on her lap, a mug of tea in one hand on the couch's arm, her head leaning back to watch down the hall for Josh to emerge. It took a while, half an episode, but at last new light shone in the hallway as the bedroom door opened and she sat forward like she hadn't been waiting for his arrival, and bit into her cold toast.

Josh came into the family room, eyes dopey, hair in cute disarray, dressed in a T-shirt and sweatpants, looking toward the TV.

She paused it. "You really slept in. You must be so tired."

He nodded and scratched his head.

She said, "I made some breakfast. It's in the kitchen. Come sit with me."

He muttered, “I smelled bacon,” and headed into the kitchen.

She said over her shoulder, “There’s scrambled eggs with cheese, too. You can pop it in the microwave. I didn’t want to wake you.”

Josh went through a series of kitchen noises, followed by the hum of the microwave. Soon he came in to join her. She’d imagined the horrible scenario where he would stay in the kitchen, eat at the counter because he couldn’t stand to sit on the couch with her. The relief flooded her fast and hard, making her eyes blurry for a second.

She pressed play, and they watched TV together until they were done. She took his plate, cleaned up, and loaded the dishwasher. When she returned, she found Josh lying on his side, eyes looking somewhere near the TV but not at it. She sat down again and muted the TV.

“What do you want to do today? Let’s go do something fun,” she said.

“Like what?”

“I don’t know,” she sighed, flopping down to sit by his bare feet. “I know you’re tired, so we could go see a movie or something. How about that?”

He said yeah, and her heart leaped. She held his ankle, then rubbed his calf. “Hey, you know what we could do?”

“What?”

“Does Meyer have Sophie this weekend?”

“Yeah.”

“Maybe we go see a movie with Soph, how about that? Or what if we all went to the drive-in tonight?”

“No, I don’t think so.”

“Why not?”

“I just don’t feel like it.”

“Not up to it?”

Josh didn’t answer, then pulled his feet away and sat up, looking straight ahead. He ruffled his hair and leaned forward with his head in his hands, elbows on his knees.

“Okay. Just the two of us,” she said. “Afternoon movie, go get dinner. Just you and me. Maybe we can see Sophie tomorrow.”

Josh breathed into his hands, then sat back again, slumping in the couch, his face red, his eyes bleary and tired. He looked her way, but not at her. He said, “Kimmy, I told Meyer.”

Something deep inside began to grow cold. “Told him what?”

Josh finally met her gaze, and she could lose herself in his eyes, swim in the bountiful absence of the spark that made her husband who he was. He said, “Did you know he was watching you?”

“Meyer? Watching me when? What do you mean?”

Josh looked down, and it occurred to her he thought she’d known she was being watched—did that mean he thought that was why she followed him to Rome?

“When I was gone, I told Meyer to watch you for me.”

“Follow me? Josh...”

“No, just see if you came and went from the apartment when you should be.”

The revelation stunned her, knocked her senseless. She stood, mad and wanting to stomp away, but then plopped back down. How could Josh do that?

Because of what you did to him.

She touched her own face and her fingers' iciness shocked her. She said, "You had him watch me?"

Josh said nothing and when she turned to face him, he turned to face her. He was silent and unreadable, but those empty eyes killed her.

She nodded, tears coming fast and hard, looking to fill her eyes. "Okay," she squeaked. Yeah, she deserved that. Nothing to say about that. She stood again, this time not falling, hugged herself and left the room as quick as she could before blubbing in front of him, proving her guilt to Josh in further certain terms.

So Meyer knew.

Would Sophie know?

Her pace quickened as she neared the bedroom.

Would she be exiled from the family, have a niece that would ask later Whatever happened to Aunt Kimmy? she was so nice, and no one would answer poor Sophie, and that little girl would be left with the pervasive dread of some unnamed tragedy that would make no sense to an innocent child.

Would the name Kimmy be forever unspeakable?



Kimmy padded down the hall and the bedroom door closed with a quiet click. She would cry again and knowing that hurt his heart. Hurt because he didn't want Kimmy to suffer, but couldn't stop it from happening. He turned the TV off and sat in silence, looking at the blinds blocking the pale September sunlight.

Maybe they'd go see a movie. They could do that. Dinner sounded good.

Maybe he shouldn't have told her about Meyer.

Maybe he shouldn't have asked Meyer to spy on her.

Who fucking knew anymore. Even Kimmy stopped her watery denials. There was no point pretending anymore. Kimmy had done something with Devlin.

But you told her not to deny it. You told her to act like nothing happened. How else is she supposed to act now?

Maybe he was the bad guy. Maybe this despondent display held some measure of drama, of theatrics. If he tried hard enough, maybe he could shake and shudder and find some shape of smile to spread his face.

It didn't come.

Not the shakes, not the smile. Nothing.

His phone chimed somewhere behind him. He struggled to stand, never feeling so heavy in his life, and searched for his phone, finding it where he'd left it in the front hall when he'd come in late last night.

A text.

Not from Kimmy down the hall, not from Meyer to see how he was doing.

Another unknown phone number, the beginning words showing a lure to get him to swipe the message open.

The text snippet he could read: Do you recognize this beautiful thigh?

Already his heart hammered. Echoes of how this started: dreams of Devlin tormenting him in a tent, of dreaming Kimmy slept with Devlin at Tiffany's party, of the taunting texts thereafter that seemed to know so much but said so little. Texts that told him he'd find Devlin's business card in his own front hall.

The text opened, and he read it, aware of the photo below, but not scrolling high enough to make it out yet. Knowing it would be his worst nightmare. Anticipating it with heart-stopping mania.

Do you recognize this beautiful thigh? How would one get such an intimate picture as this?

Then the photo.

Cropped. Zoomed in and blown up. Almost wall to wall flesh in the color of Kimmy's skin. He tightened his stomach, his breath wheezing with fire. It was the inside of a woman's leg, from knee to near the crotch. The knee was closest to the lens, in focus, the pattern on the skin there as definable and unique as a fingerprint. Kimmy's knee. His wife's knee.

Text me back if you want to see more, Josh.

10

WROUGHT

Too much flesh for a woman wearing a dress. Had she worn shorts? Maybe the picture was taken in Cayman. The day she wore the bikini.

Devlin was a cold manipulator and he would be a fool to believe anything he told him and anything he sent him. But the closeup photo of Kimmy's inner thigh was all he could think about.

His boss Harmeet had summoned him to the office mid-morning, the first day back after the trip to Rome. He'd heard nothing on the weekend.

Ah, the weekend.

A time of rest and recuperation. Except he spent his weekend twisted in agony, wanting to move on with the best person in his life, and instead simmered an anxious pot of roiling hate and lust. The hurt applied by his enemy showed his enemy's indecency. A true barbarian, fond of kicking someone when they were down.

The picture of Kimmy's thigh was all he could think about—but he'd said nothing. Texted nothing in return to Devlin, made no mention of the bullying taunt to Kimmy. Suffered alone and in silence. Just the way he liked it.

Harmeet looked amped today, like he had good news, though he said nothing to Josh about what prompted the good mood, he hoped it was good news about the trip to Rome. He leaned back in his squeaky office chair, crossed a leg, showing off a sliver of his dark, hairy calf. They made chit chat about the trip, talking about the travel home and how it would take a

while to get used to being back in Canada. It was odd how he was here alone. None of the others who went to Rome were present.

Harmeet said, “You were like a rock out there. Just a hunk of lead.”

Josh nodded, not knowing what it meant.

“You didn’t give them anything, you didn’t take anything from them. You sat and listened and only asked questions when you had to.”

Harmeet could mean this as a bad thing, that he was disengaged, and yeah, there were times he’d checked out, but the way Harmeet jabbed his hand, all five fingers, beefy gold ring on the middle one, reminded Josh of coaches giving half-time pep talks. He nodded again—checked out and thinking how another man took a picture of the inside of his wife’s naked thigh. What did the rest of the photo show?

Harmeet shrugged a shoulder, saying, “You saw some of those other execs. Even some from the main office. Too effusive, too ingratiating. I know these guys’s office is in Rome, and you might think they’re passionate Italians, but these people are Saxons. They think that kind of bubbly TikTok personality is for kids or imbeciles or people setting a trap. They don’t trust it.”

He shook his head no. Those people didn’t speak with affectation and didn’t gush. Harmeet continued, and Josh nodded along.

The unexpected benefit of the illicit photo Devlin sent was it swayed any anger Josh had sent Kimmy’s way. This was the man he was dealing with, and that meant it was the man Kimmy dealt with.

The best thing for him to have done was to stand up when this began and forbid his wife from involving herself with the worst human being he’d encountered in his life. He’d thought back then that interjecting himself would be inappropriate. That telling Kimmy no she couldn’t accept the job offer would be telling her how she could and couldn’t live her life. Something a man shouldn’t do. But it had nothing to do with stopping his

wife from working. It had everything to do with protecting his family. That was something he'd failed at.

It was like he'd forgotten all the times Devlin had tormented him back at Dalton High—and even before high school. It was like he'd forgotten what a cruel piece of shit Devlin was.

But he hadn't forgotten. The passing years had so buffered him from that torture that he thought it was safe to believe a man like Devlin could change.

Harmeet was pointing a stubby finger his way.

“Someone there actually mentioned you, Josh. Wanted to know your name again.”

Josh nodded.

With his hate flowing but redirected, the flesh in that sleazy picture of his wife's inner thigh had been tempered from lust and sex and infidelity to that of sympathy. To the flesh of the tormented. Kimmy no different from him. That inner thigh flesh was the inner thigh flesh of another victim of Devlin's bullying, his manipulations, his games of deceit and betrayal. Devlin had used Kimmy like a puppet, making her arms and legs and mouth move in the patterns most likely to cause Josh intense and humiliating harm.

“I'm going to move you up on the team for the next stage,” Harmeet said at last, leaning forward again and resting his forearms on his desk. “I know you can handle it. I want you there.”



Monday after lunch, she met Devlin out front of the office building, Devlin waiting for her in his Mercedes with the motor idling. A meeting downtown this afternoon, entered on the calendar a week before Josh found her panties in Devlin's couch. She got into Devlin's roadster, briefcase in her lap, doing up her seatbelt without saying a thing to him. Buckled up, she looked straight ahead like he didn't exist. He stared at the side of her face. She said, "Let's get going."

Devlin cocked his head, pretending to be amused, as if he thought her anger to be petty. He said, "Monday morning and you're still mad."

She still said nothing and checked her watch, reminding him this appointment had a start time.

Devlin put the car in gear and headed out from the office and onto Yonge Street, heading downtown. "How was your weekend?"

She said, "Sensational."

"That's good to hear. How's Josh? How was his trip?"

"Josh is... Yeah, he's good. We don't need to talk."

"You and Josh?"

"You and me, Devlin. Any last-minute information before we meet with these guys?"

"I thought you meant you don't talk to Josh. I thought that was surprising. I thought you'd have a lot to talk about."

She put her fingers through his roadster's door handle and fantasized opening it at the next light and walking away from it all. But she wouldn't do that. As much a relief as it would be, she'd worked too hard to give up on this just because she should have known better than to sleep with the worthless Devlin fucking Stone.

"I'm glad you guys are talking."

She shook her head. Bit her tongue. Then spoke even though she'd sworn to herself she wouldn't say a thing to Devlin outside of business. "I had one rule. One rule, Devlin. Don't hurt Josh. We can't go back. So get on the DVP and let me think. You don't have to talk."

"Do you want the radio on?"

"Fine."

He didn't turn the radio on. He said, "Who wants to go back when we're moving forward so well?"

"More cryptic bull shit," she said to no one, just thinking out loud.

As if all-knowing, he said, "No one hurt Josh, Kimmy. He's not hurting."

And she thought of him on Saturday morning, a fragile eggshell man, sleeping in the sunlight, looking at peace from the devastation she'd wrought. How his eyes were empty and lifeless, how she'd stolen his soul, how she'd betrayed the only man that mattered, and cracked their priceless marriage into a hundred pieces. She held their lives together in her hands now like a shattered vase, and any small unfortunate movement could have the shards misaligning, the former perfect shape crumpling, none of the broken edges touching, the whole thing tumbling to the floor to break into a thousand shards more.

The tears came, and she'd thought she'd cried herself empty this weekend. She hid in her hair and opened her purse, took out a tissue and dried her eyes.

Devlin said, "Are you crying?"

She shook her head no, but couldn't speak.

"I don't want you to cry, Kimmy. We were a good team. We had magic together."

You fucking ruined it!

He said, “Should we cancel the meeting?”

She scoffed. “What?”

“Are you going to be okay?”

“I’m fine.”

“I can pull over.”

She snapped her purse shut, glad of Devlin’s arrogance pushing away her sadness with pure hatred. “You can’t bully me like you bully Josh.”

“Because I care if you’re crying? I thought that made me compassionate. Apparently, it makes me a bully now.”

“It’s your tone. Your tone reveals your subtext. No one wants to challenge you on it, no one would dare to because they’re afraid of you. I’m not afraid of you.”

He drew a deep breath, his lips pursed. He let it out. “That’s why we had magic.”

“We don’t have magic anymore and you want to blame me because you think it’s fun to taunt someone with obvious untruths.”

Devlin chuckled, not mean or rueful, but amused. He said, “Kimmy, Kimmy, Kimmy. Wow, that gets me so hot. That’s every reason right there I wanted you in my life. Fuck, you are amazing.”

She turned to look at him for the first time, watched the sun slanting through the sunroof and lighting a line across the muscled ridge of his jaw. “Then why did you treat me like dirt? Why did you push me away?”

He shook his head, looked over his shoulder, changing lanes, saying, “I keep telling you I’m not the bad guy but you don’t listen. Everyone says I’m the asshole—but all I’m trying to do is grant everyone’s wishes, make everyone happy, make a good living, and bring dreams to life.”

She rolled her eyes and pinched the bridge of her nose.

Devlin said, “Are you crying again?”

“No.”

“Are you going to cry at the meeting?”

She looked over at him again, and this time his eyes met hers. He showed a small sympathetic smile. Then he said, “Are you going to fix your hair?”

“What do you mean?”

“You used to do it so nice. Pulled back, all shiny. This doesn’t look very professional.”

“It’s the way I used to wear my hair. It’s the way I wore it when you hired me.”

“I used to love walking into meetings with you behind me. It made my fucking dick hard the way the people we’re meeting would dart their eyes your way. My killer Kimmy. Kimmy Chang. You scared them. My black-eyed shark, my red-lipped blood drinker.”

“I’m not your fetish, Devlin. I’m not your exotic dragon lady you found in the Orient. So don’t fucking tell me how to do my hair or how to dress, or wear heels because you like heels.”

He drove in silence for almost a full minute before he said, “Did you tell Josh you’re with me today, that we’re driving downtown together, that we might even be out late tonight?”

“No. I didn’t.”

Devlin shook his head in slow wags, sighing. “Bad Kimmy. Bad, bad Kimmy.”



It was after seven when she finally got home, coming in the front door of their apartment, tossing down her keys, then lurching forward and holding the edge of the table under the photo of the Lungshan Temple. Her breaths came in shudders. Even home held no reprieve from her misery. Her hands trembled, and the tears pushed forward like water against a dam.

The apartment was dim, no smells of cooking, no TV on, no video games, none of her cherished comforts. She'd taken them for granted and traded them for wicked sex with a wicked man.

Flats slipped off, she wiped at her eyes with the backs of her hands, coming around the corner to the family room and finding Josh sitting at the kitchen pass-through, paperwork spread out, pen in hand, his expression grim. He said, "Hey."

"Hi."

"Do you want to have a seat?"

Her heart thudded and her lips wriggled. "Why?"

11

CONDITIONS

Kimmy's expression twisted to funereal mourning, her brows raised in sorrow, her lips trembling. He said, "We should talk. Do you want to get changed first?"

"Talk about what?"

He said, "What do you think?"

Now she looked around, her eyes lowered, filled with hurt, breath in short panting through her open mouth. "Okay," she said, voice tight and clipped, and sat on the stool next to him, her eyes turned to the paperwork.

He put down his pen and rubbed his face. He said, "Harmeet wants me to... Swanson wants me on the team for Rome. I gotta fill out all these forms."

Kimmy whispered, "What forms?"

He looked at her, and for the first time since she'd come through the door, he wondered if something terrible happened to her. She was bewildered. Out of it. Dumb.

"Are you okay?"

"Yeah," she said, peering at his paperwork.

He bit his lower lip, his heart hurting for her. "Did you see him at work today?"

She shook her head no.

“You sure you’re okay?”

She said, “What about Rome?”

“They’re moving me up. Well, I guess the team’s getting smaller, that’s what’s happening. I’m still on the team.”

“You’re going to Rome?” Again, her brows furrowed with worry.

“Yeah. I don’t know when. Soon, probably, and maybe more trips after that. . . . Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Yeah. When are you going?”

“I don’t know, Kimmy,” he said, changing the subject, facing her and holding her shoulders. “I don’t want to talk about Rome. I will later, but that’s not what I want to talk about.”

“What do you want to talk about?”

He looked her in the eye. “I want what you want. Those things you said when I got home. I heard them but I didn’t hear them. They sank in today. I want what you want. I want to start over. I want us to focus on our marriage.”

Her slim shoulders sagged under his palms. She turned her face up, looking almost doubtful, like this was a trick, like he would say this only to pull it away from her, to mock her. To bully her. “You do?”

“I do, Kimmy,” he said, and smiled a small smile, but a very real and honest one, one filled with hope and forgiveness.

She slipped off the stool, tears coming already, saying nothing and hugging her arms around him, too weak to squeeze him hard, but still filled with ardor and relief. He hadn’t expected her response to be so emotional, yet here she was, crying on his chest again. He held her close and loved the feel of her tears and her breath on his collar. He caressed her hair, smiling and looking across their apartment.



They went out for dinner at a new Bangladeshi place, and it was weird and awkward at first. So much bad had transpired between them, so much adulterated emotion, but they'd known each other for so long, had spent a lot of time in love; the love he felt for her was what gave his emotions their strength.

When they took their table, a booth by the window, Kimmy scooted in behind him and they sat together on the same side of the table, sharing a blue leather bench. Neither of them mentioned or made fun of how she'd done that—he couldn't recall her ever having done it before—but it warmed his heart knowing she'd done it because it made her feel good, and he liked to know that being close to him made his wife happy.

They ordered a half a chicken, a Lahori Charga, and Beef Bihari Kababs to share. He ordered a Coke, and Kimmy a Sprite. Kimmy held his hand after they ordered and were alone. He said, "I think the things we have to say would be more useful not being said. We've said it all in our own ways over the last two weeks and... Talking about it doesn't move us any further forward."

Kimmy nodded, not meeting his gaze, her eyes on the table. "Not saying them proves how much we want them lost in the past."

The place was empty on a late Monday night, UberEats drivers in and out, though, and he leaned close and kissed her forehead. Kimmy sagged against him, and he put his arm around her.



Kimmy snuggled in next to him in bed and he was relieved she faced away. If she'd pressured him for sex tonight, he'd have to reject her—and that might hurt her feelings. He wasn't there yet. Sexuality was the part of their battleship most damaged by their high seas encounter with Devlin Stone.

It felt better than sex to put his arm around her and have her wiggle herself tighter against him. After what they'd been through, sex might be a little while longer in renewing.

What if his sexual feelings for her never returned? Was that a possibility? He'd taken some sturdy hits. But what frightened him the most was his own fantasies, his own darkneses. Kimmy didn't deserve that, but what if no light could chase away his darkness?

The homey scent of curry and ginger in her hair. It reminded him so much of the time she spent after the miscarriage, puttering around the apartment, a barefoot homemaker. He'd come home to fresh homemade dumplings and a clean apartment and an open evening to spend time doing the things he liked to do.

The truth was there was still much to say about what happened and what should happen going forward. But he chickened out at dinner, enjoying too much Kimmy's devotion. Not wanting to upset it by beginning what might become a fraught argument: her continued position with Devlin at Stone Brokerage. How, seeing her upset, he'd said, "Did you see him at work today?" See who, Josh? Only your tormentor. The man who took advantage of your wife. Seduced her. The man who, in the aftermath of marital demolition, after finding Kimmy's panties in his couch, sent you a picture of Kimmy's naked thigh. Inner thigh.

It had to be Devlin who put those panties there.

He'd pretended Kimmy had planted them there for him to find. But she didn't do that, did she? Devlin did it. And because Kimmy wouldn't deny it, the truth was Devlin possessed her panties through terrible means. Kimmy couldn't tell him what those means were because she was ashamed.

What had she done?

Now he linked the two things together: 1. Devlin possessed Kimmy's panties and planted them where dipshit Josh would find them, knowing he would put dipshit Josh on that couch. 2. Devlin had a photo that showed Kimmy's inner thigh.

Was that how he had her panties?

He shifted, uncomfortable, and getting heated with that notion. Strange, sleazy fantasies swirled: Kimmy telling Devlin she was teasing Josh, and Devlin saying let me take some racy pictures and Kimmy falling for it because she wanted to tease her husband, falling prey to Devlin Stone. The photo shoot progresses and Devlin corrupts the innocent wife, coaxing her into believing her husband would go wild for this, urging her to remove her panties. Or at first, just ease them aside a little, let me get a shot that shows part of that beautiful pussy.

How would he know what her pussy looked like, that it was beautiful? And Kimmy wasn't some country bumpkin just arrived in the city from a bus out of the sticks. She wouldn't pose for a picture like that unless she wanted to.

Did she want to?

Fuck. He was getting hard now.

But, yeah, that's the only way Devlin would get a photo like that, unless she was sleeping.

Or fucked unconscious by his monster cock; orgasmed into oblivion, her poor little pussy left beaten and abused and worn out with hot pleasure.

He shifted his hips back, his arousal turning to iron stiffness now. A week ago, after thinking like this, he'd prompt Kimmy with some dirty talk, and they could play around, and she would say awful things that would knock his socks off. Tonight he wouldn't bother her, had no desire to. In fact, the idea of sex with her disturbed him. Like how his sexuality was demented, and he'd convinced her of its value. He wished he could take it all back. Wished Kimmy had never seen that part of him.

They just needed some time to heal, to come closer, to respect one another again. He had to chase away the desire to know what had happened between Kimmy and Devlin. Maybe she would tell him one day, but he didn't think she would. Would he ever be able to let that go, though? It was an incredible challenge. If his marriage was worth it, he would meet that challenge.

Somewhere in another room, his phone chimed. He'd left it in the family room, by the couch where they'd watched TV together after dinner—where he cherished spending alone time with Kimmy, not saying much, but appreciating her presence, the comfort of her closeness. Building back a friendship before taking the next step up.

It had to be after eleven. Kimmy had fallen asleep.

Who texted at this time? He was conditioned now to hear that chime like some sexual siren, a Pavlovian lure to perversion.

He hadn't responded to the first text because he was too smart now to get duped by that fucking asshole. This would be another trick, another taunt, another way for him to endure a terrible, sleepless night. Or it could be Harmeet. Something about Italy.

It wasn't Harmeet. Not at this time of night.

Although, moving up came with greater responsibilities. More hours to cover those responsibilities.

But it wasn't Harmeet.

His phone repeated the chime, and he eased back from Kimmy, getting out of bed without disturbing her. He snuck out of the bedroom, going out backwards, watching Kimmy sleep as he closed the door behind him. But in the hall, he came to his senses. Don't be so stupid. You know who's sending the text. Why do this to yourself?

Yet, he padded on, moving quiet in their apartment like he was sneaking up on his phone, like maybe he could sneak-check it and Devlin would never

know he'd even looked.

He checked his phone and sure enough, it wasn't Harmeet. It was the unknown number and the beginning of the text.

I know why you didn't respond and I—

And I what?

He cursed under his breath and opened the text. Again, a flash of skin, Kimmy's inner thigh—and for a split second, he felt the pang of disappointment. Fuck. He was disappointed it was the same photo?

He didn't even want to open the text and now he's disappointed it was the same photo and not a new one.

But it wasn't the same old photo. And he hated the lusty relief that provoked. He read the text instead, not scrolling enough to reveal the entire image. Not yet. The hurt and the excitement were palpable.

I know why you didn't respond, and I don't blame you. You've convinced yourself the photo isn't real.

No, he thought the photo was real. But maybe not, right? No, that wasn't true. He didn't know the photo was real. Even if it was Kimmy, if it zoomed out, it could be Kimmy in shorts, Kimmy in a bikini in Cayman. All meant to taunt him.

Or it could be from the day he took her panties and kept them.

The photo's real. The hard part is convincing you I mean no harm.

Yeah, right. Your best buddy always sent you secret racy pics they snapped of your wife.

I want you to be excited. Look, I know you're excited. I know you saw the picture, and you didn't stop Kimmy from going to work today.

You didn't see her today, asshole. This was more ruse. More manipulation. Why was he even reading this shit?

You don't hate the picture. You want to see more. How could you not?

That was true. That was one thing he said that made sense.

But I'm not sending more than this one. I can't. I'm not sending anything vulgar, and don't ask for a picture of her face. I wouldn't do that to her, wouldn't risk having it out in the ether. Too damaging for someone with so much to offer.

What an honorable man. Oh wow, what a real gent.

He scrolled now, his heart absolutely thundering behind his ribs.

“Oh my god.”

It wasn't the same pic. Well, it was, but it had panned higher up Kimmy's thigh. He fell to sit on the couch with a heavy whomp.

I want you to see it as much as you do, Josh. I swear. But eyes only, Josh.

Meet me.

12

DEVIL'S HOUR

The photo was lurid. It was shocking.

Corner to corner again, taking up the entire screen, 1920 x 1080, Full HD, pure erotic, unambiguous Kimmy flesh. The flesh no one saw. The sensitive, nerve ending sensual flesh high up under her skirt. Even covered by a bikini bottom. Skin in the colour of honey or cream caramel. The curve of her leg evident in the garish over-lighting, the flesh tone obliterated to a pale yellowy-white. What raced his heart and exploded his sour lust were the darker tones of flesh. The browner tones of russet, the expanse of private skin where the surface was pockmarked by tiny humps. Hair follicles. The places where his wife groomed. And god, oh fucking god, one thin black curl entering from off-frame; one of Kimmy's pubic hairs.

He groaned with pure, hurting bewilderment. Someone in the world who wasn't Josh Waters had taken a photo of Kimmy's pussy.

He touched the edge of the screen, stroked the pad of his thumb along a hurtful section of pixelated pain. The skin here showed browner, but also somehow blossomed a blushing pinkish hue. And the flesh here—he swallowed with difficulty—the flesh here was smooth as glass; no bumps, no blemishes, no follicles. Points and little archipelagoes of pure shimmering white glowed here. Glowed from wetness. Reflected back to the camera nothing but white. These were sex membranes. The flesh of her pussy.

A small squeaky prepubescent voice from his high school anatomy class whispered the phrase labia majora. Whatever the term, no one should have a photo of this part of Kimmy. He dropped the phone to his chest and

collapsed back in the couch. He opened and closed his hands, the fingers stiff and icy cold now.

The whole thing was impossible. He looked around the room, like he would come out of some spell and find he'd only drifted off to dreamland. Or nightmare land.

He whispered curses of disbelief, getting up, throwing his disgusting phone into a couch cushion, then standing there with handfuls of his hair like a man on the verge of insanity. What the fuck?

Then he was going down the hall, headed to the bedroom, opening the door and peeking in. Kimmy still slept, curled up in bed on her side and lit in nighttime lunar blue. Sleep of the innocent. She looked at peace, and seeing her that way warmed his heart. Instead of rage, instead of infidelity-fueled madness, he felt sympathy. He felt sorry for her.

He wanted to comfort her.

Now a sick and greasy compunction seized him. His badness, his dirty fantasies had pushed his wife into dark territory.

How had it come to this?

Not once had he ever wanted Kimmy to sleep with Devlin, and yet, after the taunts began, he drew closer and closer to admitting something that he wasn't even guilty of. He was being punished for a crime he hadn't even wanted to commit. It was like Devlin had organized a heist and roped him into manning the getaway car, sitting outside with the alarms ringing and cursing himself for ever being talked into it, and now in the aftermath he was heading off to do five-to-ten maximum security in Millhaven. And Devlin walked away with all the cash.

He leaned on the wall outside the bedroom door and breathed into his hands. He'd never asked for it, never desired it, but to say he wasn't guilty was the ameliorating phrase of his legal defense. Because seeing a photo of Kimmy's pussy had him aching hard. His cock throbbed, his breath came in

slow, tight squeezes. His heart raced. His mind raced. He wanted to rush back to his phone and look at the photo again. He wanted an orgasm.

This had to be a joke. It had to be a prank.

Devlin was a bully. A tormentor of the grandest scale.

Right now, he's laughing at you.

This is funny to him.

Devlin Stone could have any woman he wanted; he only wants Kimmy to fuck with you. And why? Because it amuses him.

Get your shit together.

Now he headed back to the couch and retrieved his phone. He looked at the photo again, this time with his jaw tight and hard, his brow lowered like he was Jason Statham, fighting against the mighty erotic pull of the photo's lurid coloring, the pure suggestion implicit in its sending. He looked through it, looked past it.

It was fake. It had to be. All the events leading here were a caper, not a heist. Devlin wasn't stealing Kimmy, that wasn't the prize, Devlin was chasing the extreme, psychopathic amusement he achieved in taunting other men. Men he thought lesser than him. That was how he built his ego. That was how Devlin Stone got his jollies.

He chewed his cheek, worried a canine over his lower lip.

Then he was stalking the hallway again, headed back to the bedroom with a brand new purpose, phone in hand.

Is that Kimmy's knee or not? Is it her pussy? Did Devlin find some photo online that he was sure looked like it could be Kimmy's? How would he know what Kimmy's pussy looked like?

A guess?

Then he could picture that neanderthal googling “Asian pussy,” laughing to himself at how easy it was to trick a meek man eager to always believe the worst.

Now he was slipping into the bedroom, knowing this was a terrible idea, but he was a man on a mission.

Kimmy slept facing the window, the moon painting her in pale shades of blue. He crept to the edge of the bed, mind racing, knowing he should have an excuse prepared if she woke up and caught him, but not having the time to pause and suss one out.

Kimmy made it easy for him, on her side, one leg straight, top leg bent, knee forward and near the edge of the bedding. He peeled the comforter back, then the sheet, eyes darting from the knee to her face, wary of any fluttering of her eyelashes. She still slept. She still slept, and he’d bared her knee.

He opened the first photo again and moved the image around so the knee took up the majority of his phone’s screen. He moved the screen in close proximity to his wife’s knee for a surreptitious side-by-side comparison.

It was ridiculous. What he was doing was ridiculous.

The moonlight wasn’t strong enough to illuminate every detail of her knee. It looked like her knee. It looked exactly like her knee, but a midnight comparison was a waste of time. When he’d first seen the photo, he knew right away it was Kimmy’s knee. Then he’d tricked his brain into thinking it was only a timid picture of his wife’s leg made to look more salacious than it was. Now he saw it wasn’t timid at all. It was the real deal, and now his brain sought any way to back pedal out of this terrifying scenario.

For a long, enduring moment of awful time, true defeat weighed on his shoulders, seeking to press him right down on the ground. What kept him alive and fighting on his feet was brutal lechery.

A strong urge seized him now to take that knee and spread it to the other side, open his wife’s legs and then push her panties aside. Yeah, she’d wake

up and protest and demand to know what the hell he was doing, but in this case he could tell her with shimmering paladin virtue that if she knew what was best for her, she would spread those legs and let him examine her pussy. And guilty Kimmy would let him. She'd open her legs and cry and look up at the ceiling as her husband confirmed she had a lover who took a photograph of her most private space.

He stood panting bedside like a sex maniac, with his lips sucked between his teeth, huffing raunchy breaths, looking at Kimmy's thigh and fighting the urge to actually do it. He stepped back, retreated across the room, never removing his eyes from Kimmy's bare beautiful knee, sexy, sinewy grace and fine bone perfection.

His cock twitched and spasmed and his breaths came in sobbing chugs. He hid in the bathroom and locked the door.

There was no way and no where to escape the torture. It chased him even when his eyes were closed. How could he sleep, how could he breathe, how could he fucking exist like this?

Why had he ever engaged with Devlin Stone?

He texted in return.

Josh: This could be anybody. Don't treat me like I'm stupid.

Then he sat down on the tile floor, hugging his phone to his chest, hoping to god no one ever got back to him, that he'd chased Devlin away. And yet he found comfort and maybe even strange excitement knowing this wasn't the end, that Devlin would text back, and Devlin would prove it further. Prove it with something a magnitude more damaging to his fragile psyche.

He lit his screen up again and looked at the second photo. The worst one. Looked at that slick expanse of skin right next to her vagina and he thought

of Devlin seeing it. Thought of Devlin Stone getting such a juicy view of Josh's wife's perfect pussy. And why was Kimmy so wet? Had he fucked her? Maybe the rest of the photo would show her sagging hole and puffy, just-fucked labia, and a copious flow of Devlin's thick white semen crawling down to Kimmy's tiny asshole.

"Fuck," he hissed and shut his screen black, looking up at the familiar ceiling of his master bathroom.

The curiosity provoked more unwanted images, coming in a flood now. He did nothing to stem the flow, just let them spurt like arterial blood, like his life was ebbing from him. Devlin fingering Kimmy's pussy, his big aggressive hand between her legs, his large fingers, his big knuckles, masculine veins and black hair. Fucking Kimmy's pussy against Kimmy's better judgment, two or three fingers plunging hard and fast, slick sounds of over-lubrication, her wet pussy teeming around his vile intrusion. Kimmy gasping, crying, hating how a man she despised could give her pleasure she'd never imagined before. . . . Oh, fuck. Squirting. Kimmy letting go because Devlin's mastery over her supple sex membranes proved too much. Tinkling high, pattering over Devlin's expensive suit, hollering out with her voice tightened by endless shame as an unwanted orgasm tore through her. Finger-fucking her pussy, then after she'd come, shoving one big wet finger in her anus and pushing her through a crazy anal orgasm, riding it right on top of her first orgasm like a monster truck, making Kimmy wild and sex-crazed and out of her mind with passion. Devlin not washing his hand, Devlin getting Josh to smell his finger, smell his own wife's pussy and ass on her boss's fingers while her boss's friends snickered behind his back. A little-dick chump whose wife got some grade-A extramarital fucking on her lunches. Devlin telling his friends how Josh's wife was a squirter. Rumble requesting the Asian stripper at the club, rubbing it in Josh's face and they'd all joke about it later.

His cock ached like never before, but when he put his hand down and cupped it over the fabric, he recoiled with disgust.

He couldn't touch himself. He wouldn't masturbate to this. To do so would be evil, would be careless or even uncaring. Unloving. Jerking off to his wife's subjugated objectification, to her violation, would mean he hated her.

And he didn't hate her. For some reason, he swore he might love her now more than ever before.

Now he just tightened his thighs and his stomach, rocking his butt on the floor, trying to coax the orgasm closer but without touching himself. Everything below his belly button felt inflated to bursting—but like a balloon that just won't pop, like trying to blow up a hot water bottle by huffing into it.

He curled into the shape of a question mark, his body twisted in sexual agony. His shorts were wet with pre-come and he could feel an unending slithering of wet sexual excitement from his urethra. His legs shuddered, and he whimpered a small sound of frustrated pain.

When his phone chimed again, he bobbled it, the sound jolting him out of his torment with a sudden jolt of electric thrill. The chime could mean so much. So much more. He almost hoped it was the worst thing imaginable, something that would end the questioning. The questioning uncertainty could kill him. It could break his heart or race it into cataclysm.

A photo of Devlin fucking her. A photo of Devlin's fingers stuffed into Kimmy's tight pussy, her labia hugging for dear life, glistening wet with forbidden pleasure. A pornographic panorama: Kimmy's thighs spread wide as he'd seen them, only she's on her back on Devlin's chest, and in this picture you could see Devlin's giant wrist-thick cock inside Kimmy's pussy, stretching it and filling it like no other man could ever do—especially not her husband.

He bucked and shuddered this time, and the orgasm almost seized him, but slipped away again like a taunting wood fairy, teasing him, but disappearing into the brush like a hesitant sneeze.

He opened his phone to see another text. A response to his rejection.

It could be anyone, but you know it's Kimmy. You're not stupid. How could you not recognize her? If you want to see the whole picture, then meet me.

He whimpered again and bit his own knuckle, writhing in sexual torsion on his bathroom floor. But at last, with shaking hands, he responded to the text.

Josh: When?

13

CINCH

She chanced a kiss on Josh's shoulder, over his T-shirt, and was relieved when he didn't recoil. His back was to her, the morning light coming through their apartment window and casting her shadow on his back. She retreated before she pressured him too much, but her hand remained, palm rubbing up-and-down lines between his shoulder blades.

"Time to get up," she whispered. "You awake?"

"I'm awake," he said.

"You want breakfast?"

She got the sense he nodded. He was still sullen, quiet, morose, and her lips sucked in between her teeth, dimpling as she onboarded this bad news. Would he ever wake up happy again? Hopeful? In love with her, turning around to kiss her, get playful, fool around? Of course, it was Tuesday, a workday. At least Devlin was gone until Friday. She wouldn't see him for the next three days, which was a great relief. After last night, she'd hoped for a more buoyant morning, one where her Josh would show her his boyish charm, his happy expression.

When he turned, his expression was the opposite. She said, "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," he said, voice gravel dry.

"You don't look well," she said, frowning with concern and putting the back of her hand to his forehead.

“I didn’t sleep,” he said, then covered his face with his hands, breathing into them in heavy scores.

She nodded, pursing her lips again. It was her. She’d done this. Just when he’d reconciled in his mind their past and their future, he’d lain sleepless last night, fretting what they both hoped they could forget.

“I have such a fucking headache.”

“Your voice sounds terrible, too. I think you’re coming down with something, Josh. Your immune system got wiped out traveling.”

He groaned and rubbed his forehead and his eyes. She told him to take it easy, and she’d get him an ibuprofen.

“Make it two,” he groaned as she got out of bed. “And can you bring me an ice pack, too, please?”

Just having him need her, even for a small and mundane task, made her feel so happy and welcome. She returned to the bedroom with both items and a bottle of water and found him in the same position, lying on his back under the covers with greater autumn light filling the room, his hands still on his face. She slipped back into bed. Josh took the pills and drank them down, and she arranged the ice pack on his forehead, protecting his skin with a clean kitchen towel.

“Do you want toast? Can I make you something?”

“This is good,” he sighed, just his mouth visible from under the ice pack. “How did you sleep?”

She said fine, but the truth was better than fine. She’d been so run down with guilt and worry and a hurting heart that when Josh released her from some of it last night, she’d passed out and slept through the whole night.

“Do you want to stay home? I can stay home, too.”

“No, no. I have to go in. I’ll be fine. I had a terrible night, is all. I’m not sick.”

“Have a hot bath. You want me to rub your back?” To tempt him, she squeezed his collar, thumb going in gentle circles. He rolled toward her and her heart soared. She put an arm over him. He said, “Maybe you could...”

He didn’t finish, only mumbled a nonsensical sound.

“What was that?”

Into her chest, he said, “This is going to sound— psh, never mind.”

“No, tell me, please. What do you need?”

His voice was quiet, timid. “What you did... What you did for me the other night...?”

“Really?” First thing in the morning before work?

“You don’t have to.”

“I want to, baby. I’d love to. You want me to do it in the bath for you?”

“No, I’m going to have a shower.”

“It’ll be nice and warm.”

He groaned and whimpered, annoyed with himself and his lecherous request. “I don’t want to make a big deal out of it. I have to get ready for work.”

She kissed his ear, rubbed his back, then let him go, backing out of the bed, saying, “Let me get a towel and some lotion.”

He grunted an affirmative and shifted in the covers, pulling them up to his ear, eyes closed like he’d try to grab another minute of sleep while she went into the bathroom.

It would seem like he didn’t want to have sex with her. That’s what the request amounted to. He could have rolled her on her back and they could have made love before they ate, but her husband wanted an impersonal

hand job. But it didn't have to be impersonal. She would make it amazing for him. Make it an act of love. Though, did Josh not want to have sex with her because he thought she was dirty? Like she was damaged goods? Did he assume she'd had sex with Devlin or just fooled around? She didn't even know what he really believed because he refused to talk about it. Which, as a fortunate benefit, worked in her favor. But nothing moving forward should be for her benefit. She should be punished. And she didn't mind being punished as long as Josh stayed by her side. There was one thing she was sure of: she would do anything to atone for her sins.

She returned to bed with coconut lotion this time—the petroleum jelly had proved too messy—and a used bath towel, and slipped back into bed. As she prepared the stage for a hand job, she said, “I'd do anything else, too, Josh. It doesn't have to be this.”

He opened one quivering eye, looking injured by the morning light. “I have a headache, I just... I just want some relief. I'm so fucking stressed.”

“Yeah, yeah,” she said, obedient and dutiful, getting right back to it. “I just want you to know that. Ask me for anything you want. You don't have to be... You can just put it out there.”

Josh moved an arm under the covers, shoving his shorts down, making chuffing sounds of disgust. “I'm such an embarrassment,” he grumbled.

Her voice was airy and hopeful. “Don't say that. Let me do this for you.”

His cock wasn't even hard. She'd expected him to have woken with morning wood and that's why he'd requested this release. But, no, he was shriveled. She managed to coat his penis with the lotion, then began to work her fingertips in a stroking motion on the head of his penis. It took a moment, but it began to grow. When she could grip his shaft, she did, stroking him nice and slow, and wishing now she'd opted for the petroleum jelly for a slower, slithering experience.

When he was erect, his whole demeanor changed: he sagged and relaxed, his breaths coming heavy—like he was relieved just to have achieved hardness. There was an added complication now, though. Her thighs flexed

in time with her stroke. She imagined his hardness put to better use. Like rolling to her back as she'd imagined earlier and having Josh make love to her. Though her sexuality had been lashed to the weighty anchor of Devlin's manipulations, plummeted to the frigid depths of betrayal's ocean, it was still alive and wanting and needing. She hadn't had sex in over two weeks. Hadn't had it but wanted it. Stark emotions during that time made it easy to assuage, but having your husband's erection in your hand made it impossible to quell passion. And this was the second time. Her own interior began to sweat and her breaths came heavier, matching Josh's pace. The tightening and flexing of her thighs and pelvic floor increased. Soon she ached to have him. Her core demanded him. His head was tucked to her collar while she stroked his cock, coconut wafting from under the bedding, and it hurt to know she couldn't ask him for sex. She wouldn't put the pressure on him. It wasn't just a noble gesture; she feared rejection. So she kissed his ear, and scratched nails on his scalp, pretending she was kissing him by mouthing her lips on his auricle. It only made her want him more.

The truth was that the best thing for him, the healthiest thing for his recovery, was to make love to her. She was sure he hid his face in her clavicle because he could close his eyes and think of all those strange darkneses that turned his crank—thoughts she'd helped nurture. She parted her thighs, lifted a leg over his, opening herself to his touch if he was bold enough. But he didn't take it, just lay curled against her, his hips tucked rearward enough his penis was barely presented to her. She had to dig into the cave of his body to stroke it.

She humped her hips toward his, a rhythm of lovemaking, coaxing him into the mood, letting him know she was horny and aroused and wanting him. When he made no move, she whispered, "I want you so bad right now," but he only grunted in response. She kissed his ear. "Please, give it to me, just a little, Josh. I need you."

He rolled his head on her collar, and only frustrated grunts and groans followed.

"It's okay," she said, regret hurting her heart as she felt his hardness subside in her grip. "I just want you to come. No stress, no pressure, baby, I swear, just come." She stroked and tightened her grip, aching for his hardness to

return, cursing her own selfishness for chasing it away. But she'd only wanted sex to nourish her husband, to feed him healthy whole love.

Voice tight and bothered, he said into her neck, "My head is pounding, Kimmy."

"Never mind, just come for me, Josh. I want to make you come. You can touch me if it helps. I'd like it. Touch me, baby." She humped her hips toward him, her leg locked over his.

There were terrible words on her lips, words she would never say again, but words she knew would work for him right now. They were the words Josh craved. She could tease him about Devlin, say something nasty about the shape of his huge penis when he'd shown it to her, or even worse. God, she could say so much worse. Some of the nastiest things imaginable. True things. Things that would release Josh in this moment but would lock him up even tighter in whatever masochistic chains he'd shrouded himself in. If she found the courage to say those words, he would even thank her, she was sure of it. She could tell him how Devlin doesn't want hand jobs, he only wants to fuck. That men with big cocks want to use them like a man uses a cock. Boys wanted hand jobs, little boys with small penises who were ashamed of their endowment. Small men with small penises lay under the covers and got their little dickies jerked. Men like Devlin fucked and fucked hard and deep, and they touched parts inside a woman the woman never knew would ignite such—

Josh touched her thigh, and she cooed with pleasure, responded to his touch with honest but amplified enthusiasm. His palm caressed her haunch and hip, and she tilted her pelvis so he could get the easiest access to her pussy.

But he didn't touch her there. When his hand swept between her parted thighs, he caressed the back of his hand against her inner thigh flesh. It brought his breaths quicker and heavier. His wiggly member began to stiffen and she couldn't help a happy smile from appearing, her husband's passion for her renewed. He got hard and her grip went slipperier with slick excitement. She wanted to say encouraging things, how she loved his touch, how she wanted him to be with her, to put his hardness in her, but she wouldn't heap more pressure on him right now, wouldn't want to bully his

hardness into retreat. So she told him only with her breathing, with her labored and excited breaths, choked with passion; a woman who loved her husband's touch, a woman who loved commanding her husband's hardness.

He caressed her thigh, then ran his fingertips close to her pant edge, exploring the smooth flesh there. She slowed her stroke a second, distracted, convinced he would slip a hand beneath her panties and touch her pussy, touch her where she was hot and wet right now. But he didn't. His touch concentrated on exploring a small section of real estate right next to her source of sexual frustration. God, she wanted him inside her so bad. Wanted to be impaled, wanted to be filled and to have her canal spread and reamed and batted by lust.

He groaned into her neck again, his breath dampened by his proximity to release, and she swore he'd murmured words. She quickened her stroke, just wanting him to be relieved of whatever sexual burden lay heavy on his shoulders this morning. He said it again.

"Hurt me."

"What?"

"P-punish me," he said, his body trembling.

"What— what do you want?" She frowned, eyes toward the ceiling, sure she'd misheard him.

"Please, Kimmy, hurt me, hit me, make me hurt."

"No, Josh, no way." She hugged her arm over him, held him close, wishing he would ejaculate.

"Hit my balls. Squeeze them."

"No, baby, no," she said, and now it was her whimpering and frustrated, hugging Josh harder, knowing it was she who should be punished.

14

PLASTIC

Instead of hurting the man she loved, her mouth opened and for a second she almost blurted dirty talk, trying to distract him. Play back the scene where Devlin had showed her his big dick, and she had told Josh and she had showed Devlin her bare breast. That would soar Josh in an orthogonal line, take him on a tangent.

But she couldn't do that.

She wouldn't do that.

That game was done and dead and buried.

So she slipped her hugging arm away, her features pinched in a harrowing twist, knowing she'd so abused this loving man that mistreatment felt good to him. She slipped a second hand under the covers, still stroking his cock, wishing he would just please come already, and she patted his scrotum with the backs of her fingers. Josh jerked and whimpered and his cock slipped from her slick coconut smelling grip. She found his cock again, stiff and straight and hard as steel. Josh urged her: "Harder, Kimmy, please."

She batted him again, getting him to whimper, but still he urged her, "Harder."

Her stroking hand squeezed his cock like she wanted to crush it and her stroke tripled in speed. She turned her eyes to the heavens and sought forgiveness from anyone up there who might oversee this awful act; then she grabbed his balls and clutched them tight.

Josh panted and gasped and he was on the edge of coming. She gripped them tighter still and gave a clockwise turn. With mock disgust, she said, “Hurry up and come already, I have to get to work.”

Josh went through a series of shuddering and jerking like a speeding junker breaking down on the highway, blowing rods and pistons and bursting the radiator as the tires went soggy and out of round. Then his cock lunged toward her as he thrust his hips forward. He ejaculated. Her grip went watery and loose and she felt his seed pattering on her shirt, launching so hard it bypassed the towel, even dropping warm wet lines on her inner forearm. Relief flooded her. That it was over, that Josh had his relief, that she didn’t have to punish him anymore—not when it was his wife who deserved the worst.

His orgasm raged on and on and his semen kept spurting. He squeezed her inner thigh, and she hissed with delight—then he cupped a hand right over her pussy and she cried out with erotic joy. Her knees rolled inward, her heels bowed out; she flexed thigh muscles, trapping his hand in place, enjoying the incredible pleasure Josh felt from release transferred from his body through his arm and hand and into her own sex. She went liquid wet, her panties damp where Josh’s palm connected.

Josh’s orgasm left them both panting and gasping for breath, and they lay together like that for a minute, Josh’s penis shrinking in her hand, her thigh-grip on his hand subsiding. He offered her no pleasure, even though with a little persistence she could be hoisted over the orgasm hurdle and find her own release. But she didn’t even deserve it.

Again he hid his face from her, burying it in her collar and she held her hands out, one coated in semen. Josh worked his shorts back up, rolled away, and she cleaned her hands on the towel. Josh watched her and when she turned to face him, he didn’t smile, his face blank, his eyes lost and empty. She smiled and cupped his cheek. “I hope you feel better.”

His mouth worked around, unassertive, but yet with something to say.

She showed him a more serious expression, but one of sympathy. “I didn’t want you to hurry up, you know, because I have to work. I just, I just said

that. You know...”

At last he spoke, his wet eyes finding hers. “Tell me— Tell me what you did. Tell me what you did with him.”

She recoiled with fright, not expecting it, her hand retreating from his cheek and tucking under her own. Her heart raced and her eyes went wet like his. “What? I... I thought—”

Josh shook his head like he was snapping out of a daze, recoiling from her now, too. He blabbered, “No, don’t tell me, no, don’t. Sorry, sorry, I just... I don’t want to know. I don’t even know why I said that.” He got right out of bed, and his eyes were wild and bewildered.

“It’s okay, Josh, don’t go.” She reached out a hand for him to return to bed with her.

But he didn’t. He left like he was ashamed and scared and went into the bathroom. She rubbed her own forehead, feeling an ache taking hold, both of them ruined by what had transpired over the summer. Soon, she heard the shower running.



When Josh had come out of the shower later, dressed for work in a suit and tie, he’d acted like everything was fine and nothing weird had happened in their bed when they woke up. She had to be glad for that. She’d made him a fried egg sandwich on a bagel, but he said he couldn’t eat. She could barely eat, too. But it was the drive into work that crushed her. Her stomach ached, her head ached, her shoulders were tight and sore, her temples pulsed like beating hammers with her heartbeat. She was sad and angry and depressed and hurting and hopeful and, most of all, horny. Horny like crazy. Horny and unfulfilled and needing and desiring. It was a selfish feeling she hated. Sex was something she didn’t want to think about for a long, long time. But

as much as her brain pushed sex away, her body craved it. Jerking Josh off had ignited it. Having his hand clamped on her pussy when she was wet was amazing. But it was the threat of dirty talking that put the tightness in her back and neck. It was wrong and wicked and terrible. But knowing what to say to Josh to get him to ejaculate wouldn't escape her memory. She would always know there were shady little kinks lurking in her husband's length. Dirty, dirty things that turned him on, and had come to turn her on too. She'd pulsed her thighs for the whole hour's drive into Toronto on the 401. By the time she got to the office, she'd considered going to the bathroom and masturbating, but the quick fix that would provide wasn't exciting. While she'd read contracts and researched companies, she'd fantasized a small idea right into fruition.

Now here she was on her lunch break, not even hungry, even though she'd skipped breakfast, driving a half block north from the office to a store she'd seen a few times but had never gone into. She'd had lunch more than once across the street at the Yungshang Rice Noodle.

A sex store. A store for perverts. A shop plugged into an old 1950s drive-up plaza nestled between modern high-rises. A North Toronto throwback. The store was almost empty mid-day, just two staff and one other customer, fortunately a woman, a little younger than her, white, dressed in office clothing. She'd assumed the role of the casual browser, not really interested in anything in particular, perusing all the shop's wares with equal impassivity. But now she was where she wanted to be and her heart was racing and she had a strong sexual urge, as hungry and pleading as if she was about to have sex. She was turned on like crazy, eyes roaming a collection of upright dildos. She'd even picked one up, an unthreatening seven inch dildo in a pale blue. Not even lifelike, just a satisfying phallic shape. Then she'd seen it was glow-in-the-dark, and the idea of having toxicity inside her body had her shelving it. Then it was a bright pink model she had, seven inches again, carrying it between thumb and finger, noncommittal, squishing air from one cheek to the other, like maybe she didn't want anything today at all and this was just whim shopping. But the swath of flesh-like dildos stopped her. They were ugly and garish and almost threatening in their masculinity, and that was what she wanted. She

put the bright pink one back. It looked like a toy. She wanted a cock. A big, hard cock like a man would have.

Her head went light and airy when she realized she was really going to do this, really going to buy a real-looking fake cock and orgasm on it. Her stomach went light and fluttered with butterflies. She picked up one that had a cock head that called out to her with its large urethra and swooping, plump shape. Eight inches. Eight thick inches. Then there was a nine-inch one. The head shape not as appealing, more prow-like, but this dildo was proportioned long, and she liked length. And the nine-inch one proclaimed its “thrusting action.” It must have gears or something that would make the shaft move back and forth. Wow, multi-speed. God, it was such a hot-looking cock, though. Thick veins and massive balls and it came with a remote control. Did they have ones where the balls moved inside the scrotum? Or skin that moved on the shaft? Probably not. But this thrusting model was \$250. Price wasn’t really an issue. But then down at the end of the aisle she saw it: the ugliest, meanest, manliest one in the whole store. Twelve inches. Not just beautiful veins, but these veins looked like they were under the skin, and were colored a gray-blue. Like real cock veins. Her hands shook while she held the plastic packaging, admiring it. It looked like Devlin’s. Not quite, but enough her thighs trembled. Twelve inches, including the base. Big balls. It was so huge, so long. Every wrinkle and blemish had been sculpted and painted. It didn’t thrust, but there was no doubt in her mind this was what she needed. Like, needed.

The two sales girls were together at the counter and she felt ashamed, like they were judging her; skinny Asian woman buying a ridiculously huge white man’s cock, and her face went hot. She fumbled cash out of her pocket, a hundred-eighty, and passed it over. The one sales girl was showing the other how to work the cash like it was a training day, going over the monster King Cock package, back and forth, looking for the UPC or whatever they needed, and she was sure they were fucking with her. For the first time in weeks she wished she’d worn one of her newer suits, worn her heels and stood six-feet tall with her face painted and her hair slicked into a bun. These girls would hop to and not dare shame her. But today she shrugged like a meek mouse, saying, “Bachelorette gift. I don’t want to get her, you know?”

Two weeks ago they would have begged her to let them gift wrap it for free.



After lunch, Josh made his decision and called Meyer at work.

“Why haven’t you answered my texts?”

“I’ve been busy. Look, Swanson wants to move me up, like go to Rome again.”

“Oh, that’s good, right?”

“Yeah, of course.”

In the quiet moment after he answered, something obvious hung in the air: Meyer wondering if his cousin Josh was calling to ask him to spy on his wife again.

So he moved on, saying, “It’s great news. I don’t know when they’re sending me, but I think somehow I impressed them.”

“Well, first time for everything.”

“Hilarious.”

“Everything good?”

“Yeah. Working it out.”

“Can you meet me?”

“When?”

“I’m super busy right now, but meet me for a beer.”

“For sure, for sure. Not tonight, but yeah.”

“How about Friday?”

“Uh, no. No, Friday’s no good. But, hey, it’s kind of why I’m calling. I, uh... Can I tell Kimmy I’ll be hanging out with you on Friday?”

“Uh, yeah. But you’re not hanging out with me?”

“No, no.”

“You’re telling Kimmy that?”

“Right.”

Meyer breathed into the phone a moment, then: “Where are you really going to be?”

“I’d rather not say. I’m just going out.”

Another long pause where he listened to his cousin breathing. Meyer knew old Joshy wouldn’t be going out with some other woman. He’d suspect who Josh might visit without telling Kimmy. “Josh, don’t... You’re not going to do anything crazy, are you?”

“No, Meyer, no,” he said, monotone, not adamant enough to dissuade his cousin’s horrific imagination.



There was no other place to do what she needed to do. Not in Toronto. She wouldn’t do it at the office. Glass walls and shared bathrooms. She looked up through her windshield at the blank windows of Devlin’s apartment. She had the key and Devlin was in Kingston.

GHOSTS & SPIRITS

What a ridiculous thing to do, but still, it was the best option. She closed Devlin's apartment door behind her and listened, standing in the foyer unmoving. He was in Kingston today, but the man's presence had bloomed into a large and foreboding thing in her life, and he always felt near. It would be like him to expect she would come to his apartment to masturbate, hiding in the closet to step out at the most opportune moment and surprise her.

But the place was a tomb. Empty and lifeless, lights off, cool and air-conditioned. She slipped off her flats and went into his kitchen, going to the fridge and opening the door, like if he were watching right now he'd see an old comrade just stopping by to use his place to grab a bite. Then she wandered, going into the living room, everything neat and tidy, nothing left out, no empty pop cans or video games. Down the hall, to the bedroom, poking her head in, making sure she was truly alone.

Seeing the apartment empty this way, devoid of human existence, standing on the bedroom's threshold, reminded her of the time he'd fucked her from behind and she was sure the real estate woman had seen them. She smiled and shook her head, reliving the badness, the wickedness, almost disbelieving it was her in that erotic memory. But it was. It surely was. She'd watched herself in the mirror, Devlin with his hands on her hips, pounding her from behind with that huge cock. She'd come so hard that day.

Now she was moving again, going quicker in bare feet down the hall, returning to the foyer and doffing her fall jacket. Into the kitchen with the noisy plastic bag from the sex shop under an arm, opening the drawer where she'd find the scissors. She removed the package from the bag and

lay it on the counter. Admired it. Felt bolder, like she was getting away with something. She ran her fingertips over the massive dildo's shaft, slick and smooth, riding its PVC-sheathed packaging. A stiff drink would be nice, and she turned to the cupboard by the fridge where he shielded his good whisky from deprecating light, and drew down a bottle of something Scottish. Poured herself a glass, took a sip and savored it, wincing, exhaling the smokiness through her nose.

The scissors weren't enough for the dildo's heavy duty plastic wrap and she needed the aid of one of Devlin's handmade knives, pulled from a walnut block on the kitchen island. It sliced a cutout around the dildo without having to tackle the reinforced edges the scissors had trouble defeating. Then her might friend was out and free, unzipped from its plastic trousers. She plopped the suction base onto the granite countertop, laughing as this big rubbery cock wagged back and forth.

"Perfect," she said, then gathered up the packaging, smiling, chuckling, putting it all into the plastic bag and then stashing all the discarded packaging into her purse in the hall. When she returned to the kitchen, the twelve-inch King Cock still ticked side to side like a beefy metronome. She stroked a thumb and finger circle down the shaft, starting at the delicious plump curl of the cock head's flared corona. The dildo didn't have quite the supple cock-head feel that turned her on. It was rigid and unforgiving. The shaft was sticky, unnatural. Maybe she should have bought condoms. At least then it would have an excuse for feeling unnatural. She didn't think they had any condoms here in the apartment. They'd been bareback for a while. She liked it raw. Her hand rested on the flat below her pants' waistband, and her brow lowered a moment. Then she fisted the cock away with a loud pop and walked down the hall to Devlin's bedroom, whisky glass in the other hand, tossing the heavy dildo onto the king-size bed where it bounced twice, then lay lifeless on its side. King-size bed for a king-size cock.

The bedroom smelled like him. Not him, not his body, not his natural smell. It smelled like the after shave he wore. She unbuttoned her shirt and went to the tall dresser where he kept some personal items on the top. A watch, a Patek-Philippe with a leather band, one he hardly wore; three bottles of

amber cologne; a comb, some coins, a money clip with two twenties and a fifty pinched in its golden mouth. Seeing those items made it feel like Devlin was home, like he was still here. It chilled her.

She went to his closet, taking off her shirt, tossing it toward the bed, walking around her menacing lover's bedroom in pants and a bra. His fine, expensive suits were indexed on hangers, organized by color. Shades of black, steel, and charcoal. She ran fingers on the fabric, unbuttoning her pants. At the bedside she let them drop to the floor and stepped out of them, returned them to his dresser and lifted one of the bottles of cologne. She held it near her nose, closed her eyes, flashes of times he'd worn this scent playing dirty pictures in her thoughts. She touched the pad of an index finger on the flat circle of the spray nozzle and then rubbed the oily wet at the base of her thumb, returned to the bed smelling his scent on her wrist. With the covers pulled back, she sat down, set the whisky bedside, and unhooked her bra. She removed it, put it on the floor, then cuddled her breasts, stroking her thumbs across her nipples, each time finding them plumper. She closed her eyes and breathed, tried to set a scene in her head. Then she lay back, swung her legs under the covers and put her head on the pillow. The stillness was beautiful, the quiet. And being in Devlin's apartment, too. Nice in that old wicked way, but at least this was harmless. Under the covers, she thumbed down her panties, brought them out and dropped them in the locale of her discarded bra. Totally naked now in Devlin's bed. A warmth began; an inner heat, a changing of her brain's chemistry narrowing her unseeing vision, shaded by closed eyes. Her breathing slowed and deepened; her hands stroked her stomach, her sides, her hips. Both hands smoothed her flesh below her navel, swooping down between her parted legs. Two middle fingers worked up and down on her seam, hot and lively but still dry. She found her wet and lubricated her petals, her legs beginning to writhe under the sheets.

When she knew she was ready, she moved her hand around on the covers, eyes still closed, finding the weighty bulk of the extra large penis she'd purchased. She brought it under the covers, held it over her stomach and gripped the base of the shaft, the other hand swirling a grip on the cock head, like she wanted the dildo to feel pleasure.

But the cock wasn't very cock-like in feel. It wasn't warm and yielding. It was rubber. From a factory in the U.S. it had boasted. It should be washed first. Why didn't she buy condoms?

She grunted, frustrated, whipped the covers back and sat up, opened the bedside drawer. The lube they used was there, and she drew the bottle out and put it on the bed, then shuffled the other contents around looking for a rubber.

Lo-and-behold, she got lucky and found one. At least she didn't have to get up now and go to the washroom. The closet door was open, and she stared at Devlin's suits. Got up after a moment and crossed naked, touching the fabric again, then removed one. She held it up by the hanger, admiring it, running a palm over the lapel. Brought that back to the bed and lay it on the other side, up by the pillow. She got back in bed and pulled up the covers, laying on her side, looking at the suit. She opened the breast, grabbed a pant leg and pulled the pants loose off the hanger, having to work out the dowel from the mechanism that kept the pants hanging in place. With the pants flattened out, she found the King Cock again, tucked it down inside the waist, pushed it up so it pressed out the fabric. Then she squeezed it over Devlin's pants, like she'd found him hard while they were kissing.

That butterfly kaleidoscope fluttered again, and the horniness came up in a tidal swell. She leaned closer to Devlin's pants and unzipped them with both hands, put one in there and found that massive cock and withdrew it from his fly. She pressed her lips to the head. Pushed the head against their plumpness. Parted her lips and let the head enter her mouth, as large as Devlin. Her other hand touched between her legs, found herself nice and slick and ready. She imagined the King Cock as a real cock, imagined Devlin's heavy breathing when she used her mouth on him. She sucked the head only, stroked the mighty shaft, eyes closed the whole time, rolled back in her head and imagining sinful times when she was a very bad woman.

She rolled to her back, lifting the heavy dildo through the fly, putting it under the covers with her. She teased her opening, put pressure, eased it away, pushed it in. She said to the empty room, "Get a condom," then searched for it, found it, lay Devlin's cock on her flat stomach and opened the packet. She had to push the covers down to get the condom on the thing,

but when it was sheathed, she closed her eyes, put the dildo under the covers again and teased herself. She whispered, “You’re so big. We’re going to need the lube.”

She popped the thin nozzle on the lube and squirted some into her palm. Then she coated the huge cock, again going slow and deliberate, like the dildo would appreciate the tender care she offered. She pushed that huge cock head into her wetness again, this time gasping with the pleasure.

The dildo was too rigid, too unforgiving. It was inhuman. But she was wet and so fucking horny and needing that she could imagine herself out of its unnatural feel. Thought instead of Devlin; Devlin the asshole, Devlin the cruel manipulator, Devlin the masterful man who owned her pussy. Who dominated her sexuality even when she was the Kimmy that would strike fear in those sex-shop working girls. She pictured herself now, dressed for work the way she liked, high heels, high gloss, stopping with Devlin in Devlin’s Mercedes, walking the aisles with him, superior to all the products, just looking for some leather and paddles and lube. Those girls would drool. They would masturbate later on at home with the very toys they sold.

As she inched it deeper, felt the enormous stretch and fulfillment a big, hard cock offered, she pictured Devlin fucking her on the counter at the sex shop while those small cunts watched with gaping mouths. Her with her elbows, confident, aroused, tiger-like, mewling as Devlin pushed deep inside her, spreading her canal and opening up interior rooms that no one knew were even there. The dildo went deeper still, and she pushed away thoughts of those dumb girls and now thought of herself the way she was now: splayed out in her lover’s bed, her husband at work, her boss needing her for the interplay they both loved. Fucking at lunch at his swanky fuck pad. Getting takeaway and waiting here for her lover’s arrival. Getting fucked like no other man could fuck her. Going back to work with his sperm in her, going home to her loving husband and kissing his mouth with another man’s kiss lingering there.

She groaned and moaned, biting her lip, hating the intensity of this illicit arousal. It was awful, terrible. It was the opposite of who she was. Yet it was her. Six-foot in Loub’s, dinner at the Royal York, Porterhouses and whisky, leather interiors and lots of spending money.

Her legs shook and quivered, and her pot began to boil. It wasn't the big cock stirring it up, though that was a great mind-anchor, it was her own thoughts, her own monstrous desires that scrounged all the materiel needed to construct her erotic bomb, igniting megatons of orgasm a kilometer above her city. She cried out loud and free, no one to hear her, letting out so much pain and anguish and unfinished business. Regret, shame, worry and terror all swirled black tendrils into the white hot passion of her solo pleasure. She cried real tears, tears of release and sorrow and lamentation and of joy. The orgasm left her panting for breath, relieved of her sins for now, emptied and wiped out, just like she'd done with her hand for Josh this morning. In the wake of her husband's release, his first question had been tell me everything. In the aftermath of her own release, her first statement was you can never tell him.

Her phone chimed, and she made sounds of annoyance, whipping back the covers and sitting up.

"Fuck." She'd left a wet swath on Devlin's charcoal bedding. She'd come all over her former lover's bed. At first she thought of blow-drying it, then shrugged. The used dildo was tossed to the floor, the condom's reservoir tip empty—she loved when Devlin ejaculated, and the emptiness made her feel hollow—and she swiped up her pants. Phone retrieved she sat back on the bed and swiped it awake. A text from her sister Eileen.

"Fuck you," she whispered, reading it, seeing the attachment. A sonogram of Pop's first grand baby. But her lips trembled, and she touched the image, feeling sorry for having animosity for Eileen at such a beautiful time.

She wrist-wiped her eyes, smelling Devlin's cologne again, sniffing, hating feeling sorry for herself, hugging her naked stomach and putting one foot over the other. She'd missed her last period, and now this one wasn't coming either. It should be here today at the latest. It should have begun a few days ago. What if—

The front door of the apartment opened, someone coming in, and she cursed and jumped up, scrambling naked with nowhere she could escape to.

BRANCH CHAIN

Friday night he found himself in a place he'd never imagined he'd be: in the visitor's parking outside Devlin Stone's apartment, looking to meet with Devlin behind Kimmy's back. It was like he was guilty of the same thing Kimmy was. But he was drawn here by the cruelest torment. His own. His own desires had brought him out in the warm September rain, engine idling, windshield wipers arming droplets off the windshield in regulated intervals while he searched for the resolve to do what he came here for. Sickness swirled in his stomach and his heart fluttered with the panic of fight or flight.

He didn't have to do this. He could go home. Go home to Kimmy, go to his cousin's, where he'd told her he'd be. He could put this wickedness behind him, he and Meyer could order a pizza and some jalapeño poppers and play some Call of Duty, and later, around eleven or twelve, he could go home to his apartment and climb into bed with the woman he loved. A woman he'd pushed off a treacherous cliff. Had punished with his lechery. But a woman who held him blameless. A woman who'd proved to him she wanted no other man than him, and would do anything he wanted to restore what they had.

He could wipe the slate clean and start over, but he was sitting in his car outside Devlin's apartment.

Headlights passed by the rear bumper, a tenant coming in, the underground garage door lifting and giving access to the building's private residents-only belly. The car stopped. Then its white reverse lights came on and it pulled into the empty visitor's spot next to his Qashqai. The sickness in his stomach condensed to cold, hard lead. The car was low and sleek and black,

its paint rippling with rain water. The passenger window went down, and he motored his down as well. Devlin. Devlin sitting in his roadster.

“Hey, Josh, man, sorry, I’m late, I—”

“I just got here.”

“Oh, good. . . . Fuck, it’s pissing, eh? I’m going to park and I’ll meet you in the lobby. Go wait in the vestibule.” Devlin closed his window and backed out; the garage door had begun its descent closed, then jerked to a stop and yawned open again. Devlin’s Mercedes disappeared into the underground and the door rolled down, shutting off the light.

Josh shook his head and chewed his cheek. “What the fuck are you here for?” He could leave. It wasn’t too late. Devlin might taunt him that he chickened out, but what would that amount to? Maybe everything.

And that’s why he was here.

He checked his pockets, shut off the car, prepared himself for the dash to the lobby, then went for it, jumping out of the Qashqai, slamming the door and trotting to the awning outside Devlin’s apartment building.



They went up in the elevator without saying anything. Devlin was late for their meeting—a meeting that held Josh’s existence in the balance—because he was at the gym. Standing now in the elevator cab with his gym bag in one hand, texting on his phone with the other. He wore compression leggings and shorts, a couple layers of expensive sporty tops, and a jacket. Shoes were some high-tech Crossfit bullshit in neon. He smelled like cologne on top of male musk.

When the elevator doors opened, Devlin tucked his phone in his pocket and gestured for Josh to go ahead. When they were out and in the hall, Devlin said, "This is pretty heavy, huh? You're not saying anything."

Josh shrugged. "What's there to say? Let's just do this."

Devlin nodded, parsing Josh's answer, then going ahead to his apartment door, Josh following behind. Key in his door lock, he said, "I think there's a lot to say, Josh. But we're going to work this out."

"Work out what?"

Devlin didn't answer, just opened his door and again gestured for Josh to go ahead. He stepped forward, but then stepped back again. The apartment was dark. The situation foreboding. Devlin proved he hadn't changed since high school. Rumble was in there. Rumble was in there waiting. Maybe Devlin's new buddy Glenn, too. They'd punch him in the stomach and then tie him to a chair and they'd all cackle and guzzle beer as they forced him to watch some video of Devlin fucking Kimmy like a dog, the volume turned all the way up, neighboring apartments receiving the audio broadcast of Josh Waters's wife cheating on him with his high school bully, crying out loud and crystal clear every time Devlin rammed his huge cock balls deep into her tight pussy.

Devlin eyed him like his behavior was strange, and he went ahead into the apartment. Josh stayed in the hall, arm out and propping the door open. Devlin flicked on the lights, kicked off his shoes, put his bag down, stored away his keys.

"Come on in," he said, and went deeper into the apartment.

Josh followed, stuffing his hands in his pockets, keeping his jacket and shoes on like he could only stay a minute. He stood like that in the foyer until Devlin went into the kitchen and turned the lights on in there. Then he pried off his shoes and moved with caution into the kitchen, hands still in his jacket pockets.

Devlin pulled a blender out from where it was stashed against the tiled backsplash and plugged it in. “Just gotta make a quick shake. I’m running so late today. I didn’t even shower.” He grabbed some items out of his fridge and cupboards and arranged them by the blender. “You want a drink of something? You want a bourbon or Scotch?”

It was probably a dig, a barb meant to invoke how he’d passed out bourbon-drunk at Tiffany’s party, and how Devlin had forced himself on Kimmy and something happened that night that had sent his marriage away with one wheel in the gutter. “No, thanks.”

“Coke, pop, water? I’ve got some of those Bublys; cherry, I think, maybe strawberry, too...” He threw a banana into the blender and poured in some milk.

“I’m not thirsty. Can we just do this?”

“Yeah, yeah,” he said, tapping out two scoops of chocolate protein powder or something. Then it was like he realized he was being a jerk, and he turned, slowing down, leaning his butt on the counter and putting his hands on the edge. “Josh, look. I am sorry I’m late. We’re going to do this.” He jabbed a thumb behind him to the blender. “It was squats today, and I just, I gotta get some sugars, some amino acids. Timing is everything.”

Josh gritted his teeth. “Yeah, go ahead.”

Devlin turned back, set the blender to high and then stripped out of his top two layers, baring his hairy, muscular arms in a lycra tank top. He stopped the blender, poured the concoction into a glass, and took a long drink. He refilled it then, emptying the blender, picking up the glass and facing Josh. “Okay. You ready to do this?”



In the living room, Josh stopped and stared at the couch where he'd been arranged to sleep after the Jays game and where he'd found his wife's distinct panties tucked in between the cushions. The lead ball loosened to a jelly sickness and the strong urge to flee raced through him.

You don't have to do this.

Devlin emptied his glass and put it on a side table, opened the side table drawer and removed an iPad. He lifted the Pad to show Josh, a grave expression on his face that told Josh all he needed to know: the picture of his wife's pussy was on that tablet.

His heart raced and his sickly stomach soured further. A sudden urge toretch toe-kicked him in the guts and he lurched forward like he might vomit all over Devlin's floor. But it abated, and he held a fist near his mouth to quash it.

Devlin nodded like he understood how serious the situation was for Josh. He even said, "Yeah," like he was acknowledging it.

Josh shook his head in slow admonishing wags. "Why do you even want to do this?"

"You deserve to see it. That's why you're here."

"But fucking why? Why and how and what the fuck is wrong with you?" His voice held no anger, only whispered disbelief that a man could be so manipulative and cruel.

Devlin looked befuddled. "Me? Why is this all on me?"

"Who else?"

Devlin chuckled as if offended, but biting his tongue. He pinched the bridge of his nose like dealing with Josh Waters required patience. "I don't understand you, man. I don't get it."

"What's there to get? You're fucking with me like you've always fucked with me. You're trying to make me crazy—"

“I’m not trying to make you anything. What the hell are you talking about?”

“Sending me texts like a movie villain. Ooh, I have pictures of your wife. Like, get real. Who the fuck are you?”

“Movie villain? Josh, are we on the same planet? You want this. You told me you want this.”

He scoffed and rolled his eyes, panic seizing his breath, his eyes beginning to swell, his temples pounding. “I’m done, Devlin. I’m done. This is the sickest shit you could do to a person. You need help.”

Devlin chuckled. “Yeah, you and me both, man.” Then he said no more, just looking at Josh with his head cocked, lips pursed, a mask of sympathy.

It angered him. Fake. Fucking manipulator. “What if I went to the police or your dad or, or some kind of Ontario ethics board? I could ruin you. Kimmy would back me up even if you said it was consensual. I mean, we could sue you.”

“Josh, you think I don’t know that? Of course I know that. I’m taking a big risk here. I know you hold all the power. This was a big risk for me, a big gamble. You’re the dealer, the house, and it’s me who’s the gambler. This game is yours now.”

Josh chuckled. A real honest amusement. “What game?”

“Come on, Josh. Are you kidding me? I can’t tell when you’re sly or when you’re unaware.”

“I’m aware, trust me.”

Devlin straightened, put out a hand, five-finger pointing, a whole new sales pitch. “What do you gamble on?”

“Money.”

Devlin shook his head no. “Money’s boring, Josh. If money was everything, you wouldn’t be here, you would just sue me—or at least try to. Then you

would have money. You're here in my apartment because you know you want something more valuable than money. That's what people gamble on. Stakes."

Josh scoffed again and rolled his eyes. "What's at stake?"

"You're a heartbeat away from fulfilling every dark fantasy you think should stay locked up. But I'm here to tell you—to prove to you—if you have the courage, we can make the forbidden manifest. And no one gets hurt. No one is left out. And for the more sanguine, yes, there's money, too. Lots and lots of money. You see why I'm gambling on you? You see why I might take this risk?"

Josh grumbled and shrugged his shoulders, crawling with irritation like he'd fallen into an ant colony, wanting to kick Devlin in the balls and race him as fast as his Nissan would take him. Put all of this behind him, leave it in the past. Never learn what Kimmy did behind his back.

His shoulders slumped, and his stomach sagged low and heavy and soggy. An unbearable, sad burden oozed over his back and shoulders, trying to crumple him in front of Devlin.

He looked at the couch. "I found Kimmy's panties in your couch."

Devlin was quiet a long moment and Josh said no more. Devlin said, "I know."

The burden increased in weight, and his legs trembled to keep himself upright. Then flat and unemotional: "You know." He nodded, onboarding Devlin's first admission of a crime. "Did you hide them there for me to find?"

Devlin stared back. "You'd like that to be true, wouldn't you?"

He rubbed his mouth, worked his jaw around, pulse pounding in his neck and temples. "When I met you at Updike's for a drink before the Jays game?"

“Yeah?”

“You said your drink smelled funny, and you made me check it. Glenn, too. He said you’d fingered some skank.”

Devlin nodded, slow, eyes burning on Josh’s.

“Was that Kimmy?”

“Kimmy’s no skank, Josh.”

“Was that Kimmy?”

Devlin raised his eyebrows, looked away by a small measure. “Yeah,” he said. “Yeah, it was.”

UNVEILING

Reality thumped him like the world's biggest pillow swung by a giant. He staggered aside, put out a hand in case he would fall, but made it to the couch and fell sitting on it. He grabbed his hair and pulled. "You fingered my wife?" He couldn't even feel the couch, could feel nothing, as if he floated, or as if some part of his nervous system, the tangle of important cables strung in his spinal column, had been snipped by sharp scissors. Disconnected. Empty. Lost.

Devlin reacted to his loss of legs by lurching forward like he would prevent him from falling, but then putting up his hands in a braking motion, saying, "Wait, just wait, will you? Hold on. Let's look at what you came here for first. Okay?"

His mouth hung open, his eyes wide. Some part of him had expected Devlin to deny touching Kimmy to his dying day. A flip had switched. His face veered toward Devlin. "Did you taunt me? Did they know?"

"Who know?"

"Glenn. Rumble."

Devlin looked shocked, head darting away and brow furrowing. "What? No. No way. No, Josh. I swear they didn't know. That thing I did was for you and me. It's like a hunter using deer scent, you know? I'm trying to draw you closer to me, not make fun of you, not push you away."

He looked at the floor, then back up at Devlin. "You really did it?" This was like the tent-dream, only he was lucid and alive, sitting here in Devlin's apartment after enduring three days of time after arranging to meet him at

all. The drive here, the walk up. All sober as a judge. This was real, so fucking real.

But didn't he know it already?

He sat up an inch, a sudden autonomous urge to leap the distance between them and slug Devlin right in the fucking face. Instead, the urge dissipated like steam on a hot road and he sat back down. He punched himself. One right on the left side of the jaw, then one on the right. He fucking did this. It was him.

"Whoa, Josh, whoa," Devlin said, getting closer and grabbing Josh's wrists. "Relax, man, relax. Hold on."

He struggled to free his wrists from Devlin's grip, but Devlin was too strong. After a long session of helpless wrestling, Devlin said, "Do you want to hit me? Do you want to? I mean, I get it."

Instead of struggling, now he sagged, retreated from his bully, falling back against the couch seat. Devlin let his wrists go.

"You fingered her?"

Devlin looked annoyed now, turning aside. "Josh, I don't know what to say to you anymore."

"What do you want from me? Why are you doing this to me?"

Devlin wheeled back, not angry, more like pleading. "I'm not doing anything to you. I'm trying to work with you and you're making it so fucking hard. All that shit in Cayman, you were practically begging for a threesome. And I fucking told you I'm down. But you had to turn it into this like evil thing, this astronomical devastation just because I want to do it too." He paced away, making aggravated sounds, then returned. "Like you're hot and cold with me. You're snide and insulting—when I'm Kimmy's boss, I mean, her salary comes from me—you tease me, play like weird sexual games in front of me and then I'm the bad guy. . . . Is it you? I feel like this is your fault. Am I crazy?"

Josh rubbed his cheeks and his brow, flexing his neck, head going in circles. He'd done it. He knew he'd done it. He played along with the taunts, put Kimmy in Devlin's reach, and now he wanted to blame only Devlin. His head went back on the couch seat, arms limp at his sides, palms up at his thighs. "You showed her your... Showed her your thing... You fucking took it out and like played with it."

Devlin rubbed his chin and looked away. "Yeah. Kimmy told me she played you the recording. She felt guilty. Poor kid, man. I shouldn't have done that to her. I mean, I thought I'd be going back with her to your place. The three of us. You know?"

"Why would you do that? Why would you take it out?"

"She wanted to see it."

"You just showed it to her. She didn't ask."

Devlin tried to speak, moved his hands around, flummoxed, like he wanted to say something but thought maybe he shouldn't; something like no, that Kimmy had asked to see it.

"Did she ask?"

Devlin held up the iPad again. "Why don't you look at what you came to see?"

"I don't think I can." He could barely move.

"You came all this way. . . . Do you want a drink now?"

Josh shook his head and, with great difficulty, scooted his butt forward to the edge of the couch seat. He held out a hand for the iPad.

Devlin opened the iPad's cover and woke it up. "I'll get it up on the big screen." He turned the huge TV on and it lit up in brilliant solid blue. The Apple TV menu replaced it and Josh resumed rubbing his cheeks. Maybe it still wasn't too late. Maybe he could still leave and preserve his marriage, preserve his dignity.

Devlin hugged the iPad to his chest, looking down on Josh, almost like he'd changed his mind, and for Josh's sake, he wouldn't show the picture now. "I'm not going to hurt you, Josh. That's not what I'm doing. This is for both of us to enjoy."

"You're enjoying this?" A healthy measure of defiance put strength in his voice.

"I am. And when you admit you're enjoying it, too, you might not beat yourself up anymore."

He put his elbows on his knees and covered his face, saying into his hands, "Just show me the picture, please."

He could hear the iPad being laid to rest on the coffee table before the couch. He moved his hands away. Devlin said, "It's all yours," nodding to the iPad. "I'll give you a minute alone. Put it up on the screen, whatever you want. I'm going to hop in the shower."

They stared at each other forever, but at last Josh nodded. Devlin stepped away and then left the room, headed to his bedroom.

Josh stared at the iPad, laying screen up, just a menu with a handful of icons. He picked it up and put it on his lap. There was no way he could look at this, was there? It seemed like an easy thing to do when he was in Ajax, but now that he was here, he felt like he would burst into flames if he opened the picture up now.

The Photos icon glared at him, taunted him, dared him to touch her.

He did. His finger pad pressed the icon, and the menu whooshed to fill the screen.

Only one photo in the whole library. One photo, and even from the very small thumbnail, he identified it as the complete picture he'd come here for.

He touched that image.

Another whoosh, and now he was looking right at the entirety of the partial image that had haunted him all week long. A woman on her back with her legs open. She wore a business suit, the jacket open, and the skirt hiked up above her hipbones in a rough band. Her long, so very, very long legs were pulled up and opened, the spiky heels almost touching. They were high heels, expensive ones, red on the bottom. Kimmy's shoes. A hank of torn fabric hooped around one slender ankle. Her panties, all black and lacy. Her shirt had been unbuttoned and parted on her narrow chest, and her bra, what he could see of it, was askew.

But the central focus of the picture, the unavoidable, undeniable source of this photo's power, was the shimmering center-point, glistening with wet. Kimmy's pussy. Kimmy's perfect little pussy, skirt up, showing it to the man who took the picture. He'd seen only a small portion of the picture, about a tenth of its square footage, a bathmat on a bathroom floor. The picture was everything he'd imagined, everything he hoped it would be. And, at the same time, the thing he hoped it wouldn't be. Kimmy's petals were engorged and parted, her core exposed, her canal opened like it had been fucked. Did he fuck her? Had Devlin just fingered her?

He hugged his stomach, held one finger on the picture until a sub menu appeared, then he launched the photo to the big and ready TV.

Now his naked wife was in full view, big screen, naked and legs parted, begging someone, anyone—Devlin—to fuck her.

"Oh my god," he breathed, slipped off the couch and went to his knees, walking to them before the TV like a suppliant, ready to place his forehead down to prove his devotion to the woman he worshipped.

His cock throbbed like electrified steel, and he shifted and grunted, his uncomfortable underwear strangling his poor member. Pre-come pulsed in a steady flow and the only thing that saved him from insanity was the ever-loving knowledge that he could go home right now and climb into bed with the same woman in this pornographic photo and put his arms around her. He could hug her and kiss her. He could make love to her if he wanted. He could even say he had a headache and ask her to jerk him off and squeeze and smack his balls.

I would do anything for you, Josh.

His breaths came in sudden gusts and he realized he'd stopped breathing for a moment. He laughed. Inexplicable. Overwhelmed. Flooded with too many emotions. Or maybe he really had crossed the sanity Rubicon.

"Oh my god," he sighed again, and reached for the TV. He'd touched that leg so many times, caressed those knees, rubbed those feet. He knew how everything in this photo felt under his touch. And Kimmy had shown it all to another man.

"I did this," he said. "I fucking did this."

Kimmy's flesh. Kimmy's beautiful skinny legs. Kimmy's perfect tawny pussy, the inner flesh blushing in cherry-stained color, slick and greased, prepared for fucking. Her pubic hair. Her hip bones. Her hands. Her slender thumbs, her nails...

But no face.

The face had been framed out of the photo.

But it was Kimmy. He knew it was.

He grabbed his cock through his pants and squeezed it until his whole body shuddered with exquisite pleasure. God, he was on the verge of orgasm from the painful revelation of his wife's brutal debauchery.

He moaned her name under his breath, saying it again and again, admonishing her bad behavior—but not blaming her. He was the one to blame.

He stared at his wife for an eternity.

He stared until Devlin reappeared, reentering the room in gray sweatpants and a clean black T-shirt, his hair wet and combed back. Devlin stood beside kneeling Josh and looked at the screen and Josh didn't prevent him. What was the point? The man had taken the photo.

Then Devlin let out a long, admiring exhale. He said, “Josh, look at her. She wanted it. Wanted it like she needed it, like she was in heat. How could I reject that? Seriously, look how beautiful she is. Oh my god. Asking me to do it? I couldn’t say no.”

“You fingered her?”

“Josh, I couldn’t say no.”

His eyes hadn’t left the screen. “What’s she on, some sand bags or something? Where is this?”

“It didn’t happen there, Josh.”

“Where did it happen? On the couch?”

“These are things you need to ask Kimmy, Josh. Not me.”

“You took a picture and showed me.”

“You broke her, Josh. Kimmy’s gone. Won’t talk to me, doesn’t hardly come into work anymore.”

“Good,” he said.

Devlin crossed his arms and snuffled disgust through his nostrils. “You’re going to rob her of everything she’s dreamed of, Josh. Be careful with her. She’s an amazing human being.”

He sighed and bowed his head. “I did it. I made it about me.”

“It’s not too late, Josh. Not too late to do the right thing.”

Now he looked up at Devlin and right away saw the enormous horse-cock bulge in his sweatpants. No underwear, his over-sized manhood hanging down and bowing out the fabric, halfway down his thigh. The sight was ugly and garish and turned his stomach. Devlin had taken that out in Cayman and showed it to Kimmy.

Maybe Kimmy asked him to.

He said, “You’re uh, you’re... hard.”

Devlin pulled his gaze from Kimmy’s open legs. “Aren’t you?”

Josh swallowed. Knew what was next and knew it would come, eventually. Had sworn off coming tonight because of it, but then couldn’t stay away. Couldn’t stay away, so in the end, he complied with Devlin’s stipulation for tonight’s attire.

He stood up, got on his feet next to Devlin, and looked away. Then his hands came to his waist and unbuttoned his jeans and drew down the zipper. Devlin half-turned from the TV, arms still crossed, and watched him do it, smirking, one eyebrow raised.

“What are you showing me, Josh?”

Even and monotone, acidic bile on the back of his tongue, he said, “What you wanted.”

Devlin stepped back, eyes turned low to watch Josh push his pants down his hips and show Devlin he’d done what he was told. He’d come here tonight wearing the panties he’d found in Devlin’s couch.

FLIGHT

He looked at Devlin, jaw clenched. “There. Does this make you fucking happy?”

Devlin frowned, squinted, leaning away like he needed glasses, looking down and trying to make out in the dim of his living room whether he’d worn them. He looked to Josh, a small smirk to one side. “Are those the panties?”

“They are,” he said with a measure of defiance, hoping in some way seeing a man humiliated but standing straight might show Devlin how ashamed he should be, making the request at all. “Does it make you happy?”

Devlin put up his hands like he didn’t know what to say, but his eyes showed a certain delight.

“I did what you wanted. I wore them. And you’ve got nothing to say?”

“I just don’t get it,” Devlin said, shaking his head like he was trying to break free from the moment. “You surprised me.”

“Surprised you how? You told me to. You said I had to. And that I had to show you.”

“Yeah, but I’ve got no leverage now. I showed you the photo already. I could see if I said show me before I show you the picture you came to see, but you saw it already. Do you just want to show me?”

“No, I don’t want to show you! You made me show you,” he said, fumbling to get his zipper up.

“Josh, you could have got out of here without doing that.”

“Then why even fucking tell me to do that at all?” He popped his button in place again. This was like standing naked by the ocean at night and each wave that hit you opened a door to a closed room in your brain and splashed around, stirring up all the times someone humiliated you. Devlin in the locker room. Devlin and his buddies and their cruel taunts.

Devlin turned away, and in the moment before he did, Josh could see he was amused, could see that look of mirth Devlin would get when he dominated other kids in the school. He took a step away before turning around again. “I guess like I wanted proof of life. You know? Wanted to know you had stakes in the game.”

“This isn’t a game, Devlin. It’s my life. We’re not in high school anymore. None of this is funny.”

“Who’s laughing?” That amusement had disappeared from his expression. Now he looked cold. “I wanted you to prove you were invested.”

“You wanted to humiliate me.”

“You choose to be humiliated. If you owned it, you wouldn’t be.”

“Fucking psychobabble,” he muttered.

“If you opened your jeans up and said look at my hard cock in these satin panties because this shit turns me on, no one could take that from you.”

“You’re humiliating me now while you’re saying I shouldn’t be humiliated. You fucking talk in circles.”

“And you’re a rigid prick. You know that?”

“I didn’t wear Kimmy’s underwear because it turns me on, so why the fuck would I own that? I don’t own it. That’s you. Why don’t you own that you’re a miserable manipulator who is interfering with my marriage?”

“This is the rigid prick part. Right here. I’m not interfering. I was minding my own business, and I didn’t manipulate a single thing. My manipulations, as you call them, are for your benefit. I’ve been nice to you—”

“Sending me pictures of my wife, telling me to come tonight wearing the panties I found? That you hid for me to find. Are you crazy?”

“Why don’t you work with me instead of against me? Ask yourself that. If I ask you to wear panties, call me out on it and say no. Say you won’t do that.”

“I grew up with you, Devlin. Stop gaslighting me. And saying no is working against you, not with you. Plus, if I say I won’t, and I don’t, you’ll make me suffer. You’ll make me suffer twice as much. That’s why I wore them.”

Devlin said nothing for a little while, like he was contemplating what he just heard. Calmer, he said, “Would Kimmy approve of you wearing them?”

“What do you think?”

“I think you should take them off. I don’t think you should have showed me. I didn’t even ask.”

“You fucking told me to wear them.”

“Don’t do it if you don’t want to. That’s what I’m saying. Stand up to me.”

“That’s never worked before.”

Devlin nodded, squeezed his nose, eyeing him. He rubbed his brow, then ran his large hand down his face. “Life is chaos, Josh. Everything is chaos. All around, up and down. That’s why you don’t see it—see what’s at stake here and how you can clean up. That’s why you resist it. You have this existential understanding of order that’s let you down, and now your boat’s got a leak and you’re hanging on to a lifesaver of an idea you thought kept you safe before. But it’s just like that boat that let you down already, put you in those big waves, where it’s cold and foreboding and you know you’ll

never see shore again. But there is a shore, man. You know there is one, you just have to have faith.”

Josh shook his head, disbelieving the nonsense Devlin spouted with conviction. Kimmy had told him how he did this. “I don’t even know what you’re saying, Devlin.”

“Josh, I’m telling you, your life and everything you love depends on it: there is order here.” He gestured toward the TV and the lurid picture of Kimmy with her legs spread open like a woman who needed to get fucked. “You don’t see it, don’t see your role in it, but it’s right out in front of you, and you just got to reach out and put your hand around it. When you hold it, you’ll feel its strength, and you’ll know it’ll help you back to shore.”

He took a deep breath and let it out. “What happens when I’m on shore?”

“A man who can survive what you’re going through, a man who can make it back through all that wind and waves and black, scary night, a man who can swim knowing there are monsters out there who can swallow him in one gulp, and some who’ll bite him in two, three, four, maybe a hundred pieces, well, when that man makes it to shore, feels sand under his feet, the land will be his.”

Josh raised his eyebrows, aloof, saying, “He’ll walk on it like a king.”

Devlin’s smile crumpled. “You think it’s a joke. I get it, I don’t blame you. I want you to think about it. I mean, really sit and think. You’re rejecting it because you’re a man who only sees the chaos.”

“It is chaos. Everything is chaos. You just said it.”

“Put it in order, Josh. That’s all we want. Men, I mean. We want order. We want stability.”

Josh scoffed and walked away, turning his back on Devlin and shaking his head. “What’s stable about this? Tell me what you see as stable.” His heart grew heavy knowing the thing he would say next. “You put your fucking fingers in my wife.” Inside Kimmy.

“A man who wears panties to my apartment tonight instead of bringing a machete knows exactly what’s stable about this. You’re just afraid to admit it.”

Now Josh had reached a dead end, had wandered down a box canyon and had come to its terminus with riders on his tail. He turned around to regard Devlin, out of excuses, but still afraid to say it. “Tell me.”

“You and Kimmy ran a game on me in Cayman. Both of you want this if you’re going to lay games like that. I heard you guys together. You wanted me to. I heard you fucking her. You guys knew I was waiting for you. Knew I could hear you. So, look. We can make it happen.”

“What happen?”

“Your wildest dreams, Josh.”

“I don’t know what that means,” he said, but his heart was pounding.

“Sure you don’t. That’s all right. You and I both know something was going on between you and Kimmy, and I was a third wheel. Third wheel on a tricycle, though, my friend.” He showed Josh a wry raising of an eyebrow. “Maybe even the big wheel out front.”

“I’m not even sure what you’re saying. What are you saying?”

“I like you, and I’m not saying anything you don’t want to hear. You’ve played me along the way, put me where you want me. Why are you so afraid to commit?”

“Commit to what?”

“Getting what you want.”

“Just say it.”

Devlin stared at him with steady confidence. “You want to watch me with her. You want to watch me with Kimmy. It excites you; the idea thrills you.

You hide from it. You skulk around with shame, when what you want is pure and, really, unsurprising. You know that Kimmy wants it, too.”

“She doesn’t. She plays the games for me. It’s me.”

Devlin chuckled. “Kimmy wants it more than you do.”

His stomach went loose and squirrely and he felt the strong need to have a seat. Instead, he stood upright, wobbling a little, but intact. “Did she say that?”

Devlin fixed his posture, more serious and judicial. “That’s something you should ask your wife. Ask Kimmy what she wants. She still works for me. She didn’t run too far away.”

That was true. And he was afraid to confront her over it. He was afraid she would say no again, that she wanted the money and the job.

“Ask her and she might tell you. There’s no reason to be afraid.”

Now he looked at Devlin with wild disbelief. No reason to be afraid?

Devlin said, “There isn’t, Josh. If you cross this threshold, only amazing things await you. And you know that. That’s why you’re here.”

Devlin studied him a long while as he stood numbed and muddled, lost in a cottony fog, knowing there was nothing to search for because he knew what it was and where to find it. As much as he hated Devlin’s words, why had he come here tonight? Why on earth would he have complied with such an insane request?

Because you wanted this.

Deep down, you’ve always wanted this.

Devlin could see Josh’s mind working, his expression lightening, dipping a little to meet Josh eye to eye. “What if I’m making up stories right now? What if I fingered Kimmy the other day like I told you, but it was just the way I finger her most days of the week? What if part of the reason Kimmy

took this job with me was so she could get out of the house and have an affair with me?

He stepped back, wounded and shocked by the change in direction. “Fuck you.”

Devlin snuffled a laugh, seeing the humor in it, throwing up his hands and saying, “It could be true. Maybe if you sneak your hand between all the cushions in my apartment, you’ll snag a pair of your wife’s panties, her bras, used condoms... If we used condoms.”

The idea they’d been sneaking around behind his back punched him in the belly and he exhaled through his nose. The thought of Kimmy and Devlin in this very apartment, on the couch where he’d found the panties, and Kimmy naked and getting fucked hard without a condom, pinched at his core, squeezed his soul. The hurt brought a strange delight.

Devlin pointed to the TV. “See this picture? Come look at it again. Let’s look at it.” They took a step toward it, both of them looking at Kimmy’s naked pussy, wet and shiny. “What if I have a hundred photos of Kimmy like this one? What if I have thousands? What if I told you there were videos?”

His heart rate spiked into space. “There are?”

“I’m making a point, Josh. What if there were videos of me fucking Kimmy, and you could watch them and listen to her sounds, listen to her get it deep and hard? I bet you’d love to hear what she sounds like.”

His heart galloped out of control and his pulse raced so hard his hearing grew murky and distant. “No...”

“Josh, this is my point. Look within”—he touched a tented hand to Josh’s chest—“When I tell you the worst thing imaginable, you’ve already explored it in your own mind. You’re ready for it. And, when I sent you this picture, you didn’t call some ethics board like you said, didn’t call a lawyer. Fuck, you didn’t even show up here with a gang of your buddies, you came

here wearing the panties I told you to wear. Isn't it obvious to you yet what you want? Why can't you see it?"

Devlin wasn't wrong. He was a bully and a manipulative thug, but the things he said weren't wrong. He'd called Meyer and told him to cover for him, and he'd come here tonight wearing Kimmy's panties, all to see a better photo of his wife compromised by his tormentor. They should be enemies, but Devlin wasn't lying about the secret desires that darkened Josh's doorstep. He swallowed and licked his lips, his mouth dry.

Devlin put his strong grip on Josh's shoulder. "Right? You see it now. Think about it."

Josh shrugged his shoulder away, and then stepped back, the whole while disregarding Devlin's gaze, and looking instead to the screen and the photo of the woman he loved with her legs opened for another man. He'd really put his fingers inside her. Why didn't that enrage him more? He was angry, but angry at himself. He'd wanted all of this from the beginning, and he'd teased Kimmy to the point she'd succumbed to his game. And that surrender to his desires left her somewhere on her back, on a pallet of something, her legs wide open, her pussy wet, Devlin Stone taking photographs.

Devlin turned to look at the photo as well. "What if Kimmy likes it deep?"

Josh hissed in air at the shock of the words, like water thrown in his face.

Devlin half faced him. "I could tell you that. I could tell you she has a pocket, it's like a coin purse, folded over behind her cervix, squished over her uterus, and when I fuck her deep, like maybe three times a week, I get in that spot." He went nearer to the TV and touched the image of naked Kimmy, touching her pussy, stroking the finger point higher to above where her skirt hooped her waist. "Kimmy doesn't like it when I bump her cervix, but if I tilt those skinny hips the right way, I glide right by, and the head of my cock fills that coin purse"—he circled Kimmy's tummy with a finger—"stretches it out, and boy when I do, Kimmy comes like never before, her feet go like"—he put up his hands in trembling fists, posing like a horse trying to box—"and then, look out, because Kimmy Chang's a squirter."

Josh exhaled shaky breath through his pouted lips. His eyes had gone to wide circles and his heart was a rapid drumbeat.

It was true. Kimmy did do that. It sounded so real. And she wasn't always one.

One what, Josh?

Say it... A squirter.

That was new. It was new, and it started after she began working for Devlin Stone.

Devlin crossed his arms, all matter of fact now, saying, "Women never want every inch, ninety-nine point-nine percent want only half of it. Kimmy's that point-one percent." He rumbled a small laugh, then dropped a hand and squeezed his enormous bulge. With it in his hand, Josh could make out the clear shape of it under the fabric, the flared rim of his cock head, even the veins. "So when she comes on my cock, its buried in her all the way, our pubic bones grinding, and her squirt patters up to my chin, sprinkling in my chest hairs, and man, the way her pussy quivers on me in that moment? . . . I've never had a pussy as good as Kimmy's."

Devlin's malevolent eyes fell on Josh's now, and his smile looked twisted. But there was a challenge in his expression: am I lying or is what I'm saying true?

He wanted it to be true. He wanted the unknowing to be over. The purgatory of suspicion and fantasy was killing him and he just wanted it to be true, so it would end. It would be better than another day of torturous conjecture.

He tried to swallow again, but it was difficult. He choked, cleared his throat. "Why would you say something so awful?" His voice was a coffin's creak. "How could you think it's okay to talk about my wife like that?"

Devlin's expression changed to sympathetic, head leaning to one side. "Show me again."

“What?”

“Show me again. Show me those panties.”

“No.”

“Show me, Josh. I’m trying to make a point here.”

Josh made no move to unzip his denim again and Devlin smiled with calm patience, but then taking matters into his own hands and unbuttoning Josh’s jeans. He said, “May I?”

Josh said nothing, allowed Devlin to unbutton and unzip him. “Now pull your fly open and show me. You know it, you can just admit it. Or show me and prove I’m wrong.”

He said in a robotic monotone, like another person speaking nearby, “What do you want to see?”

“Part your fly, Josh. Show me the panties.”

His hands were autonomous things, moving to obey his bully’s command. He parted the fly and showed Devlin, both of them looking at what he revealed. His cock was hard and humping out his wife’s skimpy panties. The ones Devlin had stripped from her thighs before he finger fucked her. Before he put his fingers in Kimmy and then later made Josh smell them. He closed his eyes, his mind swirling, his breathing smooth but rapid.

Devlin tugged the panties waistband and his eyes snapped open. “Show it to me.”

They looked at each other, then down, and Josh thumbed out the waistband, his much smaller cock freed, ticking from left pointing to straight up, the naked tip shimmering with pre-come.

“I told you a man’s worst nightmare and you’re hard as a rock. You should see the energy in your eyes. Don’t hate me. Don’t hate what we do. Let it go, let it happen, get what you want. Kimmy and I are waiting for you to catch up.”

He shook his head, and in frantic tugs, pushed his erection back into the panties and jerked up his zipper. He turned away, his mind racing, the fight-or-flight right now screaming fuck it, flee, flee, flee!

Behind him, Devlin said, “So you have to figure something out, Josh. You’ve got homework. You have to think, ‘Is Devlin fucking with me?’ . . . And you have to think why. Why would Devlin do anything? If anything I said tonight is true, why the fuck would I say it? You, Josh, box your dreams away, when I’m telling you, if you held your head up and looked where you were going, you might actually get there. You’re the one who is wrecking this for yourself, but you’re wrecking it for Kimmy. And for me, too.”

“I gotta get the fuck out of here,” he said, heading for the door, Devlin following him. As he shoved his feet back into his shoes, he looked up to see Devlin with his arms folded, leaning against the wall.

Josh said, “Is that shit you said true?”

Devlin shrugged a shoulder. “Look in your heart and tell me if it would matter.”

“Of course it would matter,” he said, thinking of Kimmy and Devlin fucking three times a week in this apartment. “What the fuck is wrong with you?”

“You know you want this. You can’t even say no anymore. You’re holding up these weak placards with ‘It matters’ written on it in Sharpie, you even got the little exclamation point, but you’re just a man with a broken-down limo waiting at the airport, holding up your weak sign and hoping you’ll find someone in the crowd who cares. Nobody cares, Josh. Hold that sign up all day. Hold it as high as you can. It matters, it doesn’t matter. There’s no one to judge you, make you feel small, hurt you. Get what you want, man. Get what you want.”

His eyes darted from Devlin and all around the man’s apartment. “I have to go. I’m going.” He opened the door and stepped into the hall.

Devlin said after him, “You knew it was happening and you did nothing, Josh. You explained it away because deep down, you wanted it to be true. Now you know it is. What are you going to do, run away?”

19

HEAVY CARGO

The shock found him at last, looping off the 401 highway into Ajax, moving along Kingston, the Tim Hortons sign lit up on his right, twenty-feet high.

What had just happened?

How low had he sunk?

He pulled into the Tims because his hands were shaking. Fuck, everything was shaking. First thing he thought, driving near the end of the drive-thru lineup, was he had to get the panties off. He had to get them off right fucking now. He didn't need a coffee, and sure as fuck didn't need a goddamn donut at this moment. So he bypassed the lineup and backed into a parking spot where he'd be hidden behind the hulking metal cargo container the Tims used as their trash storage.

When the car was off, he stayed posed like he was driving, with his hands gripping the wheel, jaw flexing, and his eyes laser focused straight ahead, looking at parked cars glimmering under the parking lot lights.

The texts that had lured him to Devlin's.

Do you still have the panties?

Josh: yes

bring them

Josh: Why?

I want to see them. I want to see you wearing them.

He unlatched his seatbelt and climbed into the back of the Qashqai, where no one would see him—where he hoped no one would see him. He undid his jeans and took them off, cursing under his breath, cursing himself for the weakness he showed.

Those textual taunts had come to him in his weakest, most unseeing moment in his entire life. And he behaved like the fourteen-year-old automaton Devlin conditioned him to be, all those years ago. Complete compliance. To do otherwise would result in pain and destruction.

He slumped in the back of the Qashqai, a man wearing no pants, only his cheating wife's underwear. Devlin fingered Kimmy. That wasn't a lie.

And what about the other stories Devlin told you?

It was unbelievable. Unbelievable to have arrived at this point, lying in the Qashqai's cargo, looking at the unlit dome light and feeling like he had nowhere to go. Back home? Back home with Kimmy?

He thumbed the panties off, getting naked in a Tim Hortons parking lot, like a pervert. Like a masochistic pervert.

Like the masochistic pervert that he was.

Then he scrambled to get the jeans back on before someone caught him. That would be great. Right on his criminal record. Harmeet bringing him into the office and reading back the police report.

Josh, were you naked at a Tim Hortons?

No, I was wearing panties.

Women's panties?

They're my wife's panties.

Like that would make it better. Well, maybe it would. He could say, "My wife and I play a little game. The cops just showed up at the wrong time, Harmeet."

But tonight's game was between him and his wife's boss. Not Kimmy. Kimmy was home alone, probably sleeping, maybe watching Netflix. And she knew nothing about what he did tonight. What he did behind her back.

Just like Kimmy crept behind your back.

And, holy fuck, if Devlin showed Kimmy a small percentage of the cruelty he showed Josh, how much had Devlin made Kimmy suffer?

Bad enough she came running to find you in Rome.

He put a hand over his heart, still staring at that blank dome light, thinking of the torture Devlin had put Kimmy through. He'd blamed himself. Blamed himself because he liked the blame; liked to be the center of attention. But he and Kimmy were just puppets in Devlin's marionette show.

"Fuck's sake," he said, alone in the cargo space, the hand on his heart forming a fist and thumping down on the Qashqai's cargo carpet—then he was climbing into the front again, sitting, angrier, the shock dissipating. He buttoned up his jeans and put on his seatbelt.

That fucking asshole.

Devlin had lured Kimmy. He'd lured Josh as well. Devlin had moved them around like toys on an airbrushed battlefield.

Now he wiped his brow with the back of his hand, admitting something awful: He'd liked it. He'd liked it, and Kimmy liked it, too.

Whatever had happened between Kimmy and Devlin, Kimmy had liked it.

Kimmy liked getting fingered.

Out loud, he said, "Liked getting that deep pocket stretched," then belched and held a fist to his mouth, plugging an acidic retch that wanted to whisk up his lunch all over the Nissan. Once the fire's heat abated, he muttered, "She fucking liked it." He thumped the steering wheel. "She fucking liked it," he said again, louder, the slogan becoming his new mantra.

Fucking bitch.

He started the Qashqai and revved the engine. Then stopped, let it idle, and thought some more.

He unplugged his phone from the stereo system and swiped it to life, going straight to the texts. The ones that came from the unknown number. He read them again.

I want to see your little cock in them.

Why had he worn them? If Devlin said something so cruel, what kind of man would comply?

One who wanted to wear them already. One who wanted to submit.

Had Devlin known? Had Devlin known the obsession he held for the sultry satin fabric that caressed his wife's privates? The ones she'd stripped away for another man?

He'd wanted to wear them, wanted to feel the satiny tightness on his hard cock. Devlin making the request had been his license. He'd shown up before the very man who'd stripped them from his wife, like a dutiful and willing soldier in some wicked war game.

Again, only one question: what kind of man are you?

"One who hates himself," he answered, and kept reading through the wicked texts.

Josh: why would you want to see that?

because you want to show me

Josh: is that your fantasy?

you know it's yours, Josh

He heaved a hurting sigh and tapped his forehead with his phone edge, reliving the brutal humiliation that seemed like a dream now. An unreal event. But he'd done it. It wasn't done in a dream. He'd shown Devlin he wore Kimmy's panties.

He sniffled and sighed more, overfilled with terrible emotions he couldn't name, wallowing in existential dread and watching cars creep along to the menu board to order their late night coffees.

you know it's yours, Josh

But when he'd showed Devlin he wore them, Devlin didn't know what to think. Devlin took a look like he didn't know what he was looking at. Devlin said he was surprised.

In his head, he had screamed, "You fucking told me to, you asshole!"

He read the text string again, starting from the top, bypassing the photos of Kimmy's inner thigh. Then he read through them once more.

"Holy shit," he sighed, turning off his phone and laying it in his lap.

Did Devlin have an accomplice?

Did Devlin's accomplice prank Devlin, telling their prey to show up in Kimmy's panties, and Devlin didn't even know?

Two bullies. Rumble and Devlin. As usual. Rumble and Devlin together, Rumble laughing later when they played over Josh showing up at the apartment, Rumble saying to Devlin, "Did our little buddy show up in women's panties?" And Devlin punching his arm, laughing, saying, "You fucking asshole, it scared the shit out of me, I was like, 'Dude, why are you wearing panties, and why the fuck are you showing me?'" Rumble laughing, saying, "Next time I'm gonna tell him to suck you off," and they collapse together in masculine hysterics, beating their fists on Devlin's leather couch—where he'd fingered Kimmy—and Devlin can barely breathe, wheezing, "Dude, his little dick was so fucking hard in those women's panties."

“What a fucking loser,” they’d say together.

He’d worn the panties as an act of defiance, not compliance. At least that’s what he’d told himself.

Show him the panties, humiliate Devlin for even asking. Is this what you wanted to see, a man in women’s panties?

But in the end, what mattered was he’d complied. That’s all that mattered.

And now in the aftermath, what he’d done was even worse than compliance. It was a whole tenth level of humiliation and manipulation.

Had Devlin been the one to ask? Or was he the butt of someone else’s joke?

He undid his seatbelt, got out and opened the rear hatch, that dutiful dome light on now, bright and eager, and finding the panties bundled up in a ball, casting a sharp black shadow under their satiny shine. He grabbed them, marched to the sea-can, took a half minute to figure out the lever, then opened it and threw them in.

You’re such a wimp. You’re such a fucking wimp.

He slammed the door closed and re-locked it. Then, back into the Nissan, driving out of the Tims, less than five minutes from home. Less than five minutes from Kimmy.

But as soon as he pulled out, he growled and flicked his indicator, cutting across oncoming traffic to pull a U-turn, and headed back to the Tims.

There was an awful truth he had to recognize here: only Kimmy knew he’d obsessed over those panties.



Josh woke her coming into the apartment after eleven o'clock. She lay in bed with her eyes open, listening and waiting for him to make it into the bedroom.

For the first time in weeks, Josh had gone out tonight to do a normal thing. A thing he would have done on the regular before the summer. Before everything in their lives had been cast in shadow. She hoped he'd had a good time with Meyer, and that he kept his mind off his burdens. They were moving their game piece back to where they'd been happier, and there would be no deviation, no questionable playing.

When the bedroom door opened, Josh didn't enter, only stood in the doorway, like he watched her. She lifted her head to see him standing with stooped shoulders, a shrouded figure in the dark. It scared her at first, so she called his name, worried for a second the man wasn't her husband at all.

Josh answered. "Hey."

She stretched her legs out straight under the covers. "Did you have fun with Meyer?"

"Uh-huh," he said, entering the room, pulling off his shirt.

Had he been drinking?

If he drove drunk, she would kill him. She lifted her head higher from the pillow and watched him. "Did you drive yourself home?"

"Yeah," he said, unbuttoning his jeans.

"Were you guys drinking?"

Josh shook his head no.

She said, "Were you?" Like she was unconvinced.

Josh pushed his pants down and stepped out of them. He turned to regard her.

No, he wasn't drunk. Was he angry?

Her eyes went down his naked body to between his legs, where his cock stood at full, throbbing attention. She raised her eyebrows, surprised but not dismayed. She began to smile. The moonlight came in their apartment window and the way it slanted occluded Josh's face, kept it in the dark, but his body was lit, his penis sticking out and casting a shadow across his hip like a proud sundial. She said, "What were you guys up to?" Trying to keep it light, wanting to make him laugh, pretending she didn't notice his obvious arousal.

He came to the foot of the bed, then climbed onto it, naked.

"What are you doing?" she said, laughing, protecting herself, but her heart swelling with happiness to see her husband return to her, hard as a rock, out having fun with his cousin tonight, returning home to have sex with his wife. She cupped his cheek and tilted up her chin, exposing her neck, looking to accept his kiss.

Josh's hand smoothed her collar, then snatched a tight grip on the back of her neck.

DARKNESS

Josh's lips met hers, and her husband's renewed strength conjured excitement. Gone was the timidity, the hollow, fragile man, whose eyes roamed dull and unseeing. His grip on her neck was strong, his kiss direct, his cock hard. Hard without any performance from her. Josh didn't need dirty encouragement. He'd come home from a casual night out with his cousin, already thinking of his wife and the things he wanted to do to her.

Josh prowled over her on all fours, clawing the bedding while she kicked with her feet and knees, both of them working together to remove the cotton barrier separating them. His knees straddled her hips as she sat up, Josh rearing, his kiss leaving her mouth for the first time and already missed, his hands raking down her back and pulling up the oversized t-shirt she slept in. Her hips rocked to free the shirt hem trapped under her bum, and his bare cock poked her in the cheek, then scored along by her ear. She kissed Josh above his pubic tuft as he worked the shirt over the back of her head.

But she had no patience. Moving her mouth to the point of his erection, Josh's cock head parting her lips, her jaw relaxing, her neck lowering her mouth until she engulfed almost his entire length. Josh exhaled a long, satisfied sound, like his Kimmy sucking his cock was the thing he'd needed most in the world at this moment, and he hadn't anticipated it.

She circled a thumb and forefinger around the base of his cock, the other three curling around his balls and squeezing them against her palm, remembering the uncomfortable moment earlier in the week when Josh had asked her to hurt him. Tonight she offered no brutal handling, thinking only of giving him pleasure, in the hopes he would be inspired to reciprocate. She missed him.

Josh lost himself in the pleasure she delivered, his hands cupping over both her ears, the t-shirt like a hood tugged over her head. As much as she wanted him to make love to her, if he didn't stop what she was doing, she would love to suck him until he came into her mouth. With his hard cock in her mouth, she felt forgiven.

Josh stopped her at last. Thrusting his cock deep into her mouth until she gagged. She coughed spit around his shaft, tried swallowing and gulping. If Josh wanted to face fuck her until she retched, she would comply. Anything for his love to return. Anything for Josh not to hate her.

At last, he withdrew, and she coughed and heaved for air, backhanding the wet from her lips. Josh took her face in his hands and guided her to look at him.

“That face,” he said. “That perfect fucking face. You are so crazy beautiful.”

She didn't know how to respond, didn't know how to react to this off-kilter Josh who showed up in their bedroom. She only met his gaze and said nothing, ready to hear whatever he wanted to say, which was, “Scoot back and sit on the pillows.”

Eyes still on his, she complied, putting her hands out behind and shifting backwards until her butt touched the pillows. She was topless, wearing cotton bottoms, her nipples hard and aching.

“Take off your panties.”

She said, “Okay,” and began thumbing them off her hips, still watching his eyes.

As she got them down to her ankles, he said, “Hang them on my cock.”

She struggled to comprehend, expressing befuddlement with a furrowed brow. But complied again, hoping she understood, looping a panty leg hole over his upright cock like it was a hook on the wall. The fabric dangled under his balls, hung on his cock.

“Sit back and open your legs.”

She whispered, “Okay,” again, and leaned her back on the headboard, eyes on Josh, wondering where his head was at, and parting her legs.

“Wider, Kimmy.”

And she did that, too. Parting her legs wider, exposing her pussy in full view to him.

“Like you want me to see it. Like you want me to fuck it.”

She shuddered a small tremor, not expecting such a harsh command from her husband. But turned on just the same and doing what he asked, humping her hips toward him like she needed his cock inside her. Which she did, she really did. “Like this?”

“That’s it. Now get it wet.”

Josh talking to her in this manner was almost offensive. But she would do anything he asked, anything to redeem herself in his perception. Tummy tucked in, hollowed, her hand went between her thighs and over her mound. She watched Josh’s eyes as Josh’s eyes watched her play with herself. She parted her petals, rubbed finger pads, pressed the base of her middle fingers over her hooded clit and rolled back and forth. Soon came a quiet wet clicking sound—proof she’d completed what he asked for. At the sound, Josh gripped his cock and stroked it. His grip included her panties, using the warm cotton fabric to rub his skin.

Fingers parting her labia, exposing her canal to her husband, she whispered, “It’s yours, Josh.”

Josh kept panty-stroking. Then, voice dry and stony, he said, “Is it?”

The chill of his question prickled her skin and tightened her heart. Something had happened. Something had changed. The urge to pretend he hadn’t challenged her on possession of her sex, to instead move on and encourage him further to make love to her, was strong, but not strong

enough to stabilize her emotions. She would break down if she spoke a word now. Her eyes swelled, her tongue thickened. The vision of Josh masturbating warbled through teary vision. She squeezed her eyes shut, felt a tear collect in her eyelashes. When she opened her eyes again, she encouraged Josh without using words, tilting back her head, narrowing her eyes and parting her lips. Even through the hurt in her heart, her pussy clicked with increasing excitement.

“Turn around,” he said. “Get on your hands and knees.”

Her hand left from between her legs, and she sat unmoving for a long moment and when nothing changed, she rolled to her side and did what Josh asked her. She got on her knees and her elbows, hugging a pillow under her chin.

Josh’s hands caressed her ass and her waist. His touch wasn’t angry. It was caring and loving, and she wanted to relax, wanted to chase away the notion that something had changed, that the tender rapprochement she’d clawed Josh back to hadn’t been sullied. But dread still gripped her.

When the head of Josh’s cock pressed into her wetness, she sighed his name. A real and honest expression, not a charade, not some sort of act meant to convince him. An honest sound created from their first physical union in weeks. Josh’s penis wasn’t enormous, wasn’t a thick, veiny monster, but it wasn’t plastic or rubber or silicon. It was flesh and blood and real and loving and meant for her. It felt incredible. One hand left the clutch on the pillow and reached back, her finger pads seeking her husband’s thigh, finding it and caressing it as he began to stroke his hardness in and out of her, getting it coated with her lubrication. She wanted to blubber all sorts of testaments of her undying love for him, but knew those would sound false at this moment, even if she meant them. She bit her tongue and focused on the combination of their two bodies and the intimate—though impersonal—connection.

“Such a beautiful back,” Josh said, his hands now moving up from where he held her waist and smoothing over her shoulder blades and up and down her spine. “You are an incredible thing.”

She bit her lower lip and moaned, her hips swaying while he fucked her slow and gentle.

“Devlin doesn’t deserve this.”

She stiffened, and ceased her hip swaying. Her heart raced and her mind darted for a reasonable meaning to his statement. And a reasonable response. Moving away from him and lashing out. Isn’t that what an innocent wife would do? Josh didn’t think she was innocent—but he didn’t know how guilty she was.

She said, “No,” with a quiet, noncommittal tone. Neither confirm nor deny. But what was at stake here right now wasn’t winning or losing. It was bigger than that, the stakes amounting to everything in her life that mattered. The urge to lie left her alone on the street corner in a dangerous part of town. She felt scared and helpless and the only thing that could soothe her was submission and devotion.

“But he saw this,” Josh said in a menacing whisper.

She couldn’t say no. Couldn’t bear to construct Josh’s false world any further. Josh wanted the hurt. She wanted the preservation.

“I’m yours,” she said.

Josh said nothing in return, stroking his fingertips along her naked back, fucking her slow and steady. It was dirty talk. Only dirty talk.

“What a sight,” he said to himself. “Devlin saw you like this.”

She whimpered and bit a mouthful of the pillow. She let go of Josh’s thigh and clutched the pillow with both arms.

“He fucked you like I’m fucking you, and you wanted it because he’s rich and handsome and hung.”

She spat out the pillow, playing games of dirty language with him like she would have before he found her panties in Devlin’s couch. “I’m such a

slut,” she said, pure porno trash talk, some cutesy bromide used to get a man off.

Josh curled his chest over her back, his cock almost slipping right out of her. He traced the hair from her cheek and ear and whispered, “You’re no slut, Kimmy. You know it and I know it.”

“Don’t stop,” she whispered, trying to distract him from words that were beginning to sound acute and accusing, waggling her bottom against his hips like a needy little slut would.

He held the back of her neck again and thumbed the ridge of her cheekbone. “I thought it was me. I thought I was the dark one.”

“Yeah?”

“But it’s you. It was you the whole time.”

“No,” she said in tiny, soft protest.

“You’re so dark.”

“We’re just playing, Josh,” she reminded him.

“When he fucked you like this, I bet he got so deep inside you.”

She whimpered again, then whispered, “Yes,” hoping if she encouraged filth into his mind, he would orgasm and he would quit this awful dialog.

More serious: “He fucked you deep?”

“Uh-huh,” she squeaked, shutting her eyes tight.

Josh groaned with pain and pleasure, his right hand sweeping underneath her and running over her tummy, his ring finger dipping into the shallow of her navel. Then two fingers pressed on a point above her navel and she imagined Josh picturing how deep Devlin’s huge penis would sink inside her.

She whispered, “So fucking deep,” pushing her hips back against him, moaning with awful pleasure at the feel of her husband’s shallow and insistent penetration. Josh’s manhood was quivering steel now. As hard and inhuman as the thing she’d masturbated with on Devlin’s bed.

Josh grabbed her hips and fucked her fast and hard. She took it, listening to his breath coming faster and faster, getting shaky and hoarse, hammering his hips into her bottom with a rapid-fire beat.

“Deep, Josh,” she said, “oh, he fucked me so deep, baby,” her voice jouncing with her husband’s hungry thrusting. And it sent Josh over, her husband grunting, growling, whimpering as if in pain, but orgasming huge, his cock flexing inside her as he filled her insides with his seed. The enormous wet turned her on like crazy and now she was whispering things for her own sake. “Oh, that’s it, oh, come inside me, Josh, come inside me, don’t pull out.”

Josh collapsed on her back, a quivering, trembling weight. He rolled away like he didn’t want to crush her, panting for breath. She rolled her head from the pillow and Josh was quick to grab her cheeks and kiss her, like he wanted to reconcile after the terrible things he’d said. And the terrible things she’d said.

It was only the heat of the moment. It was only Josh’s dirty passions. She grabbed his face, too, kissed him harder in return, scooting close so their naked bodies would connect as much skin as they could. His seed seeped from her, rolling through her seams and down one thigh.

Josh eased away, covered his mouth with one hand, looking like a man witnessing a horror, and she stayed with him, closing an arm over his neck and kissing his forehead. She held him that way for long, loving minutes. Both their breaths reduced to normal and their fast-beating hearts slowed enough the room seemed quiet and still again around them. She hugged his head and kissed his hair.

When at last he angled his face so their eyes met, she said, “Was that dirty talk?”

Josh looked away. “You tell me.”

Her heart sank, and she held his head tighter. Josh didn’t retreat. He enjoyed her embrace.

Eyes across the room, she said, “Did you go to Meyer’s tonight?”

His head shifted, and he sighed, reaching down to grab a corner of the bedding and cover their upper bodies. He said, “Do you think I would lie to you?”

She let his head go and returned to her pillow and they looked at each other, both of them on their sides, naked, with a flimsy delta of covering over their torsos. Their eyes darted over one another, white spots glimmering in Josh’s, the reflected moon behind her shining in the apartment window.

He said, “Do you enjoy humiliating me?”

It shocked her and her mouth fell open, her heart wounded. “Josh,” she said, furrowing her brows in sternness, “No.”

He stared and thought. Then: “Did it... Did it turn you on when you did?”

Her mouth worked open and closed and a thousand answers stuck on her tongue. She closed her mouth, her features crumpling, shame blooming larger and larger, too much to bear. The ability to lie and spin golden stories thinned to watery nothing, and she bit her lower lip hard, her breath beginning to shake and turn to snuffles. She closed her eyes and nodded, and Josh put his arm over her shoulders and pulled her close.

AFTERWORD

The eleventh book in the Devil In The Waters series will begin soon on my Patreon and on my Ream and will be available in the stores right after the last chapter has been posted.

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

ktmorrison.com

On my Patreon and on my Ream you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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